

123 LET'S LEARN ENGLISH UNDER THE PALM TREE

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STORY 1: The Road to Al-Qurawashiyah

In the winter of 1973, the sky in Britain looked like a gray blanket pulled tight over the rooftops. Mr. John sat at a small wooden table with a cup of tea that had already gone cold. A letter lay open in front of him, the paper crisp, the words bold, the meaning enormous.

Sophia walked in, pushing her glasses up with the back of her hand. She had been organizing books and notebooks into neat piles, as if neat piles could calm a big decision.

John cleared his throat. “Sophia.”

She stopped. “You sound serious.”

He lifted the letter carefully, like it might fly away. “I got the job.”

Sophia’s face softened, then tightened again in the same second. “Where?”

John smiled, but it was the kind of smile that comes with nervous excitement. “Oman.”

Sophia blinked. “Oman... as in, the Middle East?”

“Yes.” John tapped the letter. “They want English teachers. They are opening schools, building roads, starting something new. And they asked for me.”

Sophia sat slowly. “I don’t know anything about Oman.”

“I know only a little,” John admitted. “But I know this: it’s a chance. A real chance.”

Sophia looked at the letter again. Then she looked at John’s face, searching for certainty. “And you want to go.”

John answered honestly. “I’m afraid... but yes. I want to go.”

Sophia took a long breath. “Then we go together.”

John’s shoulders dropped, as if he had been holding a heavy bag for hours. “Together,” he repeated, and the word sounded like a promise.

Weeks later, their plane descended into Oman. Sophia pressed her forehead gently to the window, staring at the land below. She expected endless sand, but the view surprised her. There were mountains like giant sleeping shapes, and stretches of land that looked quiet and untouched.

When the airplane door opened, warm air rushed in, carrying a smell Sophia couldn’t name. It wasn’t smoke, and it wasn’t perfume. It felt... ancient.

Sophia whispered, “It’s warm.”

John wiped his forehead and forced a cheerful voice. "Welcome to Oman."

The airport was simpler than the ones they knew. No glowing screens everywhere, no loud announcements repeating every minute. People moved calmly, as if time walked at a slower pace here.

Sophia clutched her handbag. "John... what if we get lost?"

John pointed at a sign and read it carefully. "Exit. Taxi." Then he looked at her with a teacher's confidence. "We can do this step by step."

While they waited for luggage, John practiced quietly, like a student preparing for a test. "Hello. Good morning. Nice to meet you."

Sophia watched him and laughed under her breath. "You're rehearsing greetings."

John nodded seriously. "First impressions matter."

Then a clear voice called, "Mr. John?"

They turned. A woman stood a few steps away, wearing a hijab and traditional clothes that looked elegant and practical at the same time. Her posture was straight, her eyes kind, and her smile made the airport feel less foreign.

"I am Thuraya," she said, speaking English with confidence. "Welcome to Oman."

John stepped forward and offered his hand. "Hello! I'm John. This is my wife, Sophia."

Sophia smiled politely. "Nice to meet you."

Thuraya nodded. "Nice to meet you too. Do you need help with the bags?"

John glanced at the mountain of luggage like it was an impossible math problem. "Yes, please."

Thuraya's smile turned playful. "First lesson in Oman: carry less."

Sophia giggled. Even John laughed. It was the first time since landing that Sophia felt her chest loosen.

Outside, a car waited. Not a shiny new one, but a sturdy station wagon that looked like it could survive anything. Thuraya opened the door for them. "We will go to Samail," she explained. "Your apartment is in Al-Qurawashiyah. The school is in Samail."

John repeated carefully. "Sa-mail. Al-Qurawashiyah."

Sophia leaned toward Thuraya. "Is it hard to live there?"

Thuraya considered her answer. “It is simple. But people are... very warm.”

As the car moved, John tried to follow the paper map Thuraya gave him. The road stretched between mountains and open land. Small villages appeared like quiet paintings: clay houses, stone walls, goats, and children running barefoot, laughing as if the world had never taught them worry.

Sophia pointed. “Look... banana trees?”

Thuraya nodded. “Yes. And other trees too. But you will see more palm trees later when we move deeper.”

John kept practicing directions like a classroom drill. “Go straight. Turn left.”

Sophia teased him. “You will teach the road English next.”

Before John could reply, a small sound rose from the back seat.

“Maa-aa!”

Sophia turned. A tiny goat, no bigger than a school bag, stared at them with bright eyes as if he owned the car.

Sophia gasped. “Thuraya... is that... a goat?”

Thuraya answered like it was completely normal. “Yes. His name is Malood.”

John nearly dropped the map. “A goat is in the car?”

Malood bleated again, then tried to climb onto the seat, stepping confidently over Sophia’s skirt like a little commander.

Sophia burst into laughter. “He’s adorable!”

John looked horrified. “He is... unpredictable.”

Thuraya chuckled. “He is part of the village life.”

Malood suddenly jumped forward, trying to taste the edge of John’s paper map.

John yelped. “No! Not the map!”

Sophia covered her mouth, laughing harder. “Your first classroom in Oman is the car.”

When they finally reached Al-Qurawashiyah, the afternoon light was golden and soft. The apartment was modest: a fan, a few simple chairs, a woven mat. The quiet felt strange, like the air itself was resting.

Sophia sat on the mat and looked around. "It's simple... but peaceful."

John walked to the window. Outside, he saw girls playing *letj* (a traditional game), and boys racing each other between houses. He also noticed water in the distance, running gently through a channel. Nearby, women washed clothes, talking quickly, laughing, calling to one another like a chorus.

Sophia leaned beside him and lowered her voice. "They wash clothes there?"

John nodded slowly. "And... are children swimming?"

Sophia made a face. "That water doesn't look clean."

Thuraya heard them and spoke gently. "In the village, water is life. People use it for many things. You will understand more with time."

Sophia didn't argue. She only nodded, trying to store the moment in her memory.

Then Malood escaped.

He shot out of the apartment door like a tiny rocket, bleating happily.

Sophia sprang up. "Malood! Come back!"

A group of children appeared instantly, drawn by the chaos like birds to crumbs. They spoke to each other in fast Omani dialect, pointing, laughing, and chasing Malood as if this was the best game of the day.

One small boy ran past John, barefoot and dusty, his eyes bright. He looked at John and said one English word proudly, the only one he trusted.

"Hello!"

John blinked, surprised. Then he smiled warmly and answered clearly, like a teacher and a friend. "Hello."

The boy's face lit up as if John had given him a treasure. He ran away shouting something in dialect, and the other children giggled.

From a little farther away, behind a wall, someone watched. A boy. Quiet. Not laughing, not chasing. Just observing. His eyes moved from John to Sophia to Thuraya, and then to the children saying "Hello."

Thuraya noticed him too. Her face didn't change, but her voice softened, almost like she was speaking to the future.

"Many children here are curious," she said quietly. "Some will come soon. Some will watch first."

John followed her gaze but the boy had already stepped back into the shadow.

Sophia wrapped her shawl around her shoulders and looked at the village again. She felt strange and awake at the same time, like she had stepped into a world that would change her.

John inhaled slowly and said the sentence as if he was making a pact with the place.

"This is our beginning."

Thuraya nodded. "Yes. And tomorrow... we start teaching."

Behind them, Malood bleated triumphantly as the children finally caught him, and the village laughter rose into the evening air, welcoming them the way villages do: loudly, simply, and forever.

STORY 2: The First Walk in the Village

Narrative Story

The sun was already leaning toward the mountains when John, Sophia, and Thuraya decided to take a short walk around Al-Qurawashiyah. The village did not sleep early, but it also did not rush. Everything moved in its own quiet rhythm.

“We won’t go far,” Thuraya said as she adjusted her bag. “Just a small walk. You should see the place while there is still light.”

Sophia tied her shawl more tightly around her shoulders and looked at the road in front of them. It was not really a road, more like a dusty path that knew where to go without signs.

“Everything feels very... open,” Sophia said. “And very quiet.”

John smiled. “It’s like the village is breathing slowly.”

They walked between clay houses that looked like they were part of the earth itself. Some doors were open, some closed. Children ran in small groups, their laughter echoing between the walls.

Suddenly, a group of girls ran past them, throwing something small into the air and jumping to catch it.

Thuraya smiled. “They are playing *letj*.”

Sophia stopped. “Letj?”

“It’s a game,” Thuraya explained. “Very old.”

Sophia watched them with interest. “They don’t need toys.”

“They make their own,” Thuraya replied.

A little farther, they heard voices and splashing sounds. John followed the sound and stopped near the edge of a falaj. Clear water ran gently through the channel, shining in the evening light.

Women were sitting near the water, washing clothes, talking, laughing, sometimes calling to children who were swimming and playing inside the falaj.

Sophia froze.

“They are... washing clothes here?” she whispered.

“And the children are inside the water,” John added slowly.

Sophia leaned closer to John and spoke in a low voice, as if the falaj could hear her. “John... they are swimming where people wash clothes.”

John tried to sound calm. “It’s... village life.”

One of the women looked up, noticed them, and smiled kindly. She said something in Omani Arabic that Sophia and John did not understand. Another woman laughed and said something else.

Thuraya translated with a small smile. “They are saying: ‘Ahlan, welcome. The poor woman doesn’t know Arabic.’ And they are asking... who is your husband.”

Sophia’s eyes widened. “They are talking about us?”

“Yes,” Thuraya said gently. “But in a friendly way.”

Sophia gave an awkward little wave. The women waved back, still smiling and talking.

John, feeling the heat and dust, bent down and washed his face with water from the falaj. The water was cold and refreshing.

Sophia gasped. “John!”

He looked up. “What?”

“You just washed your face in that!”

John blinked. “Yes?”

Sophia looked horrified. “People wash clothes there!”

Thuraya laughed. “And people wash many other things too.”

Sophia made a face. “I don’t think I will try that.”

As they continued walking, the path slowly changed into a slightly wider road. Thuraya pointed ahead. “That is the small market area. Not big. But important.”

They soon saw a tiny shop, no bigger than a large room. Its door was open, and inside, shelves were filled with simple things: biscuits, small bottles, boxes, and colorful packets.

A man stood behind the counter. He had dark skin and sharp eyes and looked like he knew every child in the village.

“That is Sadoo,” Thuraya said. “He owns the shop.”

Before they could even step inside, children appeared from everywhere, as if the shop was a magnet.

“Sadoooo!” one boy shouted.

“Sadoooo, ana baghi boba jamid!” another cried.

“Sadoooo, ana baghi alook!”

“Sadoooo, ana baghi batatis Oman!”

Sophia stood near the door, completely confused. “They are... singing?”

John listened carefully. “They are asking for things.”

A small boy, barefoot and dusty, came to the counter and said very seriously, “Sadoo, ana baghi mino dajaj wa daghoos.”

John looked at Thuraya. “He wants... what?”

Thuraya tried not to laugh. “He wants corn snacks... chicken flavor... and spicy.”

Sophia leaned closer. “Children eat spicy food?”

Thuraya nodded. “Yes. They start early.”

Sophia looked at John. “Our children would cry.”

Inside the shop, Sadoo moved like a king in his kingdom. He gave this, took money from that, shouted at one child, laughed with another.

Sophia picked up a colorful packet and read the English letters slowly. “Bo... ba?”

“Boba,” Thuraya said. “A drink.”

Sophia shook the bottle. “It’s... gas?”

“Yes.”

Sophia whispered, “Children drink this?”

Before Thuraya could answer, a boy ran out with a bottle, opened it, and drank it in three big gulps.

Sophia looked at John. “This village will kill me.”

John tried to stay serious, but he was smiling.

Then something small and fast ran between their legs.

“Malood!” Sophia cried.

The little goat had escaped again and was now inside Sadoo’s shop, trying to smell everything.

“Yalla! Malood! Barraa!” the children shouted.

Malood jumped onto a low box, then onto another, and finally ran outside, followed by half the village.

Sophia laughed so hard she had to hold the door.

From across the road, a boy stood watching. He did not laugh. He did not run. He only watched. Quietly. Carefully.

Thuraya noticed him again.

“Who is that boy?” John asked.

Thuraya’s voice became softer. “That is Saeed.”

“Why doesn’t he come closer?” Sophia asked.

“He is... not allowed to go to school,” Thuraya said simply.

Sophia frowned but said nothing.

They continued walking. The road became more open, and soon they saw trees.

“Look!” Sophia said. “Fruit trees!”

“Those are *frsadh* and *lamba*,” Thuraya explained.

At that moment, a group of boys picked up stones and threw them at the trees.

Sophia gasped. “They are attacking the trees!”

Thuraya laughed. “They are *nahsher*. They throw stones so the fruits fall.”

Fruits fell. Children ran and collected them, laughing and eating.

John watched carefully and repeated the word like a student. “Nah... sher.”

Sophia smiled. “You are learning fast.”

John nodded seriously. “Let’s go and... nahsher.”

Thuraya burst out laughing. “Maybe another day.”

They watched the children eat mango with salt and chili.

Sophia blinked. “They put... salt and pepper... on mango?”

John tried a small piece and stopped. Then he smiled slowly. “It’s... strange. But good.”

As the sky started to turn orange, they went back to the apartment.

Behind them, Saeed still watched. Still silent. Still thinking.

That night, Sophia sat on the mat and said, “John... I think we didn’t move to another country.”

John looked at her. “Where did we move?”

She smiled. “We moved to another world.”

And somewhere in the village, Malood bleated, Sadoo closed his shop, children went home, and Saeed dreamed quietly of a place called school.

STORY 4: Malood and the Day of Great Disaster

Setting: القرواشية – بيت طين بسيط – السبعينات

Target Language: Simple commands, “Don’t!”, “Stop!”, “Where is...?”, “My... is gone!”

Narrative Story

That morning started like a good morning.

Which, of course, meant it was lying.

Sophia woke up early because she heard a strange sound.

Not a normal sound.

Not a bird.

Not the wind.

Not even a goat.

It was... chewing.

Very strong chewing.

She sat up in bed slowly.

John was still sleeping.

The sound came again.

Chrrrkkk... chrrrkkk...

Sophia whispered, “John?”

John turned and said half asleep, “Good morning... tea...”

Sophia frowned. “John. There is something eating our house.”

John opened one eye. “If it is not a lion, I will sleep.”

The chewing sound became louder.

Sophia jumped out of bed.

“JOHN!”

He sat up.

They both looked at the small table near the wall.

On the table were John’s notebooks.

And on the notebooks was **Malood**.

The small goat.

Very happy.

Very busy.

Very destructive.

Malood was chewing the corner of a notebook like it was the best breakfast in Oman.

Sophia screamed, “NO! NO! NO! That is PAPER!”

Malood looked at her.

Chewed.

Looked again.

And continued.

John jumped out of bed. “Malood! Stop!”

Malood did not stop.

John ran and tried to take the notebook.

Malood ran.

The notebook tore.

Half in John’s hand.

Half in Malood’s mouth.

John stared at the paper in his hand.

Then at Malood.

Then at Sophia.

“These were my lesson plans.”

Sophia put her hands on her face. “We are going to die in this village.”

They ran outside.

Malood ran faster.

He disappeared behind the wall.

John shouted, “Come back! You are not a sheep! You are a criminal!”

They were still in shock when Sophia suddenly froze.

She looked at her hand.

Then at the ground.

Then at the table.

Then at John.

Her voice became very small.

“John...”

“Yes?”

“My ring.”

John smiled. “Yes?”

“My ring is not on my hand.”

The world stopped.

John blinked. “What do you mean... not on your hand?”

Sophia whispered, “It is gone.”

They both looked at the ground.

At the bed.

At the table.

At the door.

At each other.

Then Sophia said the sentence that changes history:

“Malood was here.”

John went white.

They ran to find Thuraya.

Thuraya was in her house, calm, drinking tea.

Sophia shouted, “MALOOD ATE MY RING!”

Thuraya almost choked.

“What?”

“And he destroyed John’s notebooks!”

“And he ran away!”

Thuraya stood up slowly. “Okay. First... breathe.”

Sophia did not breathe.

John did not breathe.

Thuraya said, “We will find him.”

They went into the village.

People were outside.

Children were shouting.

A woman was screaming.

“THE GOAT! THE GOAT!”

Thuraya turned pale.

They ran.

They arrived at a neighbor’s house.

The door was open.

A man was shouting.

“Who owns this goat?!”

Malood was inside.

In the middle of the house.

Eating something.

The man pointed. “He took my food! And my clothes! And he broke my basket!”

Sophia whispered, “I want to die.”

John whispered, “If he eats my passport, I will kill him.”

Malood saw them.

He ran.

Again.

They chased him.

Like a crazy parade.

Children followed.

Women shouted.

Someone laughed.

Malood ran into their house.

Straight into the kitchen.

Straight to the big pot.

He jumped.

The pot fell.

Rice.

Meat.

Sauce.

On the floor.

Everywhere.

Silence.

Sophia sat on the ground.

John sat on the ground.

Thuraya closed her eyes.

Then Sophia screamed, "MY LUNCH!"

Malood looked at her.

And chewed.

Later.

Much later.

They caught Malood.

The ring was not found.

Thuraya said carefully, “He probably... swallowed it.”

Sophia fainted.

Not really.

But emotionally.

That evening, Sophia said quietly:

“I love Oman.”

John said, “We will never be bored.”

Thuraya said, “Welcome to village life.”

Malood slept.

Like a king.

End of Story 4 🐕🔥

STORY 5: The First Day at School

Setting: Samail, Al-Qurawashiyah – Early 1970s

Target Language: Greetings, Introducing yourself, “My name is...”, “I am...”, “Good morning”, “Nice to meet you”

The school was not a big building.

It was simple.

Very simple.

Two long classrooms made of mud bricks. A small yard in front. A wooden door that made a loud sound every time someone opened it. And inside, wooden desks, some old, some newer, all with scratches and names carved into them.

The blackboard was not very black.

And the chalk was not very white.

But for the children of Al-Qurawashiyah, this place was something new.

Something important.

That morning, the village was different.

Mothers walked with their children. Some boys ran. Some girls walked slowly, holding their books like treasures. Some children were excited. Some were scared. Some wanted to go home before they even arrived.

Inside the classroom, Ms. Thuraya stood near the board, arranging the chalk and cleaning the table with her hand.

She heard footsteps.

Then many footsteps.

Then noise.

A lot of noise.

She smiled.

“They are coming,” she said to herself.

John stood near the door, holding a book like a soldier holding a map.

Sophia stood next to him, her dress simple and long, her hair covered with a light scarf. The children of the village did not call her Sophia.

They called her:

Safiya.

Only John and Thuraya called her Sophia.

Sophia looked around and whispered, “I feel like I am about to meet one hundred small judges.”

John smiled. “They are not judges. They are students.”

“They look dangerous,” she replied.

The first children entered.

They did not walk quietly.

They did not sit quietly.

They came like birds.

Talking. Laughing. Pushing.

Ms. Thuraya clapped her hands once.

Not loud.

But strong.

“Sit down, please.”

Some sat.

Some didn’t.

Some sat, then stood again.

Then came a boy.

Small.

Thin.

Dusty.

With eyes full of ideas that no teacher likes.

Ms. Thuraya sighed softly.

“Mansoor,” she said.

Mansoor smiled.

The kind of smile that means trouble.

He sat.

On the wrong chair.

Then moved.

Then moved again.

Then turned around.

Then whispered.

Then laughed.

Then fell from the chair.

John watched everything like he was watching a film.

Sophia whispered, “That one will kill us.”

Thuraya nodded. “Yes. But slowly.”

More children entered.

A boy with very straight posture sat in the front.

His back was straight.

His book was straight.

His pencil was straight.

Thuraya smiled. “Ah... Ahmed.”

Ahmed nodded seriously.

Next to him sat Ali.

Ali looked at the board like it was the most interesting thing in the world.

His eyes were sharp.

His face calm.

Thuraya said quietly to John, “That one is very clever.”

Then came Khalil.

He smiled to everyone.

Sat.

Then stood.

Then helped someone.

Then whispered something.

Then laughed.

Thuraya knew this type very well.

Helpful.

But dangerous.

Then came the girls.

Noura entered and immediately said, “Where do I sit?”

Before anyone answered, she asked, “Is this my book? Is this my chair? Is today a long day?”

Sophia blinked. “She is fast.”

Then came Mathila.

She held many papers and pencils.

She went to other girls and gave them.

“Here. Take.”

Then Salima, Rahma, and Marwa came together, shy, quiet, sitting next to each other.

The classroom was now full.

Noisy.

Alive.

Ms. Thuraya went to the front.

“Good morning.”

The children answered in Arabic.

She smiled. “Today... we will learn something new.”

Mansoor raised his hand.

“Yes?” Thuraya said.

“Are they the new teachers?”

He pointed at John and Sophia.

“Yes,” Thuraya said.

Mansoor looked at them. “They look strange.”

The class laughed.

Sophia put her hand on her chest. “Thank you?”

John laughed.

Thuraya said, “This is Mr. John. And this is Ms. Safiya.”

Some children whispered: “Safiya...”

Sophia smiled.

John stepped forward.

He wrote on the board:

HELLO

He turned.

“Good morning.”

Silence.

The children stared.

He said it again. “Good morning.”

Thuraya said in Arabic, “Say: Good morning.”

Some said it.

Some said something else.

Mansoor shouted, “Good mourning!”

The class laughed.

John laughed too. “Close enough.”

Sophia wrote:

My name is...

She pointed to herself. “My name is Safiya.”

The children tried.

“My name is...”

“My name is...”

Mansoor said proudly, “My name is monster.”

Khalil laughed so hard he almost fell.

Sophia covered her mouth. “No, no, no. Mansoor. Not monster. Mansoor.”

Mansoor thought.

Then said, “My name is Mansoor.”

John clapped. “Very good!”

Then Ahmed said perfectly, “My name is Ahmed.”

Ali said, “My name is Ali.”

Mathila said, “My name is Mathila.”

Noura said, “My name is Noura. And this is my friend. And this is my book.”

Sophia laughed. “Very good. Very... detailed.”

The lesson continued.

“I am a student.”

“I am happy.”

“I am here.”

Some children said it right.

Some said it wrong.

Some shouted.

Some whispered.

Mansoor stood on his chair and said, “I am tall!”

He was not.

John tried to keep order.

Sophia tried to smile.

Thuraya tried to survive.

At the end of the day, the board was full.

The floor was full of chalk.

The air was full of voices.

And everyone was tired.

Very tired.

When the children left, John sat down.

Sophia sat next to him.

They looked at each other.

Then laughed.

Then laughed more.

Then Sophia said, “We are not ready.”

John said, “Yes we are.”

Thuraya smiled.

“This,” she said, “is only the beginning.”

End of Story 5

Story 6

The Market Day

The morning in Al-Qurwashiya was calm and fresh. The air smelled of wet earth after the falaj water passed through the small channels beside the houses. The mountains stood quietly in the distance, and the simple mud houses slowly woke up one by one.

John stood at the wooden door of their small mud house, fixing his watch and looking at the dusty road outside. The house was very simple: a few rooms, small windows, and a door that made a tired sound every time it moved.

Inside, Safiya (everyone in the village called Sofia “Safiya”) was packing a big cloth bag.

“John,” she said, “Thuraya said we must leave early.”

John smiled and looked at the bag.

“I still don’t understand why we need all these baskets and ropes.”

Before Safiya could answer, something small ran between their legs.

“Maaalooooood!” Safiya shouted. “Not again!”

The little baby goat stood in the middle of the room, looking very proud of himself.

John laughed and bent down.

“He really loves our house more than his own.”

From outside, they heard Azizah’s voice, his neighbor’s aunt:

“Malood! Come here, you little troublemaker!”

But Malood had already decided. Today was an adventure day.

Dukkan Al-Hillah

Thuraya told them they must stop first at **Dukkan Al-Hillah**, the small shop in Al-Qurwashiya, to buy some things.

The shop was tiny, with its door always open. In front of it were wooden boxes full of rice, sugar, and tea. On the wall, there were baskets and ropes. In one corner, dried fish (awal and qashie’) were hanging.

Sadoo, the shop owner, was standing behind the wooden counter, smiling his usual smile.

When he saw Malood enter before everyone else, he laughed.
“Malood! What do you want today?”

John pointed at some green leaves and said carefully,
“I... I want this.”

Sadoo laughed and looked at Thuraya.
“Tell him this is called qit.”

John tried to repeat it.
“Qit.”

Thuraya corrected him, smiling.
“Qit. Not ‘kit’. Qit.”

Sadoo wrapped the green leaves and tied them with a string.
Safiya was looking at the dried fish with a strange face.

“How do people eat this?” she asked.

Thuraya smiled.
“Wait. You will like it later.”

John paid and gave the qit to Malood. The little goat started walking behind them proudly, like he bought it himself.

The Pickup Car

At the end of the road, Uncle Nasser’s pickup car was waiting.

It was old. The color was tired. And even when it was not moving, it sounded loud.

The students were already there: Ali, Ahmed, Khalil, Noura, Marwa, Rahma, Salima, Mathla, and Mansoor.

Mansoor was the smallest, and he could not stand still for one minute.

Uncle Nasser held his bamboo stick and said,
“Today, who makes trouble will meet this.”

John and Safiya climbed into the back of the car and held the metal sides tightly.

Safiya whispered,
“John... I don’t think this is safe.”

John smiled, trying not to fall.
“Adventure.”

The car started moving. Dust went everywhere. The children laughed. Thuraya turned back and laughed at John and Safiya.

Samail Market

Samail market was another world.

People. Voices. Animals. Goods. Smells of everything.

Thuraya gathered the students and said,
“Today we will learn one sentence: **I want...**”

John wrote it on a paper and showed it.

Ali was the first. He went to the shop and said slowly,
“I want this.”

The shopkeeper gave him the item and smiled.

Mansoor tried next and said very fast,
“I want this this this!”

Everyone laughed.

Safiya was walking and looking around in surprise.
“People sell everything here.”

John stopped at a dried fish seller and bought a big awal. He held it and said,
“It smells very strong.”

Thuraya laughed.
“You will get used to it.”

Habbabouh Saif

Suddenly, they heard a man speaking **perfect English**.

They turned and saw an old man with a white beard and kind eyes.

“Good morning! You must be the new teachers.”

John and Safiya were shocked.

“You speak English!” Safiya said.

The old man smiled proudly.

“My name is Saif. People call me Habbabouh Saif. I worked with the Omani fleet and lived in Zanzibar many years.”

They talked for a long time. John and Safiya were very happy. Thuraya watched them and smiled.

A Full Day

On the way back, they saw children throwing stones at sidr and mango trees.

John heard one boy shout,
“Let’s nahshir the mango!”

At home, he said happily,
“Tomorrow, let’s go and nahshir!”

Thuraya and Safiya laughed and did not explain.

The day ended with tired feet, dusty clothes, and many stories.

Malood fell asleep before everyone.

And Safiya wrote in her notebook:

Today, we didn’t only go to the market. We learned a whole new world.”

Story 7

The Falaj Day

The morning sun in Al-Qurwashiya was soft and kind. The mountains were quiet, and the air smelled of wet earth and palm leaves. The falaj water moved slowly between the houses, making a gentle, never-ending sound.

Safiya stood at the door of the small mud house, holding a cup of tea and looking outside.

“John,” she said, “I think this place wakes up before people do.”

John smiled and walked next to her.

“And I think Malood wakes up before everyone.”

As if he heard his name, Malood ran past them and almost pushed the door open with his head.

“Malood!” Safiya shouted. “Where are you going now?”

Malood did not answer. He never did.

A Strange Morning Scene

They walked slowly through the village with Thuraya. The small paths were still wet, and some women were already working near the falaj.

Safiya stopped suddenly.

“Oh... John.”

John looked.

Women were washing clothes in the falaj. Children were swimming and playing in the same water.

Safiya opened her eyes wide.

“This is... impossible.”

John tried to be polite.

“This is... very... different.”

A small boy jumped into the water and splashed everyone.

Safiya moved back quickly.

“This is not clean!”

Thuraya laughed.

“It is clean enough.”

From far away, they heard women talking.

“اهلين... مي مو حالش؟”

“واحليها... ما تعرف تتكلم عربي”

“من ذا زوجها؟”

Safiya looked at John and whispered,

“They are talking about us, aren’t they?”

John nodded slowly.

“I think so.”

The Face-Washing Disaster

John walked closer to the falaj and bent down.

Safiya shouted,

“John! Don’t!”

Too late.

John washed his face.

A boy laughed and said something fast in Omani Arabic. Another boy laughed more.

Safiya looked at John in horror.

“You are going to get sick.”

John smiled and said,

“I feel... fresh.”

Thuraya laughed so much she had to sit on a stone.

The Children

A group of children were playing nearby.

Ali was sitting and watching everything carefully.

Ahmed was standing straight, like a ruler.

Khalil was throwing small stones into the water.

Noura was asking too many questions.

Marwa, Rahma, and Salima were standing together and talking quietly.

And Mansoor... Mansoor was everywhere.

Mansoor ran in front of John and Safiya and said loudly,
“Who are you?”

Safiya smiled and said slowly,
“Hello.”

The children looked at each other.

Ali said,
“Hello.”

Thuraya smiled.
“Good. Say: Good morning.”

Ali tried.
“Good... morning.”

Mansoor shouted,
“Good morning!”

Khalil said it in a funny voice and everyone laughed.

The Lesson Under the Tree

They sat under a big tree near the falaj.

John drew a line in the dirt and wrote:

HELLO
GOOD MORNING

He pointed and said,
“Hello.”

The children repeated.

He pointed again.
“Good morning.”

They repeated.

Mansoor shouted it too loud.

Khalil said it too funny.

Ahmed said it perfectly.

Noura asked,
“Why we say good?”

John looked at Thuraya. Thuraya smiled.
“Good question.”

Malood Again

Suddenly, Malood appeared.

Nobody knew from where.

He jumped on John’s bag.

The children laughed.

Mansoor shouted,
“Your goat!”

Safiya shouted,
“He is not our goat!”

Malood took a paper in his mouth and ran.

Everyone ran after him.

The lesson was over.

The End of the Day

At sunset, Safiya wrote in her notebook:

“Today, I saw a river that is not a river.
I saw children who learn faster than they know.
And I saw a goat who does not belong to us... but lives with us.”

John read it and smiled.

“Tomorrow,” he said, “we teach again.”

Malood was already asleep.

Story 8

The Day Sophia Played Like a Child

The afternoon in Al-Qurwashiya was warm and quiet. The sun was high, and even the shadows looked tired. The small clay houses were sleeping under the heat, and only the sound of birds and faraway voices filled the air.

Sophia was standing in front of the simple house she shared with John, trying to clean a thin carpet.

“This dust is not normal,” she said, looking at her hands. “I am sure it follows me.”

John was sitting on a wooden box, fixing his shoe very seriously.

“This is not dust,” he said. “This is history.”

Sophia looked at him. “I am not wearing history.”

From far away, they heard loud laughing.

Then shouting.

Then more laughing.

Then someone screaming.

Then more laughing again.

Sophia looked at the road. “Something is happening.”

John stood up. “In this village, something is always happening.”

They walked a little and saw a group of girls playing in the open sandy area between the houses. The girls looked about thirteen to sixteen years old. Their dresses were simple and colorful, and their hair was tied in different ways. They were full of energy.

They were playing **Leteg**.

Two lines were drawn on the ground. One girl stood in the middle. The others were running, turning, and jumping, trying to cross the lines without being touched.

“Turn! Turn! Jump!” one of the girls shouted.

Another girl ran, jumped, almost fell, then laughed and ran away.

Sophia stopped and watched with wide eyes.

“This looks dangerous,” she said.

“No,” John said. “This looks educational.”

Thuraya appeared behind them, carrying a small basket.

“You found the girls,” she said, smiling.

“They are flying,” Sophia said.

“They are playing Leteg,” Thuraya said. “We all played this when we were young.”

One of the girls saw them and shouted, “Come! Come play!”

Sophia pointed at herself. “Me?”

“Yes, you!”

Sophia looked at Thuraya. “I think this is a bad idea.”

“It is a very good idea,” Thuraya said.

Sophia took off her shoes.

“This is a very bad decision,” she said.

The girls showed her where to stand.

“Now jump,” one of them said.

Sophia jumped.

Wrong.

Everyone shouted.

She jumped again.

Wrong again.

Everyone laughed.

“This game hates me,” Sophia said.

“No,” John said. “The game is honest.”

After many tries, Sophia finally crossed the line without touching it.

She raised her hands. “I did it!”

The girls clapped.

Then one of them said, “Now we play **Darwazat Mutrah!**”

They started running.

Someone fell.

Someone screamed.

Someone laughed.

Mansour appeared from nowhere and ran too.

“I am fast!” he shouted.

He fell after three seconds.

Sophia ran and hid behind a tree.

“I am not a teacher today,” she said. “I am a tree.”

Everyone laughed again.

After a while, they all sat on the ground, tired and happy.

Sophia looked at her dress.

It was dirty.

Very dirty.

“I am not a tree,” she said. “I am a very dirty tree.”

One of the girls said, “You must wash.”

“Where?” Sophia asked.

“In the falaj.”

Sophia's eyes shone. "Nice! I want to swim!"

All the girls shouted, "NOOOOO!"

Thuraya laughed. "Not like that. Women go to the **majaza**."

They took Sophia to the majaza. It was a small room built over the falaj. The roof was open, and the water passed inside the room.

Inside, the women helped Sophia wash.

They used **sidr** and **sandal**.

They put **kohl** on her eyes.

Sophia looked in a small mirror.

"Do I look beautiful?" she asked.

The women smiled in a strange way.

Outside, John was waiting.

Then suddenly...

"AAAAAA!"

John started running and jumping.

He fell.

He stood.

He ran again.

A **bee** had gone into a small nest near him and stung him.

"My leg! My leg!" he shouted.

Thuraya ran to him. "A bee! You need the hospital!"

"I am fine!" he said. "I think."

Then Sophia came out.

John stopped.

Thuraya stopped.

Everyone stopped.

The kohl had melted on Sophia's face because of the heat.

She looked like a very angry ghost.

Or a very tired monster.

John looked at her.

Then he laughed.

Then he fell on the ground laughing.

Thuraya looked at Sophia.

Then she laughed too.

Sophia touched her face. "What?"

They showed her.

She screamed.

"I am going back to wash! I wash my face! I wash my hands! I wash everything!"

Later, when they were walking back, they passed the falaj again.

A small boy was swimming.

John said, "He swims in the falaj."

Sophia said, "I wash my hands in the falaj. I do not swim."

Suddenly...

Malood the baby goat ran into their house.

Again.

John shouted, "WHY does this goat love our house?!"

Malood ate a paper.

Sophia ran after him.

“This village,” she said, “is not normal.”

That night, John said, “Today we learned new words.”

Sophia said, “Yes. Wash. Swim. Hospital. Bee.”

John touched his leg. “And pain.”

Story 9: The Day Mr. John Came to School With “Puffy Eyes”

(Series: 1 2 3 Learning English Under the Palm Tree | Setting: Al-Qurawashiyah School, Samail
| Time: Early 1970s)

Mr. John walked into the classroom like a brave man... who had lost a fight with a very small enemy.

His shirt was neat. His hair was tidy. His smile tried its best.

But his eyes?

One eye looked normal. The other looked like it was wearing a tiny invisible pillow.

The students stared.

Then Mansoor, the smallest and loudest, stood up on his desk as if he was announcing a royal wedding.

“Teacher! Your eye is... BOOM!”

The class exploded.

Noura clapped her hands. “It’s true! It’s big!”

Khalil leaned forward with a serious face. “Maybe he cried all night.”

Mr. John blinked slowly, carefully, like blinking might make the swelling *change its mind*.

Ms. Thuraya walked in behind him, carrying chalk and a thick notebook. She saw the faces, the pointing fingers, and the *BOOM* hand gestures.

She tapped the board twice.

“Good morning, everyone.”

The students tried to behave. They failed for exactly two seconds.

Ms. Thuraya pointed at Mr. John’s face. “Class... what do we say?”

They remembered yesterday’s lesson. Some said it correctly. Some attacked it like a wild animal.

“Good morning, Mister Jhon!”

“Good morning, Teacher!”

“Good morning... and... sorry for your eye!”

Mr. John gave a small bow. “Good morning.”

Mansoor whispered to Ali, “He looks like he slept inside a beehive.”

Mr. John heard that word and frowned. “Beehive?”

Ms. Thuraya wrote two words on the board:

WASP

STING

She turned to the class. “Repeat after me.”

“Wasp,” the class said.

“Sting,” they said again, louder.

Mr. John pointed to his swollen eye. “Yesterday... a wasp stung me.”

Ms. Thuraya nodded. “Good. Past tense.”

She wrote:

Today: I feel pain.

Yesterday: I felt pain.

Today: My eye is swollen.

Yesterday: My eye was swollen.

Khalil raised his hand, pretending to be very polite. “Teacher, your eye **is** swollen or **was** swollen?”

Mr. John sighed. “It is swollen *and* it was swollen.”

The class laughed again.

Ms. Thuraya smiled, but her eyes warned them. “Okay. We practice past simple today. Everyone will tell a funny story.”

The students made excited sounds.

Ali sat straight like a ruler. Ahmed sat even straighter, like a ruler that wanted a promotion. Khalil looked ready to perform. Mansoor looked ready to destroy the world.

Ms. Thuraya pointed to Ahmed first.

“Ahmed. You start.”

Ahmed stood up slowly. He held his hands behind his back like a small serious man at a meeting.

He spoke carefully, using the English words he knew... and filling the gaps with Omani confidence.

“Yesterday,” he said, “I... um... I **went**... to the farm.”

Ms. Thuraya nodded. “Good. ‘Went’ is past.”

Ahmed continued. “I **played** with my cousins. I **ran**. I **climbed**. I **fell**.”

Khalil whispered, “He fell because he is too straight.”

Ahmed ignored him. “Then... I **got** pain in my stomach.”

Noura gasped. “Oh no!”

Ahmed lifted his chin, proud of the drama. “My grandmother said, ‘You eat too fast.’ My mother said, ‘You eat too much.’ My uncle said, ‘You need...’”

Ahmed paused. He looked at Ms. Thuraya, searching for the right word.

Ms. Thuraya already knew what was coming. She sighed once, quietly, the sigh of a teacher who loved culture but also loved peace.

Ahmed said it anyway.

“You need... **mijz**.”

The class made a sound like “Ooooooh!” as if he said a magic spell.

Mr. John leaned toward Ms. Thuraya. “What is... mijz?”

Ms. Thuraya’s smile became small and careful. “It is... an old treatment. Traditional.”

Ahmed lifted one finger like a lecturer. “They **heated** it.”

Mr. John’s eyebrows jumped. “They heated what?”

Ahmed’s eyes shone. “The mijz.”

Ms. Thuraya quickly wrote vocabulary on the board:

heat
burn
treat
hurt
cure (old belief)
traditional medicine

Ahmed continued, enjoying every second. “My uncle **made** fire. He **put** the mijz in the fire. It **became** red.”

Khalil whispered, “Like Mansoor’s face when he lies.”

Mansoor protested, “I don’t lie! I just... change the truth!”

Ahmed went on. “My grandmother said, ‘Be strong.’ I said, ‘I am strong.’”

He looked at the boys like a hero.

“I **sat**. I **closed** my eyes. I **said**... ‘Ready.’”

Mr. John slowly shook his head. “No, no, no...”

Ahmed acted the moment with sound effects.

“Then... *TSSSS!*”

The students shouted and laughed.

Ahmed held his stomach and leaned back like he was remembering pain.

“I **felt** like... I **became** a chicken.”

The class roared.

Ms. Thuraya tried not to laugh. She failed a little. “Ahmed. Use past verbs.”

Ahmed nodded. “I **screamed**.”

Noura clapped. “Good verb!”

Ahmed continued. “After that... my stomach **felt** better. My uncle said, ‘See? Good!’ My mother said, ‘Next time... eat slowly.’”

Mr. John raised his hand like a student. “Wait. This is real? You burned him?”

Ms. Thuraya spoke gently. “Many people used it in the past. They believed it helped. Now we have hospitals, doctors, medicine. But in the 1970s, villages used traditional ways.”

Mr. John touched his swollen eye. “I prefer... hospital.”

Mansoor jumped up. “Teacher! I went hospital one time!”

Ms. Thuraya pointed at him immediately. “Sit. One sentence only.”

Mansoor sat, but his mouth kept moving. “Okay okay... I **went** hospital... I **cried**... I **ran away**...”

“ONE sentence,” Ms. Thuraya repeated, sweet but dangerous.

Mansoor chose his sentence carefully. “I **cried**.”

The class laughed again.

Ms. Thuraya clapped once. “Now, we fix Ahmed’s grammar.”

She wrote on the board:

✓ **Yesterday, I went to the farm.**

✓ **My uncle heated the mijz.**

✓ **I felt pain.**

✓ **I screamed.**

✓ **After that, I felt better.**

Then she turned to Mr. John. “Your turn. One sentence about yesterday.”

Mr. John cleared his throat and looked at the class.

“Yesterday,” he said, “I **walked** near a tree. A wasp **stung** me. I **ran** like Mansoor.”

Mansoor whispered proudly, “See? I teach him.”

Ms. Thuraya laughed. “Good. Past verbs: walked, stung, ran.”

Noura raised her hand. “Teacher, can we say... ‘He **looked** scary?’”

Mr. John blinked. “I looked scary?”

Khalil nodded seriously. “Like a tired camel.”

The class burst again.

Mr. John tried to smile. His smile came out crooked. “Thank you.”

Then, just as the class calmed down, Khalil leaned forward and said, very casually, like he was sharing weather news:

“Teacher... last night we **saw** a ghoul.”

The room went quiet.

Even Mansoor stopped breathing for two seconds.

Mr. John froze. “A... what?”

Ms. Thuraya looked at Khalil. “Khalil... do you mean *snake*?”

Khalil nodded. “Yes. Ghoul.”

Mr. John’s face lost all color. His swollen eye looked even more worried.

“A snake?” he whispered. “In the village?”

Ali said, proud of his English, “Yes. It **came** near the water.”

Noura added, “It **moved** like this.” She waved her arm like a ribbon.

Mr. John took one step back without thinking, and bumped the blackboard.

Ms. Thuraya tried to sound normal. “Okay. New vocabulary.”

She wrote:

snake
afraid
dangerous
near
outside
inside

Mr. John swallowed. “Inside?”

Ms. Thuraya paused... and then, because she was Ms. Thuraya and she enjoyed tiny jokes, she said calmly:

“Sometimes... yes.”

The students watched Mr. John’s face as if it was a movie.

Mr. John spoke slowly. "So... yesterday I was stung. Today I am swollen. And tonight... I will be eaten."

Ms. Thuraya laughed. "Not eaten. Just... frightened."

The bell rang.

The students rushed out like little storms, shouting half-English, half-Omani excitement.

Mr. John stayed behind and looked at Ms. Thuraya like a man asking for the secret of survival.

"Ms. Thuraya," he said carefully, "in your village... do snakes... come inside houses?"

Ms. Thuraya lifted her chalk bag and smiled.

"Mr. John," she said, "you live near farms, falaj, trees... sometimes animals visit."

He nodded, weakly. "Animals. Yes."

She added, with a grin: "And sometimes... they don't knock."

That night, in their simple house, Mr. John lay on his bed staring at the ceiling.

Every small sound became a story.

A leaf moved outside. He imagined a snake wearing sandals.

A goat bleated far away. He imagined the snake answering.

Sophia, half asleep, murmured, "John... go to sleep."

Mr. John whispered, "The ghoul is waiting."

Sophia opened one eye. "The what?"

"The... snake."

Sophia sighed. "It's outside."

Mr. John whispered, "Outside becomes inside."

Sophia turned her pillow. "Goodnight."

Mr. John did not sleep.

He just listened... and promised himself one thing:

Tomorrow, he would teach past simple again.

Because if he survived the night, he deserved at least one correct sentence.

The End of Story 9. ✓

Story 10: The Man Everyone Was Afraid Of

The morning sun was already warm when Mr. John walked slowly toward the small school in Samail. He held his bag in one hand and rubbed his eyes with the other.

“Why does everything here wake up so early?” he said, half asleep.

Behind him, Sophia (or **Safiya**, as everyone in the village called her) was fixing her scarf and trying not to trip on the sandy road.

“This place is beautiful,” she said, smiling. “But my feet are not happy.”

Ms. Thuraya laughed. “Your feet will learn. Everything learns here.”

The school was a simple building. White walls. A wooden door. A blackboard. Chalk. No fans. No electricity. Just open windows and the sound of birds and goats outside.

When they arrived, the children were already there.

Ahmed was sitting straight like a ruler, holding his slate carefully.

Ali was drawing something instead of writing.

Khalil was whispering and laughing.

Noura was asking Salima a question.

Marwa and Rahma were sharing one pencil.

And Mansoor... Mansoor was standing on his chair.

“Sit down, Mansoor,” Thuraya said.

Mansoor sat down.

Five seconds later, he stood up again.

Mr. John clapped his hands.

“Good morning, everyone!”

“Good morning, teacher!” they said together.

“Today,” Mr. John said happily, “we will learn how to talk about people. We say: He is... She is... He has... She has...”

Before he could continue, the classroom door **slammed**.

BANG.

All the children jumped.

Khalil's eyes became big.
Mansoor hid behind Ahmed.
Noura whispered, "It's him..."

Sophia looked at Thuraya. "Who?"

Thuraya's face changed a little. "Stay calm," she said quietly.

Outside, heavy footsteps passed near the window.

THUMP.
THUMP.

A shadow appeared on the wall.

Ali said in a small voice, "The old man..."

Marwa whispered, "The magic man..."

Rahma said, "My mother says he is scary."

Mansoor said, "My father says he can talk to goats."

Mr. John blinked. "Talk to... goats?"

Khalil said, "Teacher... it is **Khalaf**."

"Who is Khalaf?" Sophia asked.

All the children spoke at the same time:

"He is scary!"
"He lives alone!"
"He has a big stick!"
"He walks at night!"
"He makes smoke!"
"He is a magician!"

Mr. John smiled. "There are no magicians. Only teachers."

Just then, something **fell** outside.

CRASH.

The children screamed.

“ABOOYAAAAAH!”

Some of them ran under the desks.

Sophia held Mr. John’s arm. “What was that?!”

Thuraya walked to the window and looked outside. Then she started to laugh.

“It’s just Khalaf,” she said.

“JUST?” Mr. John said.

She opened the door.

Outside stood an old man. Very thin. Very tall. Very quiet. He had a long white beard, old clothes, and a stick in his hand. Near his feet was a small bag of herbs and tools.

He looked at Thuraya. “Your goat is eating my plants again.”

Behind him, **Malood** the little baby goat was chewing something happily.

Sophia’s eyes became big. “Oh no. Not again.”

Thuraya said, “Sorry, Uncle Khalaf. We will keep him away.”

Khalaf looked at Mr. John and Sophia.

“You are the new teachers,” he said slowly.

“Yes,” Mr. John said. “I am John. This is my wife, Sophia.”

Khalaf looked at Sophia’s face for a long time.

“You look afraid,” he said.

Sophia laughed nervously. “No... just... surprised.”

He nodded and walked away.

The moment he disappeared, the children started talking again.

“See? He is strange!”

“He doesn’t smile!”

“He talks to himself!”

“My cousin says he makes medicine!”

“My brother says he makes smoke!”

Mr. John wrote on the board:

He is old.
He is thin.
He has a stick.
He walks slowly.

“Look,” he said. “We can describe him.”

Ahmed raised his hand. “Teacher. He is not a magician. He is just... quiet.”

Everyone looked at Ahmed.

Khalil said, “Are you sure?”

Ahmed nodded. “My grandfather knows him.”

Mansoor said, “But he is still scary.”

Sophia laughed. “Sometimes, people look scary. But they are not.”

That afternoon, Sophia could not find her ring.

“My ring!” she said. “It’s not here!”

They searched the house. The table. The bag. The bed. Nothing.

“Oh no,” Sophia said. “It’s gone.”

Outside, Khalil whispered to Ali, “Maybe Khalaf took it.”

Ali’s eyes became big. “The magician!”

Soon, all the children were talking.

“He took it!”
“He uses it for magic!”
“He will make smoke!”
“He will turn it into a frog!”

Mr. John sighed. “No one is turning anything into a frog.”

But even he was not very sure.

They walked together to Khalaf’s house. A small mud house near the farms.

Sophia held Thuraya's hand. "Why is my heart beating like this?"

Thuraya smiled. "Because stories are stronger than truth."

They knocked.

KNOCK. KNOCK.

The door opened slowly.

Khalaf looked at them. "Yes?"

Thuraya said, "Sorry to disturb you. Sophia lost her ring."

Khalaf looked at them for a moment. Then he went inside and came back.

He opened his hand.

Inside was the ring.

"It was near my plants," he said. "Your goat likes shiny things."

All of them looked at **Malood**.

Malood said nothing. He just kept chewing.

Sophia laughed. "Oh... Malood."

Khalaf gave her the ring.

"Next time," he said, "close your door."

Then he went back inside.

On the way home, the children were very quiet.

Finally, Mansoor said, "He is not a magician."

Khalil said, "He is just... an old man."

Ali said, "A kind old man."

That night, Mr. John wrote in his notebook:

“Today, we learned something important.
Not every scary story is true.
And not every quiet man is bad.”

He closed the notebook.

Then he heard a sound outside.

THUMP.
THUMP.

A shadow passed near the window.

Mr. John sat up in bed.

“Sophia...”

“Yes?”

“...you don’t think he really makes smoke, right?”

Sophia smiled in the dark.

“No. But if he does... please go and talk to him.”

Mr. John pulled the blanket up.

“I will talk to him... tomorrow.”

Story 11: The Hot Falaj and the Long Names

The sun was still soft when everyone started to gather near the small school in Samail. The pickup truck of Uncle Nasser was already there. It was old, noisy, and strong, and it looked like it had carried half the village many times before.

The children were excited.

Mansoor was jumping up and down.
Khalil was already planning trouble.
Ahmed was holding his bag carefully.
Noura was asking ten questions at the same time.
Marwa, Rahma, and Salima were sharing dates.
Ali was trying to climb into the truck first.

Sophia, or **Safiya** as everyone called her, was fixing her scarf and smiling.

“Are you sure this is safe?” she asked, looking at the back of the pickup.

Thuraya laughed. “Very safe. You just hold tight and don’t fly away.”

Mr. John looked at the truck with shining eyes. “Adventure!” he said. “I love adventure.”

Thuraya looked at him and smiled in a strange way. “Yes... you love it.”

Uncle Nasser clapped his hands. “Yalla! Everyone up!”

Soon, the children were sitting in the back of the pickup, holding the sides. John and Sophia were sitting with them, trying not to fall. Thuraya sat in front, next to Uncle Nasser.

“Where are we going?” Mansoor shouted.

“To **Al-Lajal**,” Thuraya said. “In Wadi Al-Maawil.”

“What is Al-Lajal?” Ali asked.

Thuraya turned and said proudly, “It is a village. And it is full of my family. The **Al-Naabi** tribe.”

“The tribe?” John asked. “What is a tribe?”

Thuraya smiled. “In Oman, people belong to tribes. Big families. Old families. We say: this is my tribe. This is my name. This is my history.”

The car started moving. Dust went up behind them. The road was long, brown, and full of stones.

“In Oman,” Thuraya continued, “we also have something called **tagheera**.”

Sophia looked at her. “Tagheera?”

“Yes,” Thuraya said. “It is like... a family symbol. A sign. Every tribe has one.”

She smiled. “For Al-Naabi, the tagheera is **fenzuz**.”

John tried to say it. “Fen... zoz?”

“Fenzuz,” Mansoor corrected him, very seriously.

Everyone laughed.

While the car was moving, Thuraya said, “Today, we will practice something very important.”

She wrote on a small paper and showed it:

My name is...

I am from...

I belong to...

Sophia clapped her hands. “Great! Let’s practice!”

She turned to Ahmed. “You first.”

Ahmed sat straight. “My name is Ahmed. I am from Samail. I belong to... my family.”

Thuraya smiled. “Good. Very good.”

Khalil said, “My name is Khalil. I am from here. I belong to... trouble.”

Everyone laughed.

Noura said, “My name is Noura. I am from Samail. I belong to my mother.”

Marwa said, “My name is Marwa. I am from the farms.”

Rahma said, “My name is Rahma. I belong to my grandmother.”

Mansoor shouted, “My name is Mansoor. I am from everywhere!”

John laughed. “Everywhere is a big place.”

Then Thuraya said, “My name is Thuraya. I am from Al-Lajal. I belong to **Al-Naabi**.”

John looked at her. “Thuraya... that is a beautiful name.”

She smiled. “My grandmother’s name was also Thuraya.”

Sophia looked surprised. “Really?”

“Yes,” Thuraya said. “My grandfather, Ali, was a teacher of fiqh. He taught in the mosque in Samail. That is why he stayed there. He married my grandmother. And her name was Thuraya.”

John’s eyes became big. “So... your name is the same as your grandmother.”

“Yes,” Thuraya said. “Names have stories here.”

The car moved between mountains and green places. Palm trees and farms appeared.

Suddenly, John pointed. “Is that the falaj?”

Thuraya looked at him. “Yes. Falaj Al-Lajal.”

John smiled. “Swimming!”

Thuraya looked at him again. That same strange smile.

“Don’t be too excited,” she said. “Not every falaj is... friendly.”

When they arrived, the place was beautiful. Green trees. Old houses. Water moving between stones.

The children ran.

“Wait!” Sophia shouted. “Careful!”

But John was already taking off his shoes.

“Cold water!” he said happily. “I am ready!”

Thuraya opened her mouth. “John—”

Too late.

John jumped.

“AAAAAAAAAAAA! WAFARIYA!”

He jumped out again like fire touched him.

“It’s HOT!” he shouted. “The water is HOT!”

The children fell on the ground laughing.

Mansoor said, “Teacher is cooked.”

Khalil said, “Falaj soup.”

Thuraya crossed her arms. “I told you not to be too excited.”

John looked at her. “You knew.”

“Yes,” she said. “Falaj Al-Lajal is warm.”

Sophia laughed and said to the children, “Okay, lesson time!”

She sat with them near the water.

“Now,” she said, “tell me about yourself.”

She pointed to Ali. “You.”

Ali said slowly, “My name is Ali. I am from Samail. I belong to my family.”

“Good!” Sophia said.

They practiced again and again.

Meanwhile, John was walking around, still angry at the falaj.

Then he saw something in the trees.

“Fenzuz,” he whispered.

He started collecting **fenzuz** quietly. One. Two. Three. Many.

He put them in his bag.

“I will surprise Thuraya,” he said to himself.

When he came back, he opened his bag and showed her.

“Look!”

Thuraya looked inside. Then she laughed. A lot.

“You collected my tagheera,” she said.

“Yes!” John said proudly.

She shook her head. “Only Al-Naabi can use it.”

John looked at the bag. “Oh.”

The children laughed again.

Later, they ate and rested.

On the way back, Uncle Nasser drove slowly. The sun was going down.

Mansoor said, “Teacher, will you swim again?”

John said quickly, “No.”

Sophia smiled. “But you learned something today.”

“Yes,” John said. “Always ask before you jump.”

Thuraya laughed. “And always listen to Omani teachers.”

That night, John wrote in his notebook:

“Today, I learned about names, tribes, and hot falaj.
And I learned that not all water is friendly.”

Then he added:

“Also, never trust Thuraya’s smile.”

Story 12: “The Day the Smoke Chased Us” (Smail, 1973)

The morning bell did not ring yet, but Smail already felt awake.

A pale sun climbed slowly behind the mountains, and the air smelled like dust, farms, and something warm being cooked far away. John stepped out of the simple house, holding a small notebook and squinting like a detective who forgot his glasses.

Sophia, everyone here called her “**Safiya**”, stood behind him at the doorway, tying her scarf neatly. She looked proud of it, like it was a new rule she learned perfectly on the first try.

Ms. Thuraya came walking from the neighbor’s path, her steps quick and confident. She carried a cloth bag and a piece of chalk tucked behind her ear.

“Good morning,” she said in English, smiling.

John grinned. “Good morning! Today is... Monday?”

Thuraya laughed. “In the seventies, you still need to learn the days, Mr. John.”

Sophia raised her iPad, then remembered... there was no signal, no internet, no “anything.” She sighed dramatically. “My iPad is just... a mirror now.”

Before anyone could answer, something small and white hopped into the yard like a sneaky cloud with legs.

It was **Malood**.

The baby goat marched straight to John’s bag, sniffed it seriously, then tried to bite the corner.

“Hey! No! That is my teaching bag!” John waved his hands like he was guiding airplanes.

Malood didn’t care. Malood *never* cared.

Thuraya bent down. “He belongs to Aunt Azizah next door. But he loves your house like it is his own.”

Sophia whispered, “He is... too confident.”

Then came a sound that made the village shift its attention, like everyone turned the page at the same time.

A loud engine.

A truck.

A voice calling from far away.

Thuraya's eyes narrowed. "Oh no. The municipality truck."

John blinked. "The what?"

Before she could explain, the pickup appeared at the end of the dusty road, moving slowly like a giant beetle. Two men sat in the back with a metal tank. A foggy cloud came out behind them, rolling through the street.

Sophia's eyebrows jumped. "Is that... smoke?"

Thuraya pulled her scarf a little tighter. "Pesticide. They spray it to kill insects. People used to do it a lot."

Malood made a tiny noise that sounded like a complaint, then coughed.

John stepped forward, concerned. "Is it safe?"

Thuraya opened her mouth, but she didn't get the chance.

Because children appeared.

A group of boys came running behind the truck, yelling and laughing, chasing the smoke like it was a game.

One of them was **Mansoor**. Of course it was Mansoor.

He ran like he was being chased by a lion, but his face was pure joy.

Thuraya shouted, "Mansoor! Stop!"

He didn't stop.

John jumped forward, suddenly serious, teacher-mode activated like a switch. He grabbed a thin stick from the fence and lifted it like a traffic sign.

"STOP!" he shouted in English. "GO INSIDE!"

The boys froze for half a second, then yelled back happily, not understanding but enjoying the drama.

One boy shouted something in Omani Arabic. Another laughed. Mansoor waved like John was part of the show.

"NOOO!" John shouted again, louder. "INSIDE! INSIDE!"

Sophia covered her mouth, laughing. “John, you look like a British police officer.”

John took one step toward the smoke... and slipped.

His shoe slid on a wet patch near the falaj channel. His arms went up. His notebook flew. Malood jumped away like, *Not my problem*.

John fell face-first into the dusty ground.

And then, the smoke rolled over him.

When the cloud passed, John stood up slowly.

He looked... terrifying.

His hair was full of dust. His face was gray. His eyes were wide and watery.

He looked like a ghost that lost a fight.

Sophia screamed, then laughed so hard she had to hold the wall.

Thuraya covered her mouth. “Oh my...”

The children screamed too, but not from fear of the smoke.

From fear of **John**.

“Abooooyaaah!” Mansoor yelled dramatically, and half the kids ran away as if the ghost was real.

John wiped his eyes and coughed. “I am... fine.”

Then a shadow moved at the edge of the smoke.

A thin old man appeared, holding a walking stick. His face was wrinkled like the earth after summer. His eyes were sharp.

The children saw him and froze.

Some whispered, “Khalaf...”

Someone hissed, “The wizard!”

Sophia leaned toward Thuraya. “Why do they look like they saw a monster?”

Thuraya whispered back, “They think he is a sorcerer. He lives alone in an old clay house. People fear him.”

The old man, **Shayb Khalaf**, walked straight to John and grabbed his arm.

“Stand up properly,” he said, rough but not cruel.

John, still dizzy, suddenly spoke in Arabic without thinking:

“إيح... حسبك جني! خوفتني... الله يصرفك صرفه”

Sophia gasped. Thuraya’s mouth dropped open.

Khalaf stared at John, then gave a short laugh. “واحليك باه... تفرع؟ خليك رجال”

He lifted his stick a little. “!والا بذي الخيزران ع ظهرك”

John’s eyes widened.

He answered fast, almost politely, still in Arabic: “هاعه... الشيمة تجمل”

Then John stopped.

He blinked like his brain just woke up.

He turned to Sophia in English, whispering, “How did I... say that? I don’t know those sentences.”

Sophia collapsed into laughter again. “You just threatened-corrected yourself in Arabic!”

Thuraya tried to look serious, but her shoulders shook. “Mr. John... you surprise me.”

Malood, meanwhile, was coughing dramatically and leaning against the wall like an actor in a sad movie.

The municipality truck moved on, the smoke slowly thinning. The children returned carefully, peeking from behind a fence.

Mansoor stepped forward, proud. “Teacher John... you are... ghost!”

John pointed at him. “No. I am teacher.”

Thuraya clapped once. “Okay! Everyone... to school.”

In the Classroom (Later That Day)

John walked into the classroom with red, puffy eyes. The chalkboard was old and dusty. The room smelled like chalk, heat, and small lunches hidden in pockets.

A new teacher stood near the door: a strong Egyptian man with a sharp moustache and a serious face.

“I am **Mohammadeen**,” he said in a loud voice. “Math teacher.”

Beside him stood his wife, sporty and confident, wearing a tracksuit. “And I am **Fatkat**,” she said. “Sports teacher.”

The students sat straighter immediately.

Mohammadeen lifted a thin stick. Not in anger, just... as a symbol.

“Any noise,” he said, “and I make you quiet faster than lightning.”

Mansoor swallowed.

Sophia whispered to Thuraya, “They look scared and respectful at the same time.”

Thuraya whispered back, “That’s how it was.”

John cleared his throat. “Today... we talk about what happened.”

He wrote on the board in big letters:

PAST SIMPLE: Yesterday, I... / He... / They...

He turned around. “Repeat: Yesterday, I walked.”

The class echoed: “Yesterday, I walked.”

John pointed to Mansoor. “Mansoor. Yesterday, you...?”

Mansoor stood up proudly. “Yesterday, I run.”

John smiled. “Good! Say: I **ran**.”

Mansoor frowned. “I ran.”

John nodded. “Excellent.”

Then John pointed to himself. “Yesterday, I... fell.”

The class burst into laughter.

Sophia added, teasing, “And yesterday, Mr. John looked like a ghost.”

John sighed. “Yes. He looked like a ghost.”

Thuraya raised her eyebrow. “He looked like a *very* dramatic ghost.”

Mohammadeen watched, trying not to smile. Fatkat failed completely. She laughed openly.

Then John lowered his voice, serious again. “Yesterday, the truck sprayed pesticide. What do we say?”

Sophia helped, speaking slowly with hand gestures. “We say: **Don’t run behind the truck. Go inside. Close the door.**”

Thuraya nodded. “Safety English.”

John wrote more on the board:

Don’t + verb

Don’t run. Don’t breathe the smoke. Don’t touch the spray.

Mansoor raised his hand. “Teacher... Malood... yesterday... Malood... cough?”

Sophia beamed. “Yes! Say: Malood **coughed**.”

The students repeated: “Malood coughed.”

John tapped the board. “Perfect.”

He paused, then looked at Thuraya with suspicious eyes. “I will ask you something after class.”

Thuraya’s smile turned *too innocent*. “Of course.”

John muttered to himself in English, “Something strange is happening here.”

From the back of the class, a quiet boy watched everything with bright eyes.

Not speaking.

Not joining.

Just watching.

His name was **Saeed**.

And he was already collecting secrets like they were treasure.

End of Story 12.

Story 13: The Man Who Came Back from the Grave

(Samail, 1973)

John did not sleep well that night.

Every time he closed his eyes, he saw smoke. Or a stick. Or a thin old man with sharp eyes. Or all of them together, standing at the end of a dark path and saying something he could not understand.

He turned in his simple bed and looked at the ceiling.

“This place,” he whispered in English, “is doing something to my brain.”

Beside him, Sophia was already asleep, breathing peacefully, her scarf folded neatly near the pillow.

Outside, the village of Samail was quiet. The night air was warm. Somewhere far away, a dog barked. Somewhere closer, Malood made a small unhappy sound, like he was arguing with his own dreams.

John closed his eyes again.

And immediately, he saw Shayb Khalaf.

The old man was standing near a clay wall, holding his stick, looking exactly like he had that morning.

“Be a man,” the voice said in John’s head.

John opened his eyes.

“No. Enough,” he said to himself. “Tomorrow, I will ask Thuraya everything.”

The Next Morning

At school, John walked in with two clear missions:

1. Teach English.
2. Understand why he suddenly spoke Arabic like a confused poet.

Sophia noticed his serious face immediately. “You look like you are going to arrest someone,” she teased.

“I am,” John said. “A mystery.”

Thuraya entered a few seconds later, cheerful as always, carrying books and chalk.

“Good morning,” she said.

John looked at her carefully. “Good morning. We need to talk.”

She smiled. “About your flying lesson yesterday?”

“About the old man,” John said. “And about what you did not tell me.”

Thuraya raised her eyebrows. “I did not tell you many things. You must be more specific.”

Before he could answer, the students ran in, filling the classroom with noise and dust and energy.

Mansoor came first, of course, nearly crashing into a desk.

Ahmed walked in quietly and sat straight like a ruler.

Khalil whispered something to Ali and both laughed.

The girls, Noora, Marwa, Rahma, Salima, and Mathila, came in together, talking about something serious and secret.

And in the back, near the door, a boy stood for a moment before sitting.

Saeed.

He did not talk much. He did not play much. He watched.

Always watched.

English First, Fear Later

John wrote on the board:

Today’s Topic: Telling Stories

He turned around. “In English, when we tell a story, we say: First... then... after that... finally...”

He wrote:

First

Then

After that

Finally

Sophia clapped her hands. “Good! Today, we talk about... yesterday.”

The class reacted immediately.

“Teacher John fell!” Mansoor announced proudly.

John closed his eyes for one second. “Yes. Thank you, Mansoor. The village will never forget.”

Thuraya smiled. “Okay. Who wants to tell the story?”

Ahmed raised his hand. “Yesterday, first, the truck came. Then, we ran. After that, teacher John fell. Finally, he became a ghost.”

The class laughed.

John sighed. “Excellent grammar. Terrible story.”

Sophia pointed at Noora. “Your turn.”

Noora thought, then said slowly, mixing languages, “Yesterday, first, smoke come. Then, Mansoor run like crazy. After that, Malood cough. Finally... teacher John... gray.”

Sophia nodded happily. “Good! Very good!”

Saeed was silent.

Watching.

Listening.

Collecting.

The Question

After the class ended, John did not leave.

He waited.

When the last student ran out, he turned to Thuraya.

“Now,” he said. “Tell me the truth.”

Thuraya smiled sweetly. “About what?”

“About Shayb Khalaf. And about me. And about why I spoke Arabic.”

She looked at him for a second.

Then she said, “Come. Let’s walk.”

They walked outside, past the falaj, past the trees, while Sophia stayed behind, organizing books.

Thuraya stopped near an old wall.

“People here,” she said, “love stories.”

John nodded. “I noticed.”

“And people here,” she continued, “love fear.”

John did not like where this was going.

She lowered her voice. “Some say Shayb Khalaf is... maghsoob.”

John blinked. “A... what?”

“Maghsoob,” she repeated. “A man who was given to the jinn.”

John laughed. “That is not funny.”

“I am not joking,” she said seriously. “The story says: to become a great sorcerer, a man must give one of his children to the devils. The child disappears. Years later, he comes back.”

John felt cold.

“They say he comes back like a dead man,” Thuraya continued. “Dirty. His clothes are old. His mind is gone. The devils ate his mind. People do not accept him, because... he already died.”

John swallowed.

“And they say,” she added quietly, “sometimes... he can put words in your mouth.”

John stared at her.

“... You are joking,” he said.

Thuraya looked at him.

Then she smiled.

“Yes,” she said. “Of course I am joking.”

He did not relax.

She laughed. “Mr. John, your face! You look like you saw the ghost again.”

“You told me that on purpose,” he said.

She nodded proudly. “Yes.”

Meanwhile... Saeed

Not far away, near the trees, Saeed was sitting with two smaller boys.

He was not playing.

He was talking.

Quietly.

“They say Shayb Khalaf is maghsoob,” he told them.

The boys’ eyes grew big.

“They say he died and came back,” Saeed continued. “They say he eats brains.”

One boy whispered, “Did he eat Teacher John’s brain?”

Saeed smiled a small, clever smile. “Maybe.”

The Afternoon

That day, John was... nervous.

Every shadow looked suspicious.

Every sound looked dangerous.

When Malood suddenly jumped from behind a bucket, John jumped like he saw a lion.

Sophia laughed. "You are becoming very local."

"I am becoming very scared," John answered.

When they walked home, John looked at every old man.

Every wall.

Every tree.

Then he saw someone sitting near the road.

Old.

Thin.

Holding a stick.

Shayb Khalaf.

John stopped walking.

Sophia continued, then noticed. "John?"

The old man looked up.

Their eyes met.

Khalaf said nothing.

Just watched.

John nodded... very politely.

Khalaf nodded back.

Nothing happened.

They walked away.

John did not breathe until they turned the corner.

That Night

John could not sleep.

Again.

He looked at the ceiling.

Then at the door.

Then at the window.

“Thuraya is enjoying this too much,” he whispered.

Outside, the village was quiet.

Inside, his imagination was not.

He closed his eyes.

And dreamed of a man made of dust, walking out of a grave, holding a stick, speaking perfect English.

The Next Day at School

John walked in with coffee and red eyes.

Ahmed noticed immediately. “Teacher... you tired?”

“Yes,” John said. “Very.”

Mansoor grinned. “You afraid?”

“No,” John lied.

Saeed watched.

And smiled.

Just a little.

End of Story 13

Story 14: The Ring That Disappeared

(Samail, 1973)

The day began quietly.

Too quietly.

John noticed this first, and that alone made him suspicious.

The village of Samail usually woke up with noise: children running, goats arguing with fences, someone shouting for someone else, and always, always Mansoor doing something he was not supposed to do.

But this morning... there was only birds and the soft sound of the falaj water.

Sophia, or “Safiya” as everyone here called her, was sitting near the small mirror, fixing her scarf carefully. She moved slowly, calmly, like she wanted the day to stay peaceful.

John was writing something in his notebook.

Thuraya arrived a few minutes later, carrying books and smiling.

“Good morning,” she said. “You both look... too relaxed.”

John looked up. “Yes. And that worries me.”

Sophia laughed. “You are becoming very local.”

They walked to school together.

Malood, the baby goat, followed them like a small white cloud with legs.

No one invited him.

No one could stop him.

The Discovery

The first two lessons passed normally.

Too normally.

The students did their work. Even Mansoor only caused two small problems.

Then, during the break, Sophia stood up to wash her hands near the water pot.

She stopped.

She looked at her hand.

She looked again.

Then she froze.

“My ring,” she said slowly.

Thuraya turned. “What?”

“My ring. It is not here.”

Sophia checked her other hand. Then her pocket. Then her bag.

Nothing.

John stood up immediately. “What ring?”

“My ring,” Sophia said. “The one from my mother.”

Silence.

Even Mansoor felt it was serious.

Thuraya walked closer. “Are you sure you wore it today?”

“Yes,” Sophia said. “I remember. I fixed my scarf and looked at it in the mirror.”

John’s face changed. “Okay. Nobody panic. We will find it.”

Mansoor raised his hand. “Teacher... maybe Malood eat it?”

Everyone turned slowly.

Malood was standing near the door.

Chewing something.

Everyone stared.

Sophia’s heart jumped. “Malood! No, no, no...”

She walked toward him.

Malood stopped chewing.

Then ran.

The Chase

Malood ran like he had stolen the crown of the king.

The children ran after him.

“Catch him!”

“He ate the ring!”

“Stop, Malood!”

John ran too, holding his trousers.

Thuraya shouted, “Careful!”

Malood jumped over a small wall.

The children jumped too.

John tried.

He did not jump.

He climbed.

Slowly.

Carefully.

By the time he reached the other side, Malood was gone.

They searched near the trees.

Near the falaj.

Near the small fields.

Nothing.

Sophia looked like she wanted to cry.

Thuraya put a hand on her shoulder. "We will find it."

Then a small voice said, very quietly:

"...Maybe Shayb Khalaf."

Everyone turned.

It was one of the smaller boys.

Mansoor's eyes became big. "Yes! Shayb Khalaf!"

Another boy whispered, "He likes shiny things."

A girl said, "He is maghsoob..."

John felt cold.

Sophia looked at Thuraya. "They don't really mean that... right?"

Thuraya hesitated.

Just a little.

John noticed.

That made everything worse.

The Rumor Grows

By lunchtime, the story was everywhere.

“Shayb Khalaf took the ring.”

“Malood works for him.”

“He uses magic.”

“He is maghsoob.”

Saeed did not say anything.

He only listened.

And remembered.

Sophia tried to stay calm, but John could see she was worried.

“This is crazy,” John said. “We are accusing an old man because a goat is stupid.”

Malood, sitting in the shade, sneezed.

“See?” John pointed. “Even he agrees.”

Thuraya sighed. “People here... when something is lost... they look for stories before they look for facts.”

Sophia stood up. “Then let’s look for facts.”

The Visit

They walked to the edge of the village.

The children did not come close.

They stayed far.

Watching.

Shayb Khalaf’s house was small.

Made of clay.

Quiet.

John felt his heart beating faster.

Thuraya knocked.

Nothing.

She knocked again.

The door opened slowly.

Khalaf stood there.

Thin.

Quiet.

Holding his stick.

“Yes?” he said.

Thuraya spoke gently. “Good afternoon, uncle. We are sorry to disturb you.”

He looked at John.

Then at Sophia.

Then at Malood.

His eyes stopped at Malood.

“...This goat,” he said. “Always hungry.”

John swallowed.

Thuraya explained. “Sophia lost her ring. The children are afraid it came here.”

Khalaf’s face changed.

Not angry.

Not scared.

Just... tired.

“I did not take anything,” he said.

Sophia felt ashamed.

“We are sorry,” she said quickly. “We only... wanted to ask.”

Khalaf nodded. “You can look.”

They looked.

The house was simple.

A mat.

A pot.

Some clothes.

Nothing else.

No ring.

John felt relief.

And guilt.

The Truth

When they walked back, Saeed was waiting.

He did not smile.

He did not joke.

He said, “Malood was chewing something white this morning.”

Everyone froze.

John turned slowly.

“White?”

Saeed nodded. “Near the big stone. Then he ran.”

They ran.

They found Malood.

Sleeping.

Very happily.

John lifted him.

“Sorry, my friend,” he said. “This is... an investigation.”

They waited.

And waited.

And waited.

Finally...

Sophia screamed.

“My ring!”

It was dirty.

Very dirty.

But it was there.

John closed his eyes. “I will never say anything bad about goats again.”

Malood looked proud.

The Shame

The children were quiet.

No one laughed.

Sophia held the ring and looked at Thuraya. “We almost blamed an innocent man.”

Thuraya nodded. “That happens a lot.”

John said quietly, “We need to fix this.”

The Apology

They went back to Shayb Khalaf’s house.

Sophia spoke first. “We are very sorry.”

John added, “We believed a story. Not the truth.”

Khalaf looked at them for a long moment.

Then he said, “People always do.”

He turned.

Then he added, “But you came back. That is... something.”

He closed the door gently.

That Evening

John was quiet.

Sophia was quiet.

Thuraya was thoughtful.

The village was normal again.

But something changed.

That night, John wrote in his notebook:

“Today, we learned something more important than English.”

In another part of the village, Saeed sat with the boys and said:

“Stories are strong. But truth is stronger.”

And Malood?

Malood slept.

Dreaming of his next meal.

End of story 14

Story 15: The Day the Skin Didn't Care

(Samail, 1973)

The sun in Samail did not wake up gently.

It attacked.

By eight in the morning, the village was already glowing, shining, and quietly threatening everyone who forgot a hat, a scarf, or common sense.

Sophia, or “Safiya,” stood in front of the small mirror, touching her face carefully.

“I think... my face is... cooking,” she said.

Outside, John was already sweating and pretending he was not.

“This is not sun,” he said seriously. “This is a personal attack from the sky.”

At the school yard, Thuraya arrived as usual, calm and prepared, as if the sun had signed a peace agreement with her.

Behind her came Fatkat, full of energy, wearing her sports clothes and carrying a whistle like a weapon.

“Ya binti,” Fatkat said loudly, fanning herself, “this sun is not normal. This sun needs discipline.”

Sophia looked at her. “My face feels like fire.”

Fatkat touched her own cheek. “Mine too. Look. We are... red.”

They stood in the shade and inspected each other like doctors without a degree.

John passed by, looked at them, and said, “You both look like tomatoes that went to the beach.”

Thuraya laughed. “You need something for your skin.”

Fatkat’s eyes shone. “There is Marhoona. She makes good masks. Real traditional.”

Sophia clapped. “Skin care!”

John raised an eyebrow. “Be careful. The skin may not agree.”

They ignored him.

That was a mistake.

The Salon of Marhoona

Marhoona’s place was not really a salon.

It was a small room.

With a mat.

A mirror.

And a lot of confidence.

Marhoona looked at Sophia’s face. Then at Fatkat’s. Then she nodded like a wise judge.

“Sun,” she said. “Too much.”

She mixed things in a small bowl.

“Sandalwood. Saffron.”

She smiled. “Very good for skin.”

She put the mask on Sophia’s face.

Then on Fatkat’s.

They closed their eyes and waited.

And waited.

And waited.

When they opened their eyes and looked in the mirror...

They screamed.

Their faces were...

Yellow.

Very yellow.

Like lemons.

Like... very sad lemons.

Sophia touched her cheek. “Why am I the color of a banana?”

Fatkat shouted, “Ya rab! I look like a warning sign!”

Marhoona said calmly, “It will go.”

That did not help.

The Return

They walked back to school.

Carefully.

Slowly.

Hoping nobody would see them.

Everybody saw them.

John was the first.

He stopped.

Looked.

Then fell into a chair laughing.

“I am sorry,” he said between laughs. “I am really sorry... but you look like... a school bus and a lemon had a baby.”

Thuraya came.

She looked.

She tried to be polite.

She failed.

“This,” she said, pointing at their faces, “is called skin care?”

John wiped his eyes. “Yes. But...”

He stood up, dramatic.

“Some of you do a lot of skin care... but the skin doesn’t care.”

Even Malood made a sound that could be a laugh.

Then Mohammadeen arrived.

He looked at Fatkat.

He froze.

Then he said in his strong Egyptian voice:

“Allah! Eh da elli fi wishik ya Fatkat? ‘Amel zay lawn el-lemon keda leh?”

Fatkat put her hands on her hips. “Don’t talk to me.”

The students arrived.

Mansoor arrived.

Mansoor saw.

Mansoor pointed.

Mansoor laughed.

Very loudly.

“Teacher Fatkat! Teacher Safiya! You are... yellow!”

The class laughed.

Sophia tried to stay calm.

Fatkat did not.

“OUT!” she shouted. “You! Outside!”

Mansoor stood there. “But teacher, I just—”

“OUT!”

Mansoor went out.

Sad.

But still smiling.

In the Classroom

John wrote on the board:

Today’s Topic: SKIN, SOAP, AND THE SUN

He turned around. “Today, we talk about... what not to do.”

Sophia touched her face. “And what not to put.”

Thuraya smiled. “Let’s learn.”

John wrote:

- skin
- face
- soap
- water
- clean
- dirty
- sun
- burn
- wash
- care

He pointed to Sophia. “Say: My skin is...”

Sophia said, “My skin is... yellow.”

The class laughed.

John nodded. “Good sentence. Sad, but good.”

He pointed to a student. “Say: I wash my...”

The boy said, “I wash my face.”

“Good.”

Sophia added, using gestures, “I wash my hands. I wash my face. I use soap.”

Thuraya said, “The sun is hot.”

The class repeated: “The sun is hot.”

John wrote on the board:

The sun is hot.

My skin is red.

I wash my face.

I use soap.

I take care of my skin.

Then Mansoor knocked on the door.

Very quietly.

Fatkat crossed her arms. “Say sorry.”

Mansoor looked at the yellow faces.

Then said, “I am sorry.”

Then, after thinking, added, “But you still look funny.”

Fatkat pointed at the door. “Outside again.”

The Lesson Ends

By the end of the day, the yellow started to become... less yellow.

Sophia touched her face. "I think it is leaving."

Fatkat sighed. "Next time, we use water. Only water."

John smiled. "And maybe... a hat."

That evening, John wrote in his notebook:

"Today we learned:

The sun is strong.

Soap is useful.

And not all 'skin care' cares about skin."

Malood tried to lick Sophia's hand.

She moved it fast. "No. You already did enough."

End of Story 15

Story 16: The Day We Discovered Everyone Can Do Something

(Samail, 1973)

The morning in Samail was already warm, even before the sun climbed high. The mountains looked sleepy, but the village was awake. Roosters were loud, doors were opening, and somewhere far away, someone was already shouting at a goat.

John and Sophia walked with Thuraya along the dusty road toward the school. Malood, the baby goat, followed them for a few steps, then stopped because a leaf looked more interesting.

Sophia fixed her scarf and said, "I still can't believe how quiet this place is in the morning."

John smiled. "Quiet is good. I hope the class is quiet today too."

Thuraya laughed. "You always hope."

They were just passing near the farms when Sophia suddenly stopped walking.

"Wait... what is that?"

John followed her eyes.

On the tall palm tree near the road, a man was climbing like a cat.

Not slowly.

Not carefully.

He was flying.

Up, up, up, using his hands and feet like the tree was a ladder.

It was Sadoo.

The shop owner.

The man who sold potatoes, sweets, and strange things.

Now he was on top of a palm tree.

John opened his mouth. “Is... is that Sadoo?”

Thuraya nodded calmly. “Yes.”

Sophia blinked. “Why is he in the sky?”

Thuraya said, “He is harvesting dates. This is how people collect fresh dates. They climb and cut.”

John looked impressed. “So... Sadoo sells things in a shop... and climbs palm trees?”

“Of course,” Thuraya said.

John watched Sadoo jump down with a bag of dates like it was nothing.

John said in English, very seriously, “Sadoo is... a multi-talented superhero.”

Thuraya laughed. “You haven’t seen anything yet. He also has a sewing shop.”

John froze.

His brain stopped working for one second.

“A... what?”

“A sewing shop. He fixes clothes.”

John looked at Sadoo like he was looking at a legend.

Sadoo saw them and smiled proudly.

He said in Arabic, hitting his chest:

”إفكر مافي معلوم أنا... سادو أنا... سادو يعرف كل شي منيه“

John, without thinking, answered in Arabic:

”!ابوي ما نرومة صوبنا“

Sophia and Thuraya both stopped walking.

They looked at John.

Slowly.

Carefully.

Sophia said, “What... did you just say?”

John blinked. “Did I say something?”

Thuraya crossed her arms. “Yes. In Arabic.”

John suddenly felt cold.

“Oh.”

He looked at the ground. Then at the sky. Then at Sadoo.

He pretended he didn’t hear anything and walked faster.

In his head, he was thinking:

How did I say that? I don’t know that sentence. Am I... learning Arabic in my sleep? Or... is this that ‘maghsoob’ thing again? No. No. Don’t think. Just walk.

Sadoo laughed and waved at them.

They waved back and continued to school.

At School

The classroom was noisy before the lesson even started.

Mansoor was making a paper airplane.

Khalil was trying to steal it.

Noura was talking.

Ahmed was sitting straight like a ruler.

Mathila was sharing a pencil.

Saeed was sitting at the back, watching everything, like always.

John entered.

“Good morning!”

“Good morning, teacher!” the class answered.

John wrote on the board:

Today’s lesson: TALENTS

I can... / He can... / She can...

Sophia clapped her hands. “Okay! Today we talk about what you can do.”

Thuraya smiled. “Your skills. Your talents.”

Mansoor raised his hand without waiting.

“I can run!”

John nodded. “Good. Say: I can run.”

“I can run!”

Khalil said, “I can climb!”

Sophia smiled. “I can climb.”

Ahmed said quietly, “I can read.”

Mathila said proudly, “I can help.”

Noura said, “I can talk.”

The class laughed.

John wrote on the board:

- I can run.
- I can climb.
- I can read.
- I can help.

Then John drew a palm tree on the board.

And a small man on it.

He wrote:

Sadoo can climb a palm tree.

The class laughed happily.

Mansoor shouted, “Yes! Sadoo climb like monkey!”

John corrected him gently. “Sadoo **can** climb.”

“Sadoo can climb!” the class repeated.

Sophia pointed to John. “Teacher John, what can you do?”

John smiled. “I can... teach.”

The class clapped.

Thuraya said, “And I can explain.”

Sophia said, “And I can organize.”

Mansoor shouted, “And I can... make noise!”

Mohammadeen passed by the door and looked inside.

He said in a strong voice, “No, you cannot.”

The class went quiet immediately.

Sophia whispered, “Wow. He doesn’t need English.”

John laughed. “He is universal.”

The Quiet Challenge

John looked at Mansoor and said, “Mansoor. Can you be quiet?”

Mansoor stood up proudly. “Yes. I can.”

Thuraya raised her eyebrow. “Let’s see.”

Sophia looked at her watch. “Let’s try. Two minutes.”

John said, “Okay. Mansoor, sit. Be quiet.”

Mansoor sat.

He was quiet.

For ten seconds.

Then he started moving his foot.

Then his hand.

Then he whispered to Khalil.

John looked at him.

Mansoor closed his mouth.

Thirty seconds.

He started making airplane noises.

Sophia said, “Mansoor...”

He stopped.

One minute.

He was shaking.

Thuraya said, “You can do it.”

Mansoor nodded seriously.

One minute and thirty seconds.

Then he exploded: “Teacher, I can’t!”

The class laughed.

John laughed too. “It’s okay. You can try again tomorrow.”

He wrote on the board:

I can try.

The class repeated.

After School

When the bell rang, Sophia said, “Today was good.”

John nodded. “Very good.”

They walked out.

Near the road, they saw Sadoo again.

This time, he was sitting near his shop.

Sewing.

Fixing a man’s shirt.

Sophia’s mouth opened. “He really does everything.”

John smiled. “Sadoo can climb. Sadoo can sew. Sadoo can sell. Sadoo can...”

Sadoo looked at John proudly.

John almost said something in Arabic again.

He stopped himself.

Sophia looked at him suspiciously.

“You’re thinking in Arabic again, aren’t you?”

John said, “No. Maybe. I don’t know.”

Thuraya laughed. “Don’t worry. Slowly, slowly, Oman is teaching you.”

John looked at the palm trees, the mountains, the road, the school.

And said quietly, “Maybe I can learn more than I think.”

Story 16: The Day We Discovered Everyone Can Do Something

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Carefully.

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Sophia looked at him suspiciously.

“You’re thinking in Arabic again, aren’t you?”

John said, “No. Maybe. I don’t know.”

Thuraya laughed. “Don’t worry. Slowly, slowly, Oman is teaching you.”

John looked at the palm trees, the mountains, the road, the school.

And said quietly, “Maybe I can learn more than I think.”

Story 18: The Day Saeed’s Silence Broke

(Samail, 1973)

Some days in Samail started quietly.

And some days... waited for trouble like it was hiding behind the palm trees.

That day started with fear.

The Missing Things

It began in the schoolyard.

Ali was jumping on one foot, angry and confused.

“My *zanoubah* is gone!” he shouted. “My mother will kill me!”

Rahma was crying. Not small crying. Big crying.

“My new sandals! I just got them! With a buckle!”

Mansoor looked around with wide eyes and said in a low, dramatic voice,
“It is... the work of Shayb Khalaf.”

The children froze.

Khalil whispered, “The wizard?”

Mansoor nodded seriously. “He makes *hura*. Things disappear.”

Noura grabbed Salima’s arm. “Maybe he took them to his clay house...”

Ahmed adjusted his books. “That doesn’t make sense.”

But nobody listened.

Only one boy knew the truth.

Saeed.

He had seen Ali playing near the falaj.

He had seen Rahma leave her sandals near the tree.

And he had seen Malood...

Yes.

Malood.

The baby goat had taken them.

But Saeed said nothing.

He just watched.

And then he remembered...

He should be in the *mal*. The small farm.

Watering.

His stomach turned.

At the Mal

The sun was high when Marhoon, Saeed's father, arrived.

He stood in the middle of the small farm and looked at the dry ground.

The channels were empty.

The plants were thirsty.

His face became dark.

“SAEEED!”

No answer.

He walked around.

Nothing.

Then he saw it.

The rope. The bucket. Untouched.

His jaw tightened.

“He went to watch those school children again,” he said angrily.

He picked up a thin stick.

And walked.

Fast.

The Road

Saeed was sitting near the school road, watching the children.

He always watched.

He didn't come close.

He just sat.

Then he heard footsteps.

Heavy footsteps.

He turned.

His father.

Marhoon.

Saeed stood up slowly.

“Why are you here?” Marhoon shouted. “Why is the *mal* dry?”

Saeed looked at the ground. “I just... wanted to see...”

Before he could finish, the stick came down.

Once.

Twice.

Saeed cried out and fell.

Marhoon was shaking with anger.

“Ahaleek bah! You want to learn yes and no like the *koffar*?” he shouted.

“You want me to tie you to the palm tree?!”

The children stopped.

They watched from far away.

Frozen.

Then a voice came like thunder.

“STOP!”

It was Thuraya.

She ran forward.

Sophia ran behind her.

John ran too.

Thuraya stood between Marhoon and Saeed like a wall.

“That is enough!” she said.

Sophia knelt and hugged Saeed tightly.

John looked at Marhoon, angry and confused.

Then John asked, in English, “What does *koffar* mean?”

Thuraya turned to him. “It means... unbelievers.”

She took a deep breath. “Let me talk to him.”

John raised his hand. “Sabriiiii!”

Everyone looked at him.

Then John started speaking.

In Arabic.

Without knowing.

“!اووي هااا ما كفار حنوه! احنا مسلمين! نصلي ونصوم كماكم باه! لا تحسب”

Silence.

Pure silence.

Marhoon’s mouth opened.

The children's eyes became huge.

Sophia whispered, "When did we pray or fast???"

Mohammadeen, who had just arrived with Fatkat, shouted,
"إمش انتو يا أختي! ده الجنى اللي فيه! يا خرابي الواد اتلبس"

Fatkat screamed.

And fainted.

She fell like a sack of rice.

Everyone jumped.

Sophia screamed. "Oh no!"

Thuraya tried not to laugh. Failed.

John blinked. "Why is everyone... looking at me?"

Marhoon sat down slowly.

Very slowly.

Like his legs forgot how to work.

He didn't speak.

He didn't shout.

He just stared.

At John.

At Saeed.

At the world.

The Truth

Saeed, still shaking, whispered,
"I didn't steal anything... Malood took them..."

They all turned.

Malood stood near the tree.

With Ali's *zanoubah* in his mouth.

And Rahma's sandal.

The children screamed.

"THE GOAT!"

Thuraya closed her eyes. "Of course."

Later, at School

Fatkat woke up.

Mohammadeen was still telling everyone the boy was possessed.

John sat in class, holding his head.

Sophia looked at him. "You are dangerous in Arabic."

John whispered, "I don't remember anything."

Thuraya looked at Saeed, who was sitting quietly near the door.

Not a student.

Not a guest.

But not invisible anymore.

Story 19: The House Where Decisions Are Made

(Samail, 1973)

In Samail, when something big happened, people did not talk about it in the street.

They talked about it in **the Sheikh's house**.

And that day, something big had happened.

The Invitation

The message came in the afternoon.

A boy ran from house to house saying, “After Maghrib prayer, everyone goes to Sheikh’s house.”

Thuraya knew what that meant.

She stood quietly and said, “They will talk about Saeed. And about school.”

John closed his notebook. “Is that... good or bad?”

“In Samail,” Thuraya said, “it is serious.”

Sophia looked worried. “Do we need to prepare something?”

Thuraya smiled a little. “Just your hearts. And maybe... empty stomachs.”

The House of the Sheikh

The Sheikh’s house was not small.

It was not fancy either.

But it was **full**.

Men sat on carpets.

Old men. Young men. Fathers. Uncles.

The air smelled like coffee, incense, and serious talk.

At the side, women were busy.

Very busy.

Big pots.

Big plates.

And **big plans** for lunch after the meeting.

Sophia whispered to Thuraya, “Why is there so much food?”

Thuraya answered, “Because no Omani meeting ends without food.”

Sophia nodded. “Important rule.”

The Food Fear

Sophia looked around and suddenly her face changed.

“Thuraya...”

“Yes?”

“Where is Malood?”

Thuraya blinked. “He was outside.”

Sophia’s eyes became big. “Outside... or... in the kitchen?”

She looked at the big knives.

At the big pots.

At the big plates.

“Oh no,” she whispered. “They killed Malood.”

She held her heart. “The goat...”

At that moment, Fatkat came running, laughing.

“!!إيه بس بقى يا أختي! مالود إيه اللي يتدبح؟ ده برّه مع الحريم! قاعد ياكل ويعمل دوشة عند أم مثلى”

Sophia froze. “He is... alive?”

Fatkat nodded. “More than alive.”

Outside, Malood’s bell rang loudly.

And someone shouted, “STOP EATING THAT!”

Sophia almost cried from happiness.

The Meeting Begins

Inside, the Sheikh sat in the middle.

Marhoon sat near the wall.

Quiet.

Not angry.

Just... heavy.

Saeed sat behind a pillar, half hidden.

John, Sophia, and Thuraya sat together.

The Sheikh cleared his throat.

“We are here,” he said, “to talk about our children. And about learning.”

Someone said, “School is new.”

Someone else said, “Work is more important.”

Marhoon looked at the floor.

Thuraya stood up.

She did not shout.

She did not cry.

She just spoke.

“Knowledge does not take your sons away from you,” she said. “It gives them a way.”

John wanted to help, but he remembered... sometimes his Arabic helped too much.

Sophia held his arm. “No Arabic today.”

He nodded.

Slowly.

Men talked.

Argued.

Listened.

Even Marhoon spoke.

“I was afraid,” he said quietly. “I thought school will change him.”

The Sheikh nodded. “It will. But not in a bad way.”

Saeed looked up.

For the first time.

And Then... Lunch

And like magic...

The serious faces changed.

Plates came.

Rice.

Meat.

More rice.

More meat.

John looked at the food like a man who survived a war.

He ate.

And ate.

And ate.

Sophia stopped him. “John...”

He said with a full mouth, “This is history. I must respect history.”

After lunch, he leaned back, holding his stomach.

And said loudly, in English:

“Now I understand why Omani men have big belly.”

Silence.

Then Thuraya shouted back, laughing:

“It’s good for wearing kanjar!”

Sophia blinked. “What is... kanjar?”

Thuraya smiled. “You will see. Very soon.”

Outside

Outside, Malood was still alive.

Very alive.

He was eating.

And stealing food.

And making children scream.

Saeed was sitting near him.

Smiling.

That Night

John wrote in his notebook:

“Today, a village talked. And something changed.”

Sophia wrote:

“Also, Malood is not food.”

Thuraya looked at the stars and said quietly:

“Tomorrow... we start something new.”

Story 20: The Day the Mandoos Was Opened

(Samail, 1973)

Some houses in Samail had secrets.

Not bad secrets.

Beautiful ones.

And most of them lived inside a **mandoos**.

The Visit

That morning, Thuraya invited John and Sophia to her parents' house.

“My mother wants to show you something,” she said, smiling in a way that meant *many* somethings.

Sophia was excited. “Is it food?”

Thuraya laughed. “Not this time.”

John looked suspicious. “Is it something that will make me eat again?”

“Maybe,” Thuraya said. “But first... culture.”

The house of Thuraya's parents was simple and warm. The walls were light-colored, and the rooms smelled like incense and coffee.

Her mother welcomed them kindly and said, “Come, come. Sit.”

Then she disappeared into another room.

She came back with a **big wooden box**.

Old.

Heavy.

Beautiful.

“What is that?” Sophia asked.

Thuraya said proudly, “That is the **mandoos**.”

John touched it carefully. “It looks like a pirate treasure box.”

Thuraya’s mother smiled. “Better.”

The Treasure Inside

The mandoos opened with a slow, dramatic sound.

Inside...

Light.

Silver.

Gold.

Stories.

Thuraya’s mother took out the first thing.

A **khanjar**.

John’s eyes became round. “Oh! The curved knife!”

“It is not just a knife,” Thuraya said seriously. “It is a symbol.”

Sophia asked, “Can I touch it?”

Thuraya’s mother nodded.

Sophia held it like it was made of glass. “It’s beautiful.”

Then came **silver jewelry**.

Big necklaces.

Heavy bracelets.

Shiny earrings.

And something that moved and made a small sound.

Thuraya smiled. “That is **marta’asha**.”

Sophia said the word slowly. “Mar... ta... asha.”

The jewelry moved and made a soft sound.

“Oh!” Sophia laughed. “It is shaking!”

Thuraya nodded. “That’s why.”

Then came **banjari**.

Sophia looked confused. “What is this?”

Thuraya’s mother showed her. “Bracelets. Many of them.”

She put them on Sophia’s arm.

Cling. Cling. Cling.

Sophia tried to move her hand.

It sounded like music.

John clapped. “You are now a walking instrument.”

Silver or Gold?

Thuraya took out two necklaces.

“One is silver. One is gold.”

John said, “Silver is... gray. Gold is... yellow.”

Sophia nodded. “Like John after lunch and John before lunch.”

John ignored her.

Thuraya smiled. “In Oman, silver is very important. Especially for women.”

Sophia looked at the jewelry. “They are heavy.”

Thuraya’s mother nodded. “Yes. But beautiful.”

John said, “I think if I wear this, I will fall.”

Thuraya laughed. “We don’t put everything on one person.”

Trying Clothes

Then Thuraya’s mother brought **traditional clothes**.

A dress for Sophia.

A dishdasha for John.

And a belt.

And something long and shiny.

John pointed. “Is that... for me?”

Thuraya smiled slowly. “Yes.”

John wore the dishdasha.

Then Thuraya helped him with the belt.

Then she put the **khanjar**.

John looked at himself.

Straight.

Serious.

Important.

Sophia clapped. “You look like... a very hungry sultan.”

John stood taller. “I feel powerful.”

Thuraya laughed. “Be careful. Power comes with responsibility.”

Sophia tried the dress and the jewelry.

Banjari.

Necklace.

Earrings.

Marta’asha.

She walked.

Cling cling cling.

She turned. “Do I look Omani?”

Thuraya smiled warmly. “Very.”

The Lesson Idea

Later, they sat and drank coffee.

John wrote something in his notebook.

“We can make this a lesson.”

Sophia nodded. “Yes! Clothes and jewelry!”

Thuraya said, “Vocabulary.”

She took a piece of paper and wrote:

- **Gold**
- **Silver**
- **Wearing**
- **Necklace**
- **Bracelet**
- **Khanjar**

- **Dress**

Sophia said, “We can teach them:

‘I am wearing...’

‘She is wearing...’”

John added, “And:

‘It is made of silver.’

‘It is made of gold.’”

Thuraya nodded. “Good.”

At School

The next day, the classroom was full of whispers.

Sophia came in wearing **only** one bracelet.

John came in with **only** the belt.

Thuraya carried a small bag.

She opened it.

And the children gasped.

Mansoor shouted, “Wow!”

Mathila smiled. “Pretty!”

Ahmed looked carefully. “Is that real silver?”

Thuraya wrote on the board:

I am wearing...

She pointed to Sophia. “Sophia, what are you wearing?”

Sophia said slowly, “I am wearing... a bracelet.”

The class repeated.

John pointed to himself. “I am wearing... a belt.”

Then Thuraya held up the necklace. “What is this?”

Noura said, “Necklace.”

“Good. And what is it made of?”

Silence.

Thuraya said, “It is made of... silver.”

The class repeated.

Then she held up another. “And this?”

Khalil shouted, “Gold!”

Thuraya smiled. “Yes. It is made of gold.”

Mansoor raised his hand. “Teacher... you are wearing... many things?”

Thuraya laughed. “Not today.”

A Small Problem

At the back of the class, Saeed was sitting quietly.

He was new.

Still careful.

He looked at the jewelry like it was from another world.

Sophia noticed.

She walked to him and asked gently, “Saeed, what am I wearing?”

Saeed thought. Then said, “You... are wearing... bracelet.”

Sophia smiled. “Good!”

John added, “And what is it made of?”

Saeed whispered, “Silver.”

John nodded. “Excellent.”

Mansoor whispered to Khalil, “One day I will wear khanjar.”

Khalil said, “One day you will lose it.”

After Class

John wrote in his notebook:

“Today, we taught silver and gold. Also, I want my own khanjar.”

Sophia said, “No.”

Thuraya laughed.

Outside, Malood was trying to eat a piece of cloth.

Thuraya shouted, “NO, MALOOD!”

Malood ignored her.

As always.

End of Story 20

Story 21: The Day of Fire in Our Mouths

Samail, 1973

The classroom was already hot before the sun reached the middle of the sky.

The fan on the ceiling turned slowly, like it was tired of working in Oman. It made a dry, weak sound: *tak... tak... tak...* but the air did not change its mind. It stayed warm, heavy, and full of dust and chalk.

John stood near the window, blinking. His eyes were still a little red from yesterday. Sophia sat on the teacher’s chair, fanning herself with a notebook.

“Next time,” she said, “we teach English in the fridge.”

Thuraya smiled. “Welcome to Samail.”

The students were already inside. Ahmed sat straight like a ruler. Mansoor was not sitting straight at all. Khalil was whispering something to Ali. Rahma and Salima shared a pencil. Marwa was drawing little flowers in the corner of her book. Noura raised her hand even before the lesson started.

And at the back of the class, a boy sat quietly, watching everything.

Saeed.

He did not sit with the others. He did not talk. He just watched.

Under the desk, something small moved.

Malood.

The baby goat had decided that the classroom was also his classroom.

Sophia looked down and whispered, “We really need to talk about your student.”

Malood answered by chewing a piece of paper.

Before John could start the lesson, Mansoor suddenly stood up.

“Teacher! Teacher!”

“Yes, Mansoor?”

“We eat lamb yesterday.”

John blinked. “You... ate lamb.”

“Yes! And with chili.”

The class reacted at the same time.

“Hot!”

“Very hot!”

“My mouth burn!”

“I cry!”

Khalil added proudly, “I eat more.”

Ali shook his head. “You crazy.”

Sophia laughed. “So... everyone ate spicy food?”

The students nodded.

John smiled slowly. A teacher’s smile. The dangerous kind.

“Good,” he said. “Very good. Today... we talk about **taste**.”

He turned to the board and wrote in big letters:

THE FIVE SENSES

Then under it:

TASTE

He looked at the class. “Repeat after me. Taste.”

“Taaaste,” the class said.

“Good. Now... what words do we use for taste?”

He wrote:

Sweet

Sour

Salty

Spicy

He pointed at the words one by one.

“Sweet.”

“Sweet.”

“Sour.”

“Sour.”

“Salty.”

“Salty.”

“Spicy.”

“Spaiiiicy,” Mansoor said very strongly.

John nodded. “Yes. Spicy.”

Sophia clapped her hands. “Okay! Examples! Who can give me an example?”

Noura’s hand went up like a rocket.

“Yes, Noura.”

“Sugar is sweet.”

“Excellent!”

Ahmed raised his hand. “Lemon is sour.”

“Perfect.”

Khalil said, “Fish is salty.”

“Good.”

Mansoor jumped from his seat. “Chili is... spicy and kill you.”

The class laughed.

John laughed too. “Yes. Chili is spicy. But it does not kill you.”

Under the desk, Malood made a sad sound.

Sophia looked down. “Unless you are a small goat.”

Thuraya laughed. “Malood learned the lesson the hard way yesterday.”

John turned back to the board and wrote:

I like...

I don’t like...

“Repeat,” he said. “I like sweet.”

“I like sweet.”

“I don’t like spicy.”

“I don’t like spicy,” said half the class very seriously.

Mansoor crossed his arms. "I like spicy."

"Of course you do," said Khalil.

Sophia walked between the desks. "Okay. You. Ali."

Ali stood up. "I like salty."

"Good. Rahma?"

Rahma smiled. "I like sweet."

"Marwa?"

"I don't like sour."

"Excellent!"

Then Sophia looked to the back.

"And you... what is your name?"

The quiet boy froze.

The class turned slowly.

Thuraya looked surprised. "His name is Saeed."

Saeed stood up slowly. His voice was small, but clear.

"I... I like sweet."

The room went quiet for one second.

Then Sophia smiled warmly. "Very good, Saeed."

Saeed sat down again, his heart beating fast.

Mansoor whispered, "He talk!"

Khalil whispered back, "He talk English!"

Under the desk, Malood moved again.

Suddenly, John felt something strange.

“Why... do I smell chili?”

Sophia’s eyes widened. “Oh no.”

She turned to the window.

Outside, in the school yard, the children from another class were eating.

Lamb.

With chili.

Very red chili.

And the smell was coming inside.

John’s eyes started to water.

Mansoor smiled. “Teacher... smell is spicy.”

“Yes,” John said slowly. “The smell is... spicy.”

Malood suddenly stood up, walked proudly to the door, and then stopped.

He sneezed.

Then coughed.

Then made a very sad sound.

Sophia rushed. “Oh no, Malood!”

The students laughed.

But then... something worse happened.

John, without thinking, walked to the window and said, “Let me see.”

Big mistake.

A wave of chili air hit his face.

His eyes closed.

His mouth opened.

He inhaled.

Then:

“AAAAAA!”

He jumped back, holding his face.

“My mouth is on fire!”

Sophia tried to help him, but then she smelled it too.

“Oh no—”

She coughed.

Thuraya tried to be strong, but even she started to laugh and cough at the same time.

The class exploded.

Mansoor laughed so much he fell from his chair.

Khalil held his stomach.

Ahmed tried to stay serious. Failed.

Malood ran in a circle, then hid under the desk again.

John grabbed the water bottle and drank.

“It is... spicy air,” he said, crying.

Sophia wrote on the board quickly, still laughing:

Hot

Burn

My mouth is burning!

She turned to the class. “Repeat!”

“My mouth is burning!”

John pointed at himself. “My mouth is burning!”

Mansoor shouted, “Teacher John is burning!”

John looked at him. “Thank you, Mansoor. Very helpful.”

Then he looked at the board and said, “Okay. New sentence.”

He wrote:

It is too spicy.

“Repeat.”

“It is too spicy.”

“Good.”

He wiped his eyes. “Today... we learn English and we learn... not to open windows near chili.”

The class laughed again.

Then John clapped his hands. “Now. Past simple.”

He wrote:

Yesterday, I ate...

He pointed at Mansoor. “Mansoor.”

Mansoor stood proudly. “Yesterday, I eat lamb.”

John smiled. “Say: I ate.”

“Yesterday, I ate lamb.”

“With chili!”

“With chili,” the class added.

John pointed at Malood. “Yesterday, Malood...”

Khalil said, “Yesterday, Malood ate paper.”

Sophia laughed. “Say: Malood ate paper.”

“Malood ate paper.”

Then John pointed to himself. “Yesterday, I...”

He thought for a second.

“...I opened the window.”

Sophia added, “And today, you learned a big lesson.”

John nodded. “Yes. Today, I learned a big lesson.”

At the back, Saeed raised his hand.

Everyone turned.

“Yes, Saeed?” said John gently.

“Yesterday... I ate... dates. Sweet.”

John smiled. “Excellent sentence.”

Saeed sat down, his face a little brighter.

Thuraya watched him quietly.

The fan kept turning.

The heat stayed.

The lesson continued.

At the end of the class, John wrote on the board:

TODAY’S WORDS

Taste

Sweet

Sour

Salty

Spicy

Hot

Burn

I like...

I don’t like...

Yesterday, I ate...

Sophia said, “Homework: write three sentences about what you like and what you don’t like.”

Mansoor sighed dramatically.

Then... something changed.

From outside, from the school office, a radio sound came.

Low. Old. Serious.

A man's voice in Arabic.

"This is the latest news from Dhofar..."

The class did not understand the words.

But they felt the tone.

It was not funny.

Not light.

Not like chili.

Sophia slowly looked at John.

John looked back at her.

For a moment, the classroom was quiet.

Even the fan sounded smaller.

Even Malood stopped moving.

Oman was not only a place of funny stories.

It was also a place of big stories.

John closed his notebook slowly.

"Okay," he said softly. "Class is over."

The End.

Story 22: "Mountains, Ships, and the Man with the Magic Box" (Samail to Muttrah, 1973)

The sky was still sleepy when Aunt Azizah's rooster shouted his opinion to the whole village.

John opened his eyes slowly, as if the morning had pushed a heavy door on his face. He listened for a second, expecting the quiet, polite mornings of England, but Samail did not do polite mornings. Samail did honest mornings.

Outside, the smell of fresh bread floated through the air like a warm invitation. Someone nearby was baking early, and the sound of a metal pan tapping, then a soft "tssss" of something frying, came from the neighbor's yard.

Sophia, or "Safiya" as the neighbors called her, sat up and fixed her scarf. She smiled quietly, dreamy.

"Something smells... amazing," she whispered.

John sniffed the air. "I think your neighbor is making breakfast for the entire planet."

Thuraya knocked on the wooden door frame and walked in without waiting, because in the seventies, in villages, people didn't knock like they were entering a museum.

"Good morning," she said brightly. "Are you ready?"

John looked around at their simple home. The walls were plain. Their bags were still half-open. A corner of Sophia's dress hung on a nail like the house itself was trying to help them unpack.

"I'm ready," John said, pretending he wasn't nervous. "Where are we going again?"

Thuraya's eyes sparkled. "Muscat. Muttrah Souq."

Sophia's mouth opened. "A real souq?"

"A real souq," Thuraya confirmed.

John rubbed his hands. "Okay. New vocabulary. New adventure."

Behind Thuraya, something tiny and determined slid through the doorway like a thief with hooves.

Malood.

The baby goat walked in as if this house belonged to him. He sniffed John's shoe, then decided the shoe was not interesting and aimed straight for Sophia's cloth bag.

"No," Sophia said gently, pulling her bag up. "Not today."

Malood stared at her like he understood, then tried again.

John pointed at him like a strict teacher. “Malood, you are not invited.”

Malood’s ears flicked. He was clearly offended.

Thuraya laughed. “He is coming from the neighbor’s yard every morning. He thinks you are his family now.”

Sophia sighed. “He is too confident.”

Thuraya clapped her hands once, business mode. “Come. Uncle Nasser is waiting.”

Outside, the pickup truck waited like a strong old animal. It was one of those boxy, tough models from that time, dusty and proud. Uncle Nasser sat behind the steering wheel with the calm face of a man who had driven on roads that were sometimes roads and sometimes... hopes.

In the back, there was a wooden bench and a rope tied neatly, ready for people to hold. Uncle Nasser didn’t say much. He didn’t need to. His bamboo stick rested beside him like an extra seat.

John climbed into the back first, trying to look confident. The pickup moved just a little and John grabbed the side fast.

Sophia climbed in more carefully, holding her scarf and laughing.

Thuraya jumped in like she had done this a thousand times. “Hold tight,” she warned. “And don’t scream like Mansoor.”

John blinked. “Mansoor screams?”

Thuraya smiled. “Mansoor screams when the wind touches him.”

The pickup rolled forward, leaving the farms behind. As they drove, the village opened like a storybook: palm shadows, small paths, and goats watching them like village security.

Then the land began to change.

Mountains appeared.

Not polite hills. Not gentle slopes. Real mountains. Tall and bold, rising like giant brown walls around them.

John leaned forward, eyes wide. “Sophia... look.”

Sophia stared. “John... I’ve never seen mountains like this.”

Thuraya glanced at them and smiled. “You don’t have mountains in Britain?”

“We have... small ones,” John admitted. “But these... these look like they belong in a movie.”

Sophia whispered, almost reverently, “They look ancient.”

As the road continued, the air changed. It became salty. Cooler. A different kind of wind, with a different smell.

Sophia lifted her chin like she could taste it. “Sea.”

John’s eyes lit up. “The sea!”

Thuraya nodded. “We are close to Muttrah now.”

When the first glimpse of the water appeared, Sophia made a small sound like she couldn’t help it. The sea stretched wide, shining. Boats and ships rested in the distance. The harbor was busy, alive, like a giant classroom where everyone was doing a different job.

John pointed. “Ships!”

Thuraya smiled. “Yes. And today, you will learn words you can’t learn in a classroom.”

Sophia opened her notebook. “I’m ready.”

The pickup stopped near the harbor and they climbed down. John’s legs felt strange, like his body was still moving.

Uncle Nasser said, “Stay close.” Then he added, very softly, “And no trouble.”

John nodded quickly. “No trouble.”

Thuraya raised an eyebrow. “That sentence is dangerous in Oman.”

They walked toward the souq area, but first they passed a small group of sellers near the port. Some had baskets. Some had cloths on the ground with items arranged carefully.

And then they saw him.

A simple Zanzibari trader, sitting beside a wooden box that looked like it had traveled more than any passport. His skin was sun-browned, his clothes plain, and his smile sharp like he knew a joke the world hadn’t heard yet.

In front of him were small things: beads, tiny perfume bottles, a little mirror, and some shiny objects that looked like treasures to a child.

Sophia slowed down. “Oh... look.”

John leaned in. “What is he selling?”

Thuraya whispered, “Many things. But be careful. Some sellers in Muttrah have strong... talking skills.”

The trader looked up and his eyes landed on John and Sophia like they were new customers and new entertainment at the same time.

He smiled. “Welcome, welcome! Come! Look! Very good things!”

John froze. He heard English. Not perfect, but clear enough.

Sophia smiled politely. “Hello.”

The trader nodded proudly. “Hello! Hello! You want? I have nice things. Small price. Big happiness.”

John laughed softly. “Big happiness? That sounds good.”

The trader tapped the wooden box with love. “This box? Magic box. It has... everything.”

Thuraya tried not to smile. “Magic?”

The trader leaned forward dramatically. “Yes. Magic.”

Sophia whispered to John, “He is a storyteller.”

John, being John, decided this was a learning moment. He cleared his throat and spoke slowly, teacher voice.

“Okay. Vocabulary,” he said to Sophia and Thuraya. Then he turned to the trader with a friendly smile. “What do you sell?”

The trader’s eyes shone. “I sell... things. Good things.”

John nodded. “How much?”

The trader blinked, then smiled wider. “Ah. You know. You learn fast.”

Sophia’s eyes were bright. “John, ask him the names.”

John pointed to a string of beads. “What is this?”

The trader answered quickly, “Beads.”

John nodded. “Good. And this?” He pointed to a tiny bottle.

“Perfume,” the trader said. “Very strong. One drop, you smell like... rich person.”

Sophia giggled. “One drop?”

The trader nodded seriously. “One drop. Two drops, you become problem.”

Thuraya’s shoulders shook with laughter.

John pointed to a small silver object. “And this?”

The trader hesitated... then said confidently, “A... ship key.”

John blinked. “A ship key?”

Sophia leaned in, curious. “A key for a ship?”

The trader nodded like it was obvious. “Yes yes. For ship. You open ship.”

Thuraya turned away, laughing into her scarf.

John looked at her. “Is that real?”

Thuraya tried to be serious. “No, Mr. John. That is not real.”

The trader jumped in quickly, sensing danger. “Okay okay! Not ship key. It is... decoration!”

John laughed. “Ahh. Decoration. Good.”

Sophia whispered to Thuraya, “He is trying to sell a story, not an object.”

Thuraya nodded. “Yes. That is Muttrah.”

John looked at the trader and decided to teach politely. “In English we say... ‘I want’.”

The trader’s eyes widened. “I want.”

John smiled. “Good. ‘I want beads.’”

The trader repeated, “I want beads.”

Sophia laughed. “He sounds like the customer now.”

The trader pointed at John suddenly. “You! You want beads!”

John laughed. “No, not me.”

The trader pointed at Sophia. “You want perfume!”

Sophia shook her head quickly. “No, thank you.”

The trader held the bottle up like it was an award. “One drop, you smell like queen!”

Thuraya cleared her throat, stepping in. “We are going to the souq. Thank you.”

But the trader leaned forward, determined. “Wait! Wait! Gift. Small gift.”

He opened the wooden box and pulled out a little mirror with a shiny frame. He offered it to Sophia.

Sophia hesitated. Her polite heart wanted to accept. Her smart brain screamed don’t accept gifts from strangers.

John tried to help. “No, it’s okay, thank you.”

The trader pushed it gently closer. “Free. Welcome gift.”

Sophia finally took it carefully. “Thank you.”

The trader smiled like he just won.

Then he pointed at John. “Now you buy.”

John froze. “...What?”

Thuraya’s eyes danced. “Welcome to Muttrah.”

John looked at Sophia, betrayed. “Sophia!”

Sophia held up the mirror. “I thought it was kindness.”

The trader nodded proudly. “Yes. Kindness business.”

John sighed, then decided: learning moment again.

He faced the trader and spoke slowly, clearly. “I don’t want to buy.”

The trader frowned, confused. “You don’t want to... buy?”

John repeated, “I don’t want to buy.”

Thuraya whispered to Sophia, “Good sentence.”

Sophia whispered back, “Very good sentence.”

The trader stared at John, then suddenly smiled. “Okay okay. You don’t want to buy. But you can... look.”

John exhaled. “Yes. Look.”

They started walking away toward the souq, but John couldn’t stop thinking about one thing.

He turned to Thuraya, voice low. “Was that... a trick?”

Thuraya smiled sweetly. “It is not a trick. It is... a lesson.”

Sophia scribbled in her notebook.

New Words:

- mountain
- sea
- ship
- port
- seller
- beads
- perfume
- gift
- mirror
- price

John looked at the entrance of the souq ahead. The narrow lanes. The shadows. The sounds. The smells of spices and incense. The voices.

He swallowed.

“I think,” he said quietly, “this place is going to teach me English again.”

Thuraya nodded. “And patience.”

Sophia smiled. “And survival.”

Uncle Nasser called from behind them, “Yalla!”

John squared his shoulders. “Okay. Next task.”

Sophia teased, “Task-Based Learning... in real life.”

Thuraya smiled. “Exactly.”

They stepped closer to the souq, and behind them, the trader waved happily as if nothing happened.

“Welcome! Welcome! Big happiness!” he called.

John muttered under his breath, “Small price. Big trouble.”

Thuraya heard and laughed.

And just before they entered the first narrow lane of Muttrah Souq, John heard a familiar voice somewhere ahead.

A loud voice, confident, and very... Sadoo.

John stopped walking.

Thuraya’s smile slowly widened. “Oh no.”

Sophia blinked. “What?”

Thuraya pointed toward the sound. “That voice... is going to start our next problem.”

John whispered, “Please tell me Sadoo is not here.”

Thuraya whispered back, almost lovingly, “Sadoo is everywhere.”

And the three of them walked into the souq...

right toward the trouble.

To be continued... (Story 23)

Story 23: “Mountains, Ships, and the Man with the Magic Box” (Part 2 – Muttrah Souq, 1973)

The first thing that entered John’s nose inside Muttrah Souq was... everything.

Spices, fish, incense, leather, old wood, perfume, and something fried that had no clear name but a very clear smell.

The second thing that entered his ears was noise.

Voices calling, people bargaining, metal sounds, footsteps, and somewhere in the middle of all that...

Sadoo.

“يا سلام يا سلام! اليوم تجارتنا نار! نار”

John stopped walking.

Sophia bumped into his back. “Why did you stop?”

John pointed slowly, like someone pointing at a wild animal in a zoo. “That... voice.”

Thuraya closed her eyes for one second. “Yes. That is Sadoo.”

Sophia blinked. “Your Sadoo?”

“Our Sadoo,” Thuraya corrected.

They moved carefully through the narrow path until they saw him.

Sadoo stood in front of a small shop, wearing his usual clothes, talking with his hands, his feet, and probably his eyebrows too. Around him were bags, boxes, ropes, and a very confused man holding a basket.

Sadoo saw them.

His face became a celebration.

“هااااه! الأستاذ جون! صفيه! مس ثريا! وينكم من زمان”

He rushed toward them like a happy storm.

John smiled carefully. “Hello, Sadoo.”

Sadoo shook his hand strongly. Then he shook Sophia’s hand. Then he tried to shake Thuraya’s hand, but she stepped back.

“سادو، ویش تسوي هنا؟” Thuraya asked.

Sadoo puffed his chest. “جيت أشتري أغراض للدكان. مطرح! كله خير”

Sophia looked around. “You have... many bags.”

Sadoo nodded proudly. “كلها لي.”

John looked at one of the bags. It moved.

He froze.

“...Why is your bag moving?”

Sadoo looked. “آه. هذا؟ سمك.”

John stepped back. “Alive fish?”

Sadoo nodded. “طازج.”

John whispered to Sophia, “I am not ready for this country.”

Before Thuraya could control the situation, Sadoo grabbed John’s arm and pulled him toward a shop.

“تعال تعال. هذا محل زين.”

The shop was full of metal things. Pots. Plates. Trays. And in the middle, a man stood with crossed arms and a very serious face.

Sadoo pointed proudly. “هذا صديقي. بيعطينا سعر خاص.”

The man looked at John. Then at Sophia. Then at Thuraya. Then back at Sadoo.

He said something fast in Arabic.

Sadoo answered faster.

They started talking. Loudly. With hands.

John turned to Thuraya. “What is happening?”

Thuraya sighed. “Sadoo is bargaining.”

Sophia whispered, “It looks like a fight.”

Sadoo suddenly turned to John. “اجون! قول له! قول له.”

John blinked. “Say... what?”

Sadoo pushed a big metal tray toward him. “قول له: I want this. But cheap.”

John cleared his throat, teacher mode. He looked at the seller.

“I want this,” he said carefully, pointing. “But... cheap.”

The seller’s eyebrow went up.

He answered in fast Arabic.

Thuraya translated. “He says: ‘This is not cheap.’”

John nodded seriously. “Okay. This is not cheap.”

Sadoo slapped his forehead. “لا لا! مو كذا! لازم تقول: I don’t want. Too expensive!”

John tried again. “I don’t want. Too expensive.”

The seller crossed his arms tighter.

He answered again.

Thuraya translated. “Now he says: ‘Then don’t buy.’”

Sadoo stared at John like John had broken the world.

“إيا رجل! خربتھا”

Sophia tried not to laugh.

John defended himself. “I said exactly what you told me.”

Sadoo waved his hands. “إبس ما كذا”

The seller suddenly picked up the tray and put it inside the shop.

He turned his back.

Sadoo gasped. “راح”

He turned to Thuraya. “إمس ثريا! قولي له شي”

Thuraya crossed her arms. “You started this.”

Sadoo looked around, then saw Sophia.

“صفيه! أنت طيبه. قولي له شي”

Sophia panicked. “Me? I don’t know Arabic!”

Sadoo smiled. “اقولّي بالإنجليزي.”

Sophia looked at the seller’s back and tried. “Excuse me... we are... just looking.”

The seller turned slowly. Looked at her. Then said in broken English:

“Looking... no buying?”

Sophia nodded fast. “Yes. Just looking.”

The seller shrugged. “Okay.”

Sadoo whispered, “نجحت.”

John blinked. “That worked?”

Thuraya smiled. “Sometimes English is magic.”

They moved away before Sadoo could cause another disaster.

They walked deeper into the souq.

More shops. More sounds. More colors.

Suddenly...

“وين منصور؟”

Thuraya stopped walking.

Sophia’s heart jumped. “What?”

Thuraya looked around. “Mansoor is not here.”

John’s stomach dropped. “What do you mean... not here?”

They turned. Counted.

One. Two. Three.

No Mansoor.

Sadoo looked around too. “يمكن راح يشوف شي.”

John’s face became white. “He is a child. In this place.”

Thuraya's voice became sharp. "We must find him. Now."

They split.

John and Sophia went one way.

Thuraya and Sadoo went another.

John walked fast, calling, "Mansoor! Mansoor!"

People looked at him like he was calling a lost camel.

Sophia checked every small shop. "Mansoor!"

Then they heard it.

Laughter.

Very familiar laughter.

They followed the sound.

And found him.

Mansoor stood in front of a man selling toys. He was holding a small wooden sword.

His eyes were shining.

"Mansoor!" Thuraya shouted, arriving behind them.

Mansoor turned. "امس ثريا! شوف"

John ran and grabbed his shoulder. "You cannot disappear like that!"

Mansoor looked confused. "بس أنا شفت سيوف"

Sophia bent down. "You scared us."

Mansoor looked guilty. "أسف"

The toy seller smiled. "He likes sword."

Sadoo arrived, breathing hard. "هذا مجنون"

Thuraya took Mansoor's hand firmly. "Stay with the group. Always."

Mansoor nodded.

John wiped his face. “New rule. Nobody moves alone.”

They continued walking.

Then...

They heard shouting.

Angry shouting.

It was Sadoo’s voice.

They turned.

Sadoo was arguing with another seller.

Loudly.

Very loudly.

“!هذا مو اللي عطيتني”

The seller shouted back.

People started looking.

Thuraya whispered, “Oh no. What did he do?”

Sadoo turned and saw them. “!هذا الرجال أعطاني شي غير”

The seller shouted something.

Thuraya translated fast. “He says you changed it.”

Sadoo put his hands on his head. “!أنا؟ لا”

The seller pointed at a bag.

Inside was... something broken.

The crowd grew.

John felt the heat. “This is becoming... big.”

Sophia whispered, “Very big.”

The seller shouted again. Sadoo shouted louder.

Then...

A police officer appeared.

Everything became quiet.

The officer looked at Sadoo. Then at the seller.

Then at the bag.

Thuraya’s heart sank.

The officer asked questions.

Fast Arabic.

Sadoo answered.

Fast Arabic.

Thuraya translated to John and Sophia in a low voice. “The seller says Sadoo broke something and does not want to pay.”

Sadoo protested. “!ما كسرت شي”

The officer looked at Sadoo seriously.

John stepped forward without thinking. “Excuse me.”

Everyone looked at him.

He swallowed. “We... are teachers. He is... our friend.”

The officer looked at him.

Then said slowly in English. “Problem?”

John nodded. “Yes. But... maybe misunderstanding.”

The officer thought.

Then said something to the seller.

The seller sighed.

He said something back.

Thuraya's eyes widened. "He says... okay. He will not make problem. But Sadoo must pay a small amount."

Sadoo's face fell. "حتى لو ما كسرت؟"

Thuraya looked at him. "Yes. Even if."

Sadoo sighed deeply. Then paid.

The crowd disappeared like nothing happened.

John exhaled. "That... was scary."

Sophia nodded. "Very."

Thuraya looked at Sadoo. "I told you. In Muttrah, your mouth is dangerous."

Sadoo smiled sheepishly. "بس حماس."

They walked back toward the bus.

Everyone was tired.

Uncle Nasser was waiting, counting them like precious boxes.

"كلکم موجودین؟"

Thuraya nodded. "Yes."

They climbed in.

As the pickup moved, the students talked, laughed, and showed what they bought.

Mansoor slept in two minutes.

John leaned back and closed his eyes.

Sophia smiled. "So... what did we learn today?"

John answered without opening his eyes. "How to say 'I don't want to buy'... and how to survive Muttrah."

Thuraya laughed. “And you still have many lessons.”

From the front, Sadoo said proudly, “رحلة جميلة.”

John opened one eye. “Beautiful... and dangerous.”

Sophia laughed.

And Muttrah stayed behind them, full of stories they would tell for many years.

Story 24: “The Domino Game and the Mysterious Shayb Khalaf” (Samail, 1973)

The village looked ordinary again.

No smoke. No shouting. No running behind trucks. Just sun, dust, and quiet footsteps that sounded louder than they should. After the Muttrah trip, Samail felt smaller, like the mountains had followed John back and were now hiding inside his head.

John stood in the yard early, holding his cup of tea with both hands. His eyes were still slightly red, not from smoke this time, but from too much thinking.

Sophia, “Safiya” to everyone except John and Thuraya, was folding clothes on a rope line. She paused every few seconds to stare at the mountains far away, as if she expected a ship to sail out from behind them.

Ms. Thuraya arrived carrying a small basket with papers and chalk. She looked bright, too bright, like someone who knew a secret joke and was waiting for the perfect moment to release it.

John watched her carefully. “You are smiling like you already know what I will say.”

Thuraya’s smile grew wider. “Maybe I do.”

Sophia leaned toward him. “John, you have been staring at the door since sunrise. Are you waiting for a letter? A miracle? A goat?”

John pointed at the road. “I’m waiting for... answers.”

“What answers?” Sophia asked.

John lowered his voice as if the date palms could understand English. “Muttrah. The market. The sea. That man with the box. And how everyone kept saying things that sounded like warnings and jokes at the same time.”

Thuraya sat on the edge of the small stone wall. “In Samail, warnings and jokes are cousins.”

John nodded slowly. “Exactly. And now I want to know if... if this village is normal.”

Sophia laughed. “John, you chose Oman in 1973. Normal is on vacation.”

Before John could reply, a familiar little shadow hopped into the yard.

Malood.

The baby goat marched in like a king, sniffed Sophia’s clean clothes, then tried to chew a corner of a scarf. Sophia gently pulled it away and sighed, “This goat has no shame.”

Malood stared at her as if offended, then ran straight toward John’s bag, the same bag he always attacked, as if it contained the most delicious secrets in the world.

John lifted the bag. “No, Malood. Not today. I need this bag for school.”

Malood jumped, failed, and looked angry.

Thuraya chuckled. “He is practicing for future crimes.”

John looked at Thuraya. “Speaking of crimes... I have to ask you something.”

Thuraya blinked innocently. “Ask.”

John took a breath. “Who is Shayb Khalaf really?”

Sophia froze mid-fold.

Malood stopped chewing.

Even the air felt like it waited.

Thuraya didn’t answer right away. She looked toward the path that led to the edge of the village, where the clay houses grew older, and the trees grew wilder.

Then she said calmly, “He is an old man. He lives alone. People fear him because people fear what they don’t understand.”

John’s voice dropped. “But why do they think he is... a wizard?”

Thuraya shrugged. “Stories grow faster than palm trees. One day he is just a lonely man. Next day he is a wizard. The next day... he is something worse.”

Sophia spoke softly. “Is he dangerous?”

Thuraya looked at her. “No. But... he likes silence. And he doesn’t like people watching him like he is a story.”

John nodded. Then he whispered, “Good. Because I want to talk to him.”

Sophia snapped her head toward him. “John... why?”

“Because,” John said, standing straighter, “I feel like he knows things. And I don’t like mysteries in places where I live.”

Thuraya’s smile returned, small and sharp. “Then go. But don’t blame me if you run.”

Sophia narrowed her eyes. “Thuraya. That sounded like a threat.”

Thuraya raised her hands. “It is not a threat. It is... a prediction.”

And just like that, John decided.

Under the Shawab Tree

The path to Shayb Khalaf’s house felt longer than it looked. The village sounds faded behind them. Even Malood followed, bouncing along as if this was a grand adventure.

Sophia tried to keep her voice light. “Maybe we should not bother him.”

John walked faster. “We are not bothering. We are greeting. We are... friendly teachers.”

Thuraya walked beside them with calm confidence. “Remember your greeting lesson.”

John forced a smile. “Hello. Good morning. How are you?”

Sophia added, “Nice to meet you.”

Thuraya nodded. “Good. Don’t forget ‘We are sorry to disturb you.’ Just in case.”

John gave her a look. “You prepared that sentence too quickly.”

Thuraya pretended not to hear.

Soon, they saw it: a small old clay house with a rough wooden door. In front of it stood the famous **shawab tree**, wide and heavy, like it had been watching the village for a hundred years without blinking.

Under the tree, a man sat on a mat.

Shayb Khalaf.

He held a small cup of coffee. His walking stick rested beside him. And in front of him... a set of dominoes, laid out neatly as if waiting for a guest.

John slowed down. His stomach did a strange little flip.

Sophia whispered, "Why are the dominoes already ready?"

Thuraya whispered back, "Because he is always ready."

Malood tried to step forward, but Thuraya gently held him back by the little rope around his neck. "Not now, trouble-maker."

John cleared his throat.

Shayb Khalaf didn't look up.

John tried again, louder. "Good morning."

Still nothing.

Sophia leaned closer. "Maybe he didn't hear."

Then the old man spoke, without looking at them.

"Good morning," he said.

His English was not perfect. But it was clear enough to hit John like a cold bucket of water.

John froze.

Sophia's mouth opened slightly, then closed.

Thuraya's eyes sparkled. She looked like she was trying very hard not to laugh.

John managed to speak. "You... you speak English."

Shayb Khalaf finally looked up. His eyes were sharp like a hawk's, but tired like someone who carried heavy thoughts.

He nodded once. "Little."

John's voice became polite and nervous. "We are teachers. New teachers. We came from Britain."

Shayb Khalaf stared at him for a long moment.

Then he pointed at the dominoes.

“Sit,” he said.

John blinked. “Sit?”

“Sit,” Shayb Khalaf repeated, like it was the only word that mattered.

Sophia touched John’s arm. “John... do we sit?”

John swallowed. “We sit.”

They sat under the shawab tree. The shade felt cooler than the rest of the village, like the tree was protecting secrets.

Shayb Khalaf pushed the dominoes forward.

John stared at them. “You want to... play?”

Shayb Khalaf nodded. “Play.”

Thuraya sat on the side, watching like a referee who already knew the winner.

Sophia whispered, “Do you know how to play?”

John whispered back, “I know the rules. I just... didn’t know I would play dominoes with a village wizard under a sacred tree.”

Thuraya whispered, “He is not a wizard.”

John whispered, “He spoke English.”

Thuraya smiled. “Some people learn languages. That doesn’t make them wizards.”

John lifted a domino piece carefully, as if it could bite.

Shayb Khalaf watched him, silent.

John placed a piece down.

Shayb Khalaf placed a better piece down immediately, like he had been waiting for John to make that exact move.

Sophia leaned back slowly. “He is good.”

John nodded stiffly. “Too good.”

After a few moves, Shayb Khalaf spoke again, still calm.

“Muttrah is noisy,” he said.

John’s heart jumped. “Yes... it is.”

Shayb Khalaf continued, “You went there. You saw ships.”

Sophia’s face changed. “How do you know?”

Shayb Khalaf looked at her. “News travels.”

John’s hands tightened on his dominoes. “Who told you?”

Shayb Khalaf pointed loosely to the village behind them. “People.”

Then he looked directly at John and said, “And you got into trouble.”

John’s face went pale. “We... we did not get into trouble.”

Shayb Khalaf raised one eyebrow.

John felt the air press down on him.

Sophia whispered sharply, “John... your face is confessing.”

John tried to laugh, but it came out like a cough. “Small trouble. Only... small.”

Thuraya covered her mouth, shoulders shaking.

Shayb Khalaf placed another domino piece.

Click.

The sound felt loud.

Then he said, still in English, “Next time, listen.”

John’s throat became dry. “Listen to who?”

Shayb Khalaf’s eyes flicked toward Thuraya for half a second, then back to John.

“Listen,” he repeated.

John stared at him, then looked at Thuraya. “Why does he keep saying ‘listen’ like it is... a warning?”

Thuraya smiled sweetly. “Maybe because you don’t listen.”

John opened his mouth to argue, but Shayb Khalaf suddenly said, casually, “Your goat likes your bag.”

Sophia turned her head so fast she almost hurt her neck. “How do you know about Malood?”

Shayb Khalaf looked at Malood, who was currently chewing the corner of John’s bag again with full confidence.

Shayb Khalaf said, calmly, “Because he is doing it now.”

John looked at Malood. Then back at Shayb Khalaf.

Then he whispered, “This is impossible.”

Shayb Khalaf placed his last domino.

He won.

John stared at the domino line like it was an official stamp of defeat.

Sophia exhaled. “He beat you.”

John, half in shock, stood up quickly. “Thank you. We... we should go.”

Shayb Khalaf lifted his cup and drank slowly.

Then he said, almost lightly, “You are afraid.”

John forced a smile. “No, I am not afraid.”

Shayb Khalaf nodded once. “Yes, you are.”

John felt his cheeks heat.

He turned away.

Then Shayb Khalaf added, quietly, in Arabic this time, like a knife slipping out:

“واحليك باه... تفرع.”

John froze.

Sophia's eyes widened.

Thuraya's smile became dangerous.

John spun back. "You... you said that before."

Shayb Khalaf looked at him. "Did I?"

John's voice shook. "Yes."

Shayb Khalaf leaned back, calm. "Maybe you imagined it."

John grabbed his sandals, suddenly needing to move, needing air.

Sophia stood too. "Thank you, Shayb Khalaf."

Shayb Khalaf didn't answer.

John took two steps... then turned and blurted, in English, "Why do people say you are a sorcerer?"

The air changed again.

Thuraya stopped smiling.

Sophia held her breath.

Shayb Khalaf's face did not change, but his eyes did.

He said, quietly, "People need a story."

John swallowed. "And the story about... the 'maghsoob'?"

Thuraya's head snapped toward John. "Why would you say that here?"

John whispered, "Because... because I heard it."

Shayb Khalaf stared at him for a long time.

Then he said one sentence, slow and heavy:

"Don't play with fear. Fear plays back."

John's stomach dropped.

He nodded quickly. "Okay. Thank you. Goodbye."

And then he did what Thuraya predicted.

He ran.

Barefoot.

Holding his sandals like a strange trophy.

Sophia followed, half laughing, half worried, calling, “John! John, slow down!”

Behind them, Thuraya walked calmly, like she owned the whole scene.

She glanced back once.

Shayb Khalaf was still sitting under the shawab tree, quiet, unmoving.

As if nothing happened.

As if they were the ones who were strange.

In School: If I... I Will...

By the time they reached the classroom, John was still breathing like he had escaped a tiger.

The students noticed his face immediately.

Mansoor whispered loudly, “Teacher John... you run!”

John tried to stand tall. “Yes. I ran.”

Thuraya wrote the target structure on the board:

IF I ..., I WILL ...

Sophia clapped her hands. “Today, we use our trip to learn English!”

John pointed at himself and said slowly, “If I see Shayb Khalaf... I will run.”

The class burst into laughter.

Thuraya smiled. “Good sentence. True sentence.”

Sophia pointed to a student. “Your turn. If you eat too much chili...”

A boy grinned. "If I eat too much chili, I will cry."

John nodded. "Excellent."

Thuraya pointed at Mansoor. "If Mansoor makes noise..."

The students shouted together, "Teacher will shout!"

Mohammadeen, passing by the door, added in his Egyptian accent, "No, no, no. Teacher will make you quiet!"

Fatkat laughed loudly from the corridor.

Sophia continued, "If we go to Muttrah..."

The students repeated, "We will see ships."

John's eyes drifted to the window.

He could almost hear Shayb Khalaf's voice again:

Don't play with fear.

Thuraya noticed his expression and leaned closer, whispering in English so only he could hear.

"Now you understand. People here can make a story inside your head, and you will believe it."

John swallowed. "Did you... did you tell him about Muttrah?"

Thuraya blinked innocently. "Me?"

John stared at her. "Thuraya."

She smiled. "If you accuse me... I will laugh."

Sophia called from the front. "John! Your turn. Give the students one more sentence."

John forced a smile and faced the class.

"If I hear a strange English voice under a tree," he said, "I will... drink tea and pretend it is normal."

The class laughed again.

But John didn't.

Not fully.

Because deep inside, he was still wondering the same thing he wondered after the smoke day:

How did that old man learn English?

And why did he feel like Shayb Khalaf knew more than he should?

Outside, the wind moved softly through the palm farms.

And somewhere in the village, under the shawab tree, silence kept its secrets.

Story 26: “The Day the Sky Fell on Samail” (Samail, 1973)

John woke up because the world was making a strange noise.

Not the normal village sounds.

Not birds.

Not roosters.

Not even Mansoor shouting.

This sound was **tapping... tapping... tapping.**

He opened one eye. Then the other.

“Tup... tup... tup...”

Sophia was already sitting up in bed, staring at the ceiling.

“John,” she whispered. “I think... the sky is leaking.”

Before he could answer, a cold drop fell on his nose.

He jumped. “The sky is WHAT?”

Another drop. Then another.

Sophia looked around. “The roof... it’s dripping!”

She jumped out of bed and ran to the kitchen, grabbing bowls, cups, plates, and anything that could hold water.

“Emergency! Emergency!” she shouted.

John followed her, half asleep. “Is this normal? Is this... a flood?”

Ms. Thuraya appeared at the door, calm as always, holding her scarf.

She looked at the dripping ceiling, then at Sophia running around like a panicking chicken.

She smiled. “Relax. It’s rain.”

John froze. “Rain?”

Sophia stopped. “Rain?”

Then suddenly...

BOOOOM!

Thunder shook the house.

Sophia screamed. John screamed a little later.

Malood screamed too, but nobody knows why.

Thuraya laughed. “Welcome to Oman rain.”

They ran outside.

The village had changed.

The ground was dark and wet. The air smelled fresh and clean. Water was running in small lines everywhere. Children were already outside, jumping in mud like it was a festival.

Mansoor was the wettest person in the village and the happiest.

He jumped and shouted, “Maaaaaan! It’s raining! It’s really raining!”

Ali was standing carefully, watching the sky. “It’s beautiful.”

Noura lifted her face to the rain. “Cold! But nice!”

Ahmed was already worried. “My book... my book is getting wet...”

Khalil threw a stone into a big muddy puddle. “Look! River!”

Sophia stood under the rain, holding a bowl on her head.

“This is... wonderful,” she said. “And my hair is already ruined.”

Another loud **THUNDER**.

John jumped again. “The sky is angry.”

Thuraya pointed. “Look.”

They all looked.

Far away, between the mountains, something big and brown was moving.

Ali shouted, “Halaaaa! The wadi is coming down!”

The **wadi**.

A wide riverbed that was usually dry.

Now it was full.

Full of fast, brown, strong water.

John stared. “That is not a river. That is a moving mountain.”

Sophia whispered, “It’s beautiful... and scary.”

Thuraya nodded. “When the wadi comes like this, it means good rain in the mountains.”

She smiled. “It also means... we can go to **Tawi Zahir**.”

The children’s eyes lit up.

Mansoor shouted, “Swimming!”

Noura shouted, “Picnic!”

Khalil shouted, “No school!”

Ahmed shouted, “Careful!”

John blinked. “What is Tawi Zahir?”

Thuraya explained, “It’s a place where clean water stays after the rain. Pools. Clear water. People go to swim, wash, relax.”

Sophia clapped. “A trip!”

John was already excited. “A trip!”

Thunder answered again. **BOOM**.

Malood ran between their legs and almost killed everyone.

In the Classroom (Later That Day)

The rain stopped. The sky became clean and blue. The mountains looked washed.

The air smelled like new beginnings.

In class, everyone was still talking about the rain.

John wrote on the board:

WEATHER

Then under it:

sun – rain – thunder – lightning – hot – cold – cloudy – rainbow – wadi

He turned around. “Today, we talk about the weather.”

Sophia added, “And about what we were doing.”

John wrote:

PAST CONTINUOUS

I was... / He was... / They were... + verb-ing

He pointed at Mansoor. “Mansoor. What were you doing when it started raining?”

Mansoor stood proudly. “I was... jumping.”

John smiled. “Good. You were jumping.”

He pointed to Noura. “And you?”

Noura thought. “I was... running.”

“Excellent.”

He pointed to Sophia. “And you, Sophia?”

Sophia laughed. “I was putting bowls under the roof.”

The class laughed.

John pointed to himself. "I was sleeping."

The class laughed more.

Thuraya helped. "Say: The children were playing. The rain was falling. The wadi was coming down."

Ali raised his hand. "Teacher... the rainbow?"

Outside, a **rainbow** was slowly appearing.

Everyone ran to the window.

"Wow..."

"Look!"

"Two colors!"

"No, many colors!"

John smiled. "Rainbow. When rain and sun meet."

Sophia whispered, "That is... poetry."

John cleared his throat and went back to teaching.

He wrote:

When it started raining...

I was...

They practiced:

- When it started raining, I was sleeping.
- When it started raining, I was playing.
- When it started raining, I was eating.

Saeed was quiet. Then he raised his hand.

"When it started raining," he said slowly, "I was... watching."

Thuraya looked at him with soft eyes.

Planning the Trip

After school, everyone gathered outside.

The wadi was still running, loud and strong.

John said, “If the wadi is like this... Tawi Zahir must be amazing.”

Thuraya nodded. “We should go tomorrow.”

Sophia clapped again. “Yes! A real Omani picnic!”

They went to see Uncle Nasser.

He stood next to his pickup, drinking tea.

“You want to go Tawi Zahir?” he asked. “Tomorrow? Good. I will take you.”

Mansoor jumped. “With the pickup?”

“Yes.”

Mansoor jumped more.

They started planning:

- Who brings food?
- Who brings water?
- Who brings firewood?

Sophia and Thuraya decided to cook.

John decided to “help” (which worried everyone).

The children ran to tell their families.

Soon, people started coming.

Rahma’s mother.

Marwa’s aunt.

Salimah’s brothers.

Even Uncle Marhoon said, “I will bring meat.”

John’s eyes became big. “Meat?”

“Meshkak,” Marhoon said proudly.

Malood heard the word “food” and followed him immediately.

The Village After Rain

That evening, Samail was different.

Everything was green. Clean. Fresh.

Birds were singing like they were paid for it.

The mountains looked closer.

The air was cool.

Sophia stood outside the house, breathing deeply. “This is... the most beautiful day since we came.”

John nodded. “I think Oman is showing us its secret.”

They looked at the wadi one more time.

It was still running.

Strong.

Loud.

Alive.

Thuraya said quietly, “Tomorrow... Tawi Zahir.”

Mansoor shouted from far away, “Teacher! I am bringing my swimming clothes!”

John shouted back, “Good! I am bringing... courage!”

Sophia laughed. “You will need it.”

Malood ran past them, slipped in the mud, stood up, and continued like nothing happened.

John looked at him. “You... are not normal.”

Malood answered by eating a leaf.

, Story 27: “Pools, Smoke, and a Very Busy Day” (Tawi Zahir, 1973)

The pickup truck was already making noise before the sun finished waking up.

Uncle Nasser was proud of his engine, even if it sounded like it was arguing with itself.

John and Sophia stood in the back, holding the side carefully.

Sophia whispered, “If I fall, please tell my mother I tried.”

John answered bravely, “If you fall, I fall with you.”

Ms. Thuraya sat in the front, calm and confident, like always.

Behind them came the children, full of noise and excitement.

Mansoor was jumping without moving.

“We are going! We are going! We are really going!”

Ahmed was checking the bags. “Food is here. Water is here. Plates are here. Good.”

Khalil was already planning trouble.

Malood was there too, because Malood was always there.

The road was dusty, then rocky, then suddenly green.

When they reached **Tawi Zahir**, everyone became quiet.

The place was beautiful.

Small clear pools of water were between rocks. Palm trees were around. The air was cool and fresh. Birds were singing like they were welcoming guests.

Sophia covered her mouth. “This is... a dream.”

John looked at the water. “This is... cold.”

The children did not care.

Mansoor was already taking off his shoes.

Ali shouted, “Swimming!”

Noura shouted, “Wait!”

Khalil shouted, “Last one is a chicken!”

And suddenly, everyone was running.

Thuraya clapped her hands. “Careful! Don’t run on the rocks!”

Nobody listened.

Setting Up the Picnic

The families arrived slowly.

Rahma’s mother.

Marwa’s aunt.

Salimah’s brothers.

Even Uncle Marhoon came, carrying a bag of meat.

“Meshkak,” he said proudly.

John’s eyes became happy immediately.

Sophia and Thuraya started working.

They put stones in a circle. They brought firewood. They started the fire.

Sophia was cutting vegetables.

Thuraya was washing rice.

They were both very serious.

John walked around like a boss.

“I am... supervising,” he said.

Thuraya looked at him. “You are in the way.”

John moved.

Malood moved too.

Unfortunately, Malood moved **into** the food bag.

“NO!” Sophia shouted.

Malood ran away with something green in his mouth.

John chased him. “Come back here, criminal!”

The children laughed.

In the Water

The boys were already in the pools.

Ali was swimming calmly.

Mansoor was jumping again and again.

Khalil was splashing everyone.

Ahmed was sitting at the side, touching the water carefully.

“It’s cold,” he said.

“Yes,” Mansoor answered. “That’s the point.”

John put one foot in.

Then he took it out.

Then he put it again.

Then he took it out again.

Sophia laughed. “You are not swimming. You are negotiating.”

Finally, John jumped.

He screamed.

Everyone clapped.

“I am alive!” he announced.

The Lesson Without a Blackboard

Thuraya looked at Sophia and smiled.

“Let’s teach them something.”

Sophia nodded.

She stood and said loudly, “Okay! English time!”

The children groaned a little, but they came.

John stood next to her.

He said, “Today... we use **Present Continuous**.”

He said slowly and clearly:

“I am swimming.”

“He is swimming.”

“They are swimming.”

He pointed at Ali. “Ali, what are you doing?”

Ali answered, “I am swimming.”

“Good!”

He pointed at Mansoor. “Mansoor?”

Mansoor shouted, “I am jumping!”

“Excellent.”

He pointed at Sophia. “Sophia?”

She said proudly, “I am cooking.”

Thuraya added, “I am washing.”

They pointed at Uncle Marhoon.

“What is he doing?”

The children laughed. “He is cooking meat!”

“He is making meshkak!”

John wrote in the sand with a stick:

I am... / He is... / They are... + verb-ing

Khalil raised his hand. “Teacher... Malood?”

Everyone looked.

Malood was eating leaves from a bag.

John sighed. “Malood is... always eating.”

They all repeated: “Malood is always eating.”

Disaster Number One

Sophia was mixing something in a pot.

She tasted it.

Her face changed.

She ran to the water.

“HOT! HOT! VERY HOT!”

She was fanning her mouth.

Thuraya tasted it.

She laughed. “You put too much chili.”

John tasted it.

He did not speak.

He just opened his mouth and stood in front of the wind.

The children copied him.

Soon, John, Sophia, and three students were standing in a line, mouths open, facing the air.

Mansoor said, “You look like fish.”

Disaster Number Two

The meshkak was ready.

Uncle Marhoon was proud.

John ate one.

Then another.

Then another.

Sophia said, “Slowly.”

John said, “I am enjoying Oman.”

Malood tried to steal one.

He failed.

He tried again.

He succeeded.

And ran.

John shouted, “That goat is impossible!”

The Afternoon

People sat. Talked. Laughed.

Some were swimming.

Some were sleeping.

Some were eating.

The children kept practicing English without knowing.

“I am swimming!”
“I am eating!”
“He is sleeping!”
“They are playing!”

Saeed was sitting on a rock, watching.

Thuraya went to him. “What are you doing?”

He smiled shyly. “I am... thinking.”

She smiled back.

Time to Go Back

The sun started to go down.

Everyone was tired and happy.

They cleaned the place.

They packed everything.

John looked at the pools one more time. “This is... one of the best days of my life.”

Sophia nodded. “Mine too.”

Malood was sleeping inside a bag.

Nobody knew how he got there.

“The Camera, the Tools, and the Fastest Goat in Samail” (1973)

The classroom was unusually quiet.

Not because Mansoor was absent.

Not because Khalil was sleeping.

But because John was standing near the blackboard with a very serious face and a very important-looking bag.

Sophia sat next to Thuraya, watching him with a small smile.

“Today,” John said, slowly and proudly, “we have... something special.”

The children leaned forward.

Mansoor whispered, “Maybe sweets.”

Ahmed whispered, “Maybe books.”

Khalil whispered, “Maybe trouble.”

John opened the bag carefully... and took out a black camera.

The class exploded.

“Aboooooy!”

“What is that?”

“Does it bite?”

“Is it a radio?”

Sophia laughed. “No, no. This is a camera.”

Ali raised his hand. “Teacher... it steals faces?”

John blinked. “No. It... keeps memories.”

He lifted it and looked through it.

CLICK.

The sound alone made half the class jump.

Mansoor shouted, “It shot me!”

Thuraya laughed. “It’s not a gun. It’s a camera.”

John wrote on the board:

We use ... for ...

He turned around. “Repeat: We use...”

The class: “We use...”

He pointed at the camera. “We use a camera for...?”

Ahmed thought carefully. “For... taking pictures.”

“Excellent!”

John smiled and wrote:

We use a camera for taking pictures.

Then Thuraya stood up and brought a small basket.

Inside were strange things.

She took out a **ma‘wal** (hoe).

“We use a ma‘wal for...?”

Ali said proudly, “For farming.”

Then she took out a **heeb** (small sickle).

“And this?”

Noura said, “For cutting grass.”

Then came the **majz**.

Some students laughed.

“We use a majz for... cutting and... treatment,” Thuraya said carefully.

John nodded slowly. “Oman has... very brave medicine.”

Then came the **mowqa‘a** (garlic crusher).

Sophia pressed it and the class laughed.

“We use this for garlic!”

Then a **silver kohl stick**.

“We use this for... eyes.”

Then a **marjal** (big pot).

Then a **qafeer** (basket).

The board was full:

We use a ma‘wal for farming.

We use a heeb for cutting grass.

We use a majz for cutting.

We use a camera for taking pictures.

John was very happy.

“This is... a perfect lesson.”

That was the moment Malood chose to become famous.

Nobody knew how.

Nobody saw how.

But suddenly, the camera was **not in John’s hand**.

It was in Malood’s mouth.

Malood turned.

Malood ran.

Sophia screamed. “THE CAMERA!”

John shouted. “STOP THAT GOAT!”

The class exploded into chaos.

Mansoor ran first.

Then Khalil.

Then Ali.

Then half the class.

Malood ran like a champion.

He jumped over a bag.

He passed under a table.

He escaped through the door.

Everyone followed.

In the yard, Malood ran in circles.

John ran after him, holding his bag.

Sophia ran after John.

Thuraya ran after Sophia.

Ahmed ran after everyone, still holding a notebook.

And then...

A hero appeared.

Sadou.

Sadou the shop owner.

He was passing by, carrying a box.

He saw the goat.

He saw the camera.

He understood everything in one second.

He put the box down.

He opened his arms.

Malood ran straight into him.

Sadou caught him like a football.

The yard clapped.

John arrived, breathing like he ran from Britain.

He took the camera and hugged it.

“Thank you, Sadou. You saved my memories.”

Sadou smiled proudly. “Malood always want be star.”

The class laughed.

That day, John took many pictures.

The students.

The tools.

Malood.

Mansoor jumping.

Khalil making faces.

Ahmed fixing his hair.

Even Thuraya, secretly.

That Evening

In the house, the lights were low.

The windows were closed.

The room was dark.

John was very serious.

“This,” he said, “is the darkroom.”

Sophia held a paper carefully.

Thuraya watched with curiosity.

They put the paper in liquid.

Nothing.

Then slowly...

A face appeared.

Sophia gasped. “It’s Mansoor!”

Then another.

“It’s Malood!”

Then another.

“It’s you!” Thuraya laughed.

They hung the photos to dry.

The wall was full of memories.

John sat down, tired but happy.

“These,” he said, “are our days.”

Sophia smiled softly. “And we almost lost them to a goat.”

From outside, they heard:

“Me-e-e-e!”

John closed his eyes. “That goat will be in every picture.”

Story 29: The Day Nobody Spoke Arabic

(Samail, 1973)

The classroom was louder than usual.

Not because the students were talking.
Because the fan was.

It stood in the corner, shaking like it had a fever, making a tired sound:
rrrrrrrrrr... rrrrrrrr...

John stood near his desk, holding a big envelope like it was a treasure chest.

Sophia stood next to him, trying very hard not to smile.

Thuraya leaned against the wall, arms crossed, watching the students' faces.

All the children were sitting... very... very... straight.

Malood was also in the classroom.

Nobody knew how he entered.

Nobody questioned it anymore.

Malood sat near the window like a student who failed many years but never left school.

John cleared his throat.

"Today," he said slowly, "is a very special day."

The students looked at the envelope.

Mansoor whispered, "Pictures?"

John raised one finger. "Yes. But... there is a rule."

Everyone leaned forward.

"No Arabic," John said seriously. "Only English. If anyone speaks Arabic..."

He pointed at the door.

"...outside."

The classroom froze.

Ali swallowed.

Noura put her hand over her mouth.

Khalil looked like he was preparing for war.

Ahmed sat straight like a ruler, ready.

Saeed was quiet, watching everything carefully.

Matla smiled confidently.

Rahma and Salma looked at each other, nervous.

Marwa whispered, “Oh no.”

John wrote on the board in big letters:

ENGLISH ONLY TODAY

Then he added:

This is... / He is... / She is...

Sophia clapped her hands. “Okay! Who wants to start?”

Silence.

Even Malood was silent.

John opened the envelope and took out the first photo.

He lifted it.

It was Malood.

Malood in the yard.

Malood on the table.

Malood in front of the door.

Malood eating.

Malood sleeping.

Malood was everywhere.

The class exploded with laughter.

John smiled. “Okay. Who?”

Mansoor jumped up. “Me! Me!”

John nodded. “English.”

Mansoor took a deep breath. “This is... Malood.”

John clapped. “Good! Very good!”

Mansoor pointed at the picture. “He is... he is... eating!”

Sophia added, “Yes! He is eating.”

Malood looked proud.

The next photo.

It was Sheikh Khalaf.

He was standing near his clay house, throwing smoke in the air, doing **maghbar**.

Some students gasped.

Ali whispered in Arabic, “... هوّه.”

John pointed. “Outside.”

Ali froze. “No no no! Sorry! Sorry!”

He tried again, slowly: “This is... Sheikh Khalaf.”

Thuraya smiled. “Good.”

Khalil added, “He is... making smoke.”

John nodded. “Yes. He is making smoke.”

Sophia explained, “In English: He is doing something. He is making something.”

Thuraya added in Arabic, then translated, “They used to do this to chase bad luck.”

The next photo.

John.

His eyes were red and swollen.

Dust on his face.

Looking like a very tired ghost.

The class laughed again.

Noura raised her hand. “Teacher... English.”

She stood. “This is... Mr. John.”

She pointed at his eyes. “He is... not happy.”

The class laughed more.

John sighed. “He was not happy.”

Ahmed corrected politely, “He **was** not happy.”

John looked at him. “Thank you, Ahmed.”

The next photo.

Sophia and Fatkat.

Both of them.

Yellow.

Very yellow.

Like lemons.

Fatkat’s mouth was open in shock.

Sophia was trying to smile.

The class fell on the floor laughing.

Marwa stood up. “This is... Miss Sophia and Miss Fatkat.”

She thought. “They are... yellow.”

Fatkat, who was standing near the door, shouted in Arabic, “يا شيخة فضيحة”

Sophia laughed. “Skin care.”

Thuraya added, laughing, “But the skin doesn’t care.”

Even Mohammadeen, passing by the door, laughed and said, “والله عاملين زي الليمون”

The next photos.

One by one.

Ali holding a fish.

Khalil making a silly face.

Matla standing like a queen.

Rahma and Salma together, shy.

Marwa falling near the falaj.

Noura pointing at something and shouting.

Saeed in the corner of many photos, watching.

Always watching.

Ahmed helping others.

Mansoor... in almost every picture... running.

Each student stood and said something:

“This is Ali.”

“He is holding a fish.”

“This is Matla.”

“She is standing.”

“This is Khalil.”

“He is... uh... funny.”

Sometimes they made mistakes.

Sometimes they stopped and thought.

Sometimes Ahmed helped.

Sometimes Thuraya helped.

But nobody spoke Arabic.

Not even Malood.

Malood only made a “meeeeh” sound.

Then John showed a photo.

It was Sadoo.

Holding Malood like a hero.

Sophia said, “This is Sadoo. He is saving the camera.”

John nodded. “Yes. Very brave.”

Then one more photo.

It was taken secretly.

The class in the shop.

The class in the street.

The class playing.

The class running.

The students stared.

Matla asked in English, slowly, “Teacher... when?”

Thuraya smiled. “He took them secretly.”

The class looked at John.

John pretended to be innocent.

“I am a photographer,” he said proudly.

The bell rang.

Drrrrrrrrriiiiiing!

Everyone jumped.

Mansoor shouted, “Tlaagah!”

Rabaa, the Tunisian music teacher, who was passing by, screamed, “Ya Rab! Who shot?!”

Thuraya laughed. “Not gun. School finish.”

Rabaa held her heart. “You scared me!”

The students ran out.

Shouting.

Laughing.

Singing:

“Ya saeeegna dooos dooos
Allah yeb‘ath lak arooos!”

John sat on his chair, tired but happy.

Sophia sat next to him. “Today... they spoke English.”

Thuraya smiled. “And nobody died.”

Malood jumped on the desk and tried to eat a photo.

John shouted, “No!”

Malood ran.

Everyone laughed.

Outside, Saeed stood for a moment.

Looking at the classroom.

Looking at the photos.

Then he smiled.

And ran after the others.

Story 30: The Detective Game – The Missing Treasure

Samail, 1973

The classroom was unusually quiet.

Not because the students were well-behaved. No. That almost never happened.

It was quiet because Ms. Thuraya was smiling.

And when Ms. Thuraya smiled like that, something dangerous was coming.

John was standing near the blackboard, holding a piece of chalk. Sophia was sitting at the small teacher's desk, fixing her notebook. Mohammadeen was leaning against the wall with his arms crossed, and Fatkat was fanning herself with a book.

Malood, the baby goat, was sitting near the window, chewing something that nobody wanted to know the name of.

Thuraya clapped her hands once.

"Today," she said in English, "we will not sit and write."

The students' eyes lit up.

Mansoor almost fell from his chair. "Teacher... we go home?"

John laughed. "No, Mansoor. Worse."

The class groaned.

Thuraya continued, "Today, we play a game."

Now the class exploded.

"A game?" Noura said.

"A real game?" Marwa asked.

"A running game?" Mansoor shouted.

Thuraya raised her hand. "A detective game."

She went to her bag and took out a big, old-looking paper. She opened it carefully.

It was a map.

"This," she said, "is the map of today's mystery."

Sophia leaned forward. "Oh, I like this already."

John looked at the map seriously. "Is there... danger?"

Thuraya smiled innocently. "Always."

The students came closer. Even Ahmed left his perfect straight sitting position and leaned forward.

“Somewhere,” Thuraya said, pointing to a drawing of a tall palm tree, “there is a **treasure**.”

“Treasure?” Khalil whispered dramatically.

“Yes. But it is missing.”

Mansoor stood up. “Who stole it?”

Thuraya looked at Malood.

Malood blinked.

Everyone laughed.

“No,” Thuraya said. “The treasure is not stolen. It is hidden. And you must find it.”

John clapped his hands. “Okay! Today’s lesson is **instructions**.”

He wrote on the board:

Go straight
Turn left
Turn right
Stop
Don’t run
Look under...
Look behind...

Sophia added, “And remember: **Only English**.”

The students looked at each other in fear.

Mohammadeen lifted his stick slowly. “Today... I also speak only English.”

The class went silent.

Fatkat smiled sweetly. “Good luck, my children.”

Thuraya divided them into two teams.

“Team One,” she said, “the boys.”

The boys cheered.

“Team Two, the girls.”

The girls cheered louder.

“Team One leader,” Thuraya said, “is Mr. John and Mr. Mohammadeen.”

John saluted. Mohammadeen nodded seriously.

“Team Two leader is Sophia and Fatkat.”

Sophia smiled proudly. Fatkat cracked her knuckles.

“And Malood,” Thuraya added, “is with me. For safety.”

Malood made a small sound that meant: *I will still cause problems.*

They went outside.

The village was warm. The sun was high. The palm trees were quiet, like they were watching the show.

Thuraya gave each team a paper.

“Follow the instructions,” she said. “Don’t cheat. Don’t fight. And don’t die.”

John looked worried. “Is that last one part of the rules?”

“Yes,” Thuraya said.

The game started.

The First Station: The Old Wall

Team One ran.

“No running!” Mohammadeen shouted.

They walked fast instead.

Ahmed read the paper: “Go straight. Stop at the old wall. Look under the stone.”

Mansoor jumped. “I found it!”

It was another paper.

Khalil read it: “Turn right. Walk ten steps. Look behind the tree.”

Meanwhile, Team Two was also moving.

Sophia was reading: “Go left. Stop near the falaj. Don’t touch the water.”

Fatkat laughed. “Why always don’t touch, don’t touch?”

They found their next paper near a rock.

Marwa read slowly, “Go... straight... until... you see... a house.”

Noura pointed. “That one?”

But when they arrived, everyone stopped.

It was **the house of Shayb Khalaf**.

The air suddenly felt... colder.

“Why here?” Salima whispered.

Fatkat swallowed. “Who made this map?”

Thuraya, far away, was pretending not to see anything.

The door of the house was closed.

“Look under the tree,” Sophia said.

They ran, found the paper, and ran away very fast.

Nobody wanted to stay there.

The Second Station: The Pickup Truck

Team One arrived near Uncle Nasser’s pickup.

He was sitting and drinking tea.

“What are you doing?” he asked.

John smiled. “Learning English.”

Uncle Nasser nodded like that explained everything.

The paper said: “Ask the driver. Then go behind the fence.”

Mohammadeen tried. “Please... sir... where is... the fence?”

Uncle Nasser laughed. “Behind you, ya ustadh.”

They went, found another paper.

The Third Station: The Bees

Team Two arrived near a big tree.

They heard a sound.

Bzzzzzz.

Fatkat stopped. “No. No. No. I know this sound.”

Sophia read the paper: “Look near the tree.”

The girls looked at each other.

Mansoor’s voice came from far away. “Maybe it is empty!”

Then they heard him scream.

“BEEEEES!”

Everyone ran.

The bees stayed where they were.

Thuraya wrote something in her notebook: *Good drama.*

The Discovery

Both teams arrived near the big palm tree called **Palm Al-Fard**.

Team Two arrived first.

Noura looked up. “There!”

High, very high, was a small bag.

Fatkat clapped. “We win!”

Sophia looked worried. “How do we get it?”

They waited.

Team One arrived.

Khalil looked up. “It’s too high.”

John scratched his head. “We need a hero.”

Thuraya walked slowly to them.

“So,” she said, “you found it. But...”

“But?” Mansoor asked.

“But the game is not finished.”

She smiled. “The treasure is there. But **how** will you get it?”

Everyone looked up.

Very high.

Too high.

Inside the bag, something moved.

Mansoor whispered, “Maybe it is a snake.”

John stepped back. “Then the game is finished.”

Thuraya laughed. “No, no. It is food.”

Sophia looked at Fatkat. “Food?”

Thuraya nodded. “Honey. And ghee.”

The students cheered.

Mohammadeen rubbed his hands. “Healthy food.”

John looked at the tree. “We need... someone who can climb.”

Everyone slowly turned.

Toward one direction.

The road.

Footsteps.

A voice.

“Who needs help?”

Sadou was standing there, carrying a bag and smiling like he knew everything.

Thuraya closed her notebook.

She looked at both teams.

“Tomorrow,” she said, “we will continue.”

The students shouted.

“Tomorrow?!”

“Yes,” Thuraya said. “Because tomorrow... you will learn how to **ask** and **promise**.”

She looked at Sadou.

“And maybe... how to convince.”

Sadou smiled bigger.

Malood suddenly ran to the tree and tried to climb.

He failed.

Everyone laughed.

John looked at the tree, then at Sadou, then at the class.

“Tomorrow,” he said seriously, “will be dangerous.”

Far away, from the shade of another tree, a thin shadow moved.

Someone was watching.

Someone old.

Someone quiet.

The door of Shayb Khalaf's house closed slowly.

To be continued in Story 31...

Story 31: Convincing Sadou

Samail, 1973

The next morning, everyone arrived at school early.

Too early.

Even Ahmed.

Even Mansoor.

Even Malood.

The reason was simple.

The treasure.

Honey and ghee were still hanging on Palm Al-Fard like a royal secret that refused to come down.

John stood in front of the class and wrote in big letters:

I WILL

He turned around and said, "Today, we learn how to **promise**."

Sophia added, “And how to **ask nicely**.”

Mohammadeen crossed his arms. “And how to **not fight**.”

Fatkat smiled. “And how to **not cry**.”

Mansoor looked worried.

Thuraya clapped her hands. “Today’s hero is... Sadou.”

The students cheered.

Outside, Sadou was sitting in the shade, fixing something with a small knife, looking very proud of himself.

Malood was standing near him, staring at him like he was planning a crime.

Thuraya took the class outside.

Sadou looked up. “Ah. The English army.”

John smiled. “Good morning, Sadou.”

Sadou nodded. “Morning... mister teacher... mister long.”

The students laughed.

John pointed to the palm tree. “We need your help.”

Sadou looked up. “Aha. The bag.”

Sophia stepped forward. “Inside the bag is honey and ghee.”

Sadou’s eyes became a little brighter.

Fatkat whispered, “He is interested.”

Thuraya said, “But Sadou, we cannot climb.”

Sadou crossed his arms. “And?”

John took a deep breath. “We want **you** to climb and get it.”

Sadou looked at the class. Then at the tree. Then at Malood.

“No.”

Everyone froze.

“No?” Mansoor shouted. “Why no?!”

Sadou smiled. “Because.”

Khalil whispered, “He is enjoying this.”

Thuraya smiled slowly. “Okay. Let’s begin the lesson.”

She turned to the students. “Remember the sentence?”

The students shouted together, “**I will!**”

John nodded. “Good. Now... we try.”

The Great Persuasion

Noura was the first.

She walked to Sadou and said carefully, “Sadou... **I will give you samboosa.**”

Sadou didn’t even look at her. “No.”

The girls gasped.

Ali tried next. “Sadou... **I will give you bakoorah.**”

Sadou shook his head. “No.”

Marwa said, “**I will give you dates.**”

“No.”

Rahma tried, “**I will give you bread.**”

“No.”

Salima said, “**I will give you tea.**”

Sadou smiled. “I don’t like tea.”

The boys started.

Khalil said, **“I will give you fish.”**

Sadou laughed. “No.”

Ahmed said politely, **“I will help you in the shop.”**

Sadou looked at him. “For how long?”

Ahmed froze. “One... day?”

Sadou shook his head. “No.”

Mansoor jumped forward. **“I will give you Malood!”**

Everyone screamed.

Malood screamed louder.

Thuraya shouted, “NO!”

Sadou laughed so hard he almost fell. “I don’t want this trouble.”

Malood looked offended.

Sophia sighed. “Nothing works.”

Mohammadeen said, “In Egypt, we solve this with shouting.”

Fatkat nodded. “And sometimes shoes.”

John was thinking very hard.

He looked at the class.

Then at Sadou.

Then at the tree.

Then at Saeed.

Saeed was standing quietly, watching everything.

John walked to him and whispered something in his ear.

Saeed’s eyes became wide.

He smiled slowly.

Then he walked to Sadou.

Everyone became quiet.

Saeed looked up and said in his simple English:

“Sadou... **I will give you... chilli. Very hot.**”

The class froze.

Thuraya corrected quickly, “Chilli, not filfil yohroak.”

Everyone laughed.

Sadou’s eyes opened wide.

“Chilli?”

Saeed nodded seriously. “Yes. Big chilli. Very strong.”

Sadou’s face changed.

A slow, dangerous smile appeared.

“You have chilli?”

Saeed nodded.

Sadou stood up. “Why you not say this from beginning?”

The class exploded.

“He agreed!”

“He agreed!”

“We win!”

But Fatkat shouted, “Wait! Which team wins?”

The girls crossed their arms.

The boys crossed their arms.

Thuraya raised her hand. “Both teams found the treasure. But...”

She smiled.

“The boys convinced Sadou.”

The girls groaned.

Mansoor danced.

The Great Climb

Sadou tied his cloth tighter around his waist.

He looked at the palm tree.

He cracked his fingers.

Then he started climbing like a cat.

Up.

Up.

Up.

The students looked with open mouths.

Sophia whispered, “He is not human.”

John whispered, “He is... many talents.”

In one minute, Sadou reached the top.

He took the bag.

He looked down.

“Ready?”

“YES!” everyone shouted.

He threw the bag.

Mohammadeen tried to catch it.

He missed.

Fatkat tried.

She missed.

Malood jumped.

The bag hit Malood.

Malood fell.

The bag opened.

The honey jar rolled.

The ghee jar rolled.

Everyone screamed.

John ran.

Thuraya ran.

Mansoor ran.

Somehow, nothing broke.

They all sat on the ground, breathing like they ran a marathon.

Sophia looked at the jars. “We are alive.”

The Celebration

They went back to school.

In the classroom, Thuraya put the jars on the table.

“Today’s lesson,” she said, “is **Healthy Food.**”

John wrote on the board:

Honey is healthy.
Ghee is healthy.
Too much sugar is not healthy.

Mansoor raised his hand. “Teacher... honey and ghee... together?”

Fatkat laughed. “That is not a lesson. That is a crime.”

They made small bread and tasted a little.

John closed his eyes. “Now I understand... why Omani men have big belly.”

Thuraya shouted, “It’s good for wearing khanjar!”

Sophia laughed. “What is khanjar?”

Everyone started talking at the same time.

Sadou stood at the door.

Saeed gave him a small chilli.

Sadou smiled.

Then he bit it.

Then he screamed.

Then he ran.

Everyone laughed.

The Ending

In the afternoon, when the class was empty, Thuraya wrote in her notebook:

“Today, they learned how to promise.
And how to convince.
And how to work together.”

Far away, near the old house, a shadow watched.

Shayb Khalaf.

Story 32 (Samail, 1973)

“Under the Palm Tree: We Must and We Mustn’t”

Target Language: *must / mustn’t* (rules, advice, responsibility)

Setting: Under the big palm tree near the school, late morning, chalkboard on a wooden stand, fan noise from a nearby classroom.

The sun in Samail did not “shine.” It *punched*.

It was the kind of heat that made even the palm leaves look tired. The school yard felt quiet, but not because the children were calm. It was quiet because everyone was trying to save their energy for later, like camels storing water.

Mr. John walked slowly across the yard holding a small chalkboard. His face was serious, like he was carrying something very important.

Sophia (and yes, the village still called her “Safiya”) followed him with a notebook, a water bottle, and the expression of a woman who had accepted that Oman was going to roast her politely every single day.

Ms. Thuraya was already under the palm tree, sitting on a woven mat. Her chalk was ready. Her eyes were ready. Her teacher-heart was very, very ready.

A small shadow ran between their feet.

Malood.

The baby goat stopped, stared at John’s chalkboard like it personally offended him, and then tried to nibble the corner.

“Malood,” John said slowly, “this is not salad.”

Malood chewed anyway.

Thuraya clapped once. “Okay, class! Sit down. Circle. Under the palm tree. Today we speak English.”

The students came running in a messy line: Ali, Ahmed, Khalil, Noura, Marwa, Rahma, Salimah, Matla, Mansoor... and a few smaller children who always followed behind like curious birds.

They sat down, legs crossed, backs half-straight, eyes shining. Some held notebooks. Some held nothing but confidence.

John placed the chalkboard on a wooden stand, wiped the sweat from his forehead, and wrote in big letters:

WE MUST / WE MUSTN'T

Sophia nodded proudly. "This lesson is important."

Thuraya smiled. "Also... it will be funny."

John turned to the class. "Today... we do something brave."

The students leaned in.

John pointed to himself. "I will start. I confess."

The children gasped like he said he stole a camel.

John took a deep breath. "Yesterday... I tried to carry a bucket of water... and I spilled it on my shoe."

The class stared.

Then Mansoor whispered loudly, "That's it?"

Everyone laughed. John sighed. "Okay. Not a big crime. But today, we practice speaking. We practice honesty."

Thuraya added softly, "Sometimes we learn English with our mistakes."

Sophia clapped once. "Yes! Today you say: *I did... and I feel...* Then we say: **We must...** or **We mustn't...**"

John nodded. "Exactly."

He pointed to the board. "Repeat after me."

He spoke clearly, slowly:

"We must tell the truth."

The class echoed:

"We must tell the truth."

John smiled. "Good. Now... who will confess first?"

Silence.

A dramatic silence.

Then Khalil raised his hand. His face looked innocent, which was always a dangerous sign.

Thuraya narrowed her eyes. “Khalil... what did you do?”

Khalil stood up, hands behind his back, trying to look like a serious man in a tiny body.

“I... I did... a bad thing.”

John encouraged him. “Say: *I did a bad thing.*”

Khalil repeated, proud: “I did a bad thing.”

He pointed to the classroom door with one finger, like he was showing evidence in court.

“Yesterday... Teacher Thuraya... she came... to open the door.”

Thuraya already knew.

Sophia already knew too. She leaned forward with interest. “Oh no.”

Khalil continued. “And I put... a bucket... above the door.”

Mansoor exploded laughing before he could stop himself.

Thuraya gasped. “You!”

Khalil lifted his chin. “And water... went... *BOOSH*... on her head.”

The whole group laughed, even the younger kids who didn’t fully understand. They laughed because Khalil’s “BOOSH” was too perfect.

Thuraya tried to look angry, but her mouth betrayed her. The corner of her lips twitched.

John held up his hand. “Okay! Now we use must and mustn’t.”

He wrote quickly:

We mustn’t play dangerous jokes.

We must respect our teachers.

He looked at Khalil. “Repeat: We mustn’t play dangerous jokes.”

Khalil repeated, careful: “We mustn’t play dangerous jokes.”

John nodded. “Good. And: We must respect our teachers.”

The students echoed it like a chant.

Thuraya folded her arms. “Khalil... you hear?”

Khalil nodded fast. “Yes teacher. Last time.”

Malood bleated loudly, like he was adding his own opinion.

Sophia laughed. “Even Malood agrees.”

John pointed to the class again. “Next confession.”

Mansoor raised his hand before anyone else could breathe. He stood up so fast he almost tripped over Rahma’s notebook.

His eyes were wide, face dramatic. Mansoor always looked like life was happening to him loudly.

“I... I confess,” he said, in broken English, but brave.

John nodded kindly. “Good. Tell us.”

Mansoor swallowed. “I... go... to Sadoo shop.”

Thuraya’s eyes flicked toward him. “Uh-oh.”

Mansoor continued quickly, like he wanted to throw the words out and run away. “I take... Bob Jamid.”

Sophia blinked. “Bob... what?”

Thuraya whispered to her, “A cold drink. Fizzy.”

Mansoor nodded hard. “Yes! Cold! I take... without pay.”

The class made a sound: “OHHHH.”

Ahmed sat straight as a ruler, looking shocked. Ali raised his eyebrows like he was calculating the crime.

John stayed calm. “Okay. Now we say rules.”

He wrote:

We must pay for things.
We mustn't steal.

He spoke clearly. "Repeat: We must pay for things."

The class echoed.

"We mustn't steal."

The class echoed again, louder this time.

John looked at Mansoor. "Now you make a promise. Say: I mustn't steal again."

Mansoor breathed in deeply. "I mustn't... steal again."

Sophia added gently, "And you can fix it. You can say sorry."

Mansoor nodded like a soldier. "I say sorry to Sadoo."

Thuraya pointed at him. "And you pay."

Mansoor said quickly, "And I pay!"

The kids clapped because it felt like a happy ending.

Next, Noura raised her hand. Of course Noura did. She didn't just ask questions. She *lived* inside questions.

She stood up and said, "Teacher... I confess... I talk too much."

The class laughed because even Noura laughed at herself.

John smiled. "That is a good confession."

Noura added, "I... I don't stop."

Sophia nodded dramatically. "That is true."

Thuraya laughed. "Okay. Rule?"

John wrote:

We must listen.
We mustn't interrupt.

The students repeated, and Noura put her hand on her chest like she was taking an oath.

Then Rahma stood up, shy but determined.

“I confess... I broke... my sister’s comb.”

She looked down. “And I said... cat did it.”

Everyone giggled.

John wrote:

We must take responsibility.

We mustn’t blame others.

Rahma repeated the sentences softly and sat down looking lighter, like the confession took a stone out of her pocket.

One by one, they confessed.

- Marwa admitted she hid her homework under a mat so her mother wouldn’t see it.
- Salimah admitted she told her brother his ears were “too big” just to make him cry.
- Ali confessed he corrected people so much he sometimes sounded rude, and Ahmed quietly said, “That is true,” without smiling.
- Matla confessed she once kept two pencils when she promised to share, then offered the class her best pencil as “compensation,” like a tiny businesswoman.

Even the small children copied them, confessing strange little things:

“I eat sugar... before lunch.”

“I kick... a stone... to Mansoor.”

“I throw... date seed... at goat.”

Malood lifted his head proudly, as if he was the goat representative in the meeting.

Finally, John clapped his hands.

“Excellent. Today you used English for real life. You spoke truth. You learned rules.”

He pointed to the board and made them say the full set again, like a strong ending:

- We must tell the truth.
- We must respect our teachers.
- We must pay for things.
- We mustn’t steal.
- We must listen.

- We mustn't interrupt.

Sophia smiled at Thuraya. "This lesson is... powerful."

Thuraya nodded. "And funny."

John picked up the chalkboard. "Now... everyone go wash your hands."

The students repeated automatically, laughing: "We must wash our hands!"

Malood tried to bite the chalk again.

John pulled it away fast. "And we mustn't eat chalk!"

The children roared with laughter as the bell rang in the distance, thin and metallic.

"Tolqah!" someone shouted, and the students jumped up like springs, running toward the classroom, toward shade, toward the next little adventure.

Under the palm tree, Thuraya watched them go and whispered, almost to herself:

"They are learning English... but they are also learning how to be good humans."

Sophia leaned closer. "And Malood?"

Thuraya smiled. "Malood is learning... how to cause trouble in two languages."

John sighed. "That goat will become fluent before me."

And for once, even the palm leaves seemed to laugh quietly above them.

Story 33 (Samail, 1973)

"Under the Palm Tree Again: We Should and We Shouldn't"

Target Language: *should / shouldn't* (advice, good behavior, being proud of good actions)

Setting: Same big palm tree, late afternoon. The air is a little softer. Birds, warm light, quiet village sounds.

The afternoon in Samail had a different personality.

The sun was still hot, but not angry anymore. It was the kind of light that made the village look golden, like someone had painted everything with honey.

Under the big palm tree, the same woven mats were waiting.

Mr. John arrived first, carrying the chalkboard and a small cup of water. He looked at the tree and said, "This tree is becoming our second classroom."

Sophia smiled. "And a very windy one."

Ms. Thuraya came with her usual calm steps, and behind her came the students, laughing and talking, and of course...

Malood.

Malood walked like he owned the place.

He went straight to the mat, sat down, and started chewing something nobody knew the source of.

"Malood," John said tiredly, "you should not eat mystery food."

Malood did not care.

The students sat in a circle: Ali, Ahmed, Khalil, Noura, Marwa, Rahma, Salimah, Matla, Mansoor... and a few smaller ones who always followed like shadows.

Sophia clapped her hands. "Okay everyone. Yesterday we talked about bad things and rules. Today..."

John wrote in big letters:

WE SHOULD / WE SHOULDN'T

Thuraya smiled. "Today we talk about good things."

The students looked at each other. This felt... nicer.

John turned to them. "Yesterday you confessed bad things. Today you will tell us good things. Things you are proud of."

He pointed to himself. "I start."

He thought for a moment. "I am proud that... I learned how to drink Omani coffee without crying."

The class laughed.

Sophia added, “And you should stop putting three spoons of sugar in it.”

John nodded seriously. “Yes. I should.”

Thuraya said, “Now students. Who wants to start?”

Matla raised her hand immediately. She always did when the topic was generosity.

She stood up, very straight. “I am proud that... I give my pencils to Rahma when she forget.”

Sophia smiled. “Good! Say: I am proud that I **gave** my pencils.”

Matla repeated carefully, “I am proud that I gave my pencils.”

John wrote on the board:

We should help others.

The class repeated together: “We should help others.”

Rahma looked at Matla and whispered, “Thank you.”

Next, Ali stood up.

“I am proud that... I help my father read letters.”

John nodded, impressed. “Excellent.”

Thuraya added, “Many people need help with reading.”

John wrote:

We should help our family.

The students repeated it, and Ali sat down looking taller.

Then Ahmed stood up, hands behind his back like always.

“I am proud that... I do my homework... before playing.”

The class made a sound like, “Ooooooh.”

Mansoor whispered loudly, “Impossible.”

Everyone laughed.

John wrote:

We should do our homework before playing.

Mansoor looked at the ground like the sentence personally attacked him.

Then Marwa stood up, shy but smiling.

“I am proud that... I share my food with my little brother.”

Sophia nodded. “Good. Very good.”

She wrote on the board:

We should share.

Next, Noura stood up and said proudly, “I am proud that... yesterday... I did not talk too much.”

The class burst out laughing.

Thuraya said, “That is a very big achievement.”

John added jokingly, “You should do that again tomorrow.”

Noura laughed and sat down.

Then Mansoor stood up.

Everyone waited.

He scratched his head. “I am proud that... I did not steal today.”

The class clapped.

John smiled. “That is progress.”

He wrote:

We should be honest.

Then Khalil stood up and said, “I am proud that... I did not put any bucket today.”

Thuraya crossed her arms. “Good. Keep it like that.”

Now Sophia stepped forward. “Okay. Now we also say things we **shouldn’t** do.”

She wrote:

We shouldn’t hurt others.

We shouldn’t lie.

We shouldn’t laugh at people.

They repeated together.

The lesson was going perfectly.

Too perfectly.

That is when something green jumped.

A big green insect flew and landed...

On Sophia’s head.

For half a second, nobody moved.

Then Sophia screamed.

“Aaaaaaaaah!”

She jumped up, waving her arms. “Something is alive on my head! Something is ALIVE!”

The students froze... then laughed.

Thuraya ran to her. “Don’t move! Don’t move!”

Sophia ran anyway.

The insect fell on the mat.

Ali shouted, “Jaradah! Grasshopper!”

Sophia looked at it like it was a monster from another planet. “It is... huge!”

John tried to be brave. “It is just... an insect.”

The grasshopper jumped again.

Sophia screamed again and ran behind Thuraya.

“I should not come to Oman,” she said dramatically. “I should live in a fridge.”

The students were laughing so hard some of them were holding their stomachs.

Suddenly, a shadow fell over the group.

A familiar, thin, quiet figure appeared.

Shayb Khalaf.

The children gasped.

Some of them moved back.

He bent down calmly, picked up the grasshopper with his hand like it was nothing, and showed them... a bag.

A bag full of grasshoppers.

“Who wants mashawi?” he asked in a quiet voice.

Silence.

Absolute silence.

Sophia’s face turned white.

“You... you eat... that?” she asked slowly.

Thuraya nodded. “Yes. People grill them.”

Sophia put her hand on her mouth. “I should not ask questions in this country.”

Shayb Khalaf walked away like nothing happened.

The class was still shocked.

The lesson ended soon after, and everyone went home.

At John and Sophia’s House (Evening)

Sophia was still traumatized.

“I cannot believe people eat grasshoppers,” she said.

John was very quiet.

Too quiet.

They sat down to eat.

Thuraya brought food.

John chewed.

Sophia looked at him.

She stopped.

She leaned closer.

“...John.”

He looked at her innocently.

“...John, why is there a **wing**... here?”

She pointed at the corner of his mouth.

John froze.

He slowly wiped his mouth.

Looked at the napkin.

It was... a wing.

Sophia’s eyes became very big. “You ate it.”

John tried to lie. “No.”

Sophia crossed her arms. “John.”

He sighed. “...Yes.”

She screamed and ran to the sink.

“You ate mashawi grasshopper!”

John smiled, proud. “Actually... not bad.”

Sophia shouted from the kitchen. “You should see a doctor!”

John laughed. “You should try it!”

She almost threw a cup at him.

Story 34

Good Manners, Black Cats, and a Very Full Stomach

The invitation came in the morning.

Ms. Thuraya was holding a small folded paper when she entered the classroom, smiling in a special way.

“Today,” she said, “we are invited to lunch.”

The students’ eyes became big immediately.

“Where?” Mansoor asked.

“To the house of Al-Mu’allim Hamad,” Thuraya said. “The village Quran teacher.”

Sophia clapped her hands. “Oh! A real Omani lunch!”

John smiled politely, but his stomach smiled more.

Before they left, Sophia stood in front of the class and said, “Okay, today is not only about food. Today is about **etiquette**.”

She wrote the word on the board:

ETIQUETTE

John added under it:

- Wash your hands
- Sit properly
- Say “please” and “thank you”
- Don’t eat like Mansoor

Mansoor protested, “I eat normally!”

Ali whispered, “Like a camel.”

Sophia continued, “We should be polite guests.”

The class repeated: “We should be polite guests.”

Thuraya nodded. “Very important.”

On the Way

They walked in two groups.

Thuraya, Sophia, and Fatkat with the girls.

John and the boys in front.

The village was quiet. The sun was soft. The smell of bread was coming from somewhere far.

Suddenly, something black crossed the road.

A black cat.

The boys stopped.

Some of them stepped back.

Mansoor whispered, “Sennoor aswad...”

Khalil said, “Bad luck...”

Ali said, “Maybe sorcery...”

John looked at the cat and laughed. “In Britain, this is just... a cat.”

The black cat sat, looked at them, and walked away like a king.

John said jokingly, “Maybe this is Shayb Khalaf.”

The boys laughed.

Suddenly, a voice came from behind.

“Why you say that, John?”

Everyone jumped.

It was Shayb Khalaf himself.

Standing there.

Looking at John.

“I look like a cat now?” he asked calmly.

John’s face turned white.

“No, no, no, no... I mean... cat is... nice... and you are... also... nice?”

Shayb Khalaf smiled a small strange smile.

“Good,” he said. “Because cat don’t fear.”

He walked away slowly.

John looked around.

“Where did everyone go?”

The boys were already ten meters away.

Mansoor shouted, “We waiting you there, teacher!”

John ran after them. “You left me with him!”

The Other Group

Meanwhile...

Sophia, Thuraya, and Fatkat were walking with the girls.

Sophia suddenly stopped.

“Oh my God...”

She pointed to a wall.

“It is... so beautiful.”

Thuraya looked. “What?”

Sophia smiled. “The lizard!”

Thuraya’s face froze.

“Maah...”

She took two steps back.

“No. No. No.”

It was a small house lizard on the wall.

Fatkat said, “Ya satir... what is this disgusting thing?”

The girls started laughing.

Sophia walked closer happily. “It is cute!”

She took it gently in her hand.

The girls screamed.

“Throw it! Throw it!”

Sophia said, “Why? It is a living creature.”

Fatkat said, “The grasshopper also is a living creature, but you didn’t like it, right?”

Before Sophia answered, the lizard jumped.

Straight to the wall.

And ran away.

Thuraya screamed and ran.

The girls laughed so much they almost fell.

Sophia said, “Okay... maybe not so beautiful.”

At Al-Mu'allim Hamad's House

The house was simple, clean, and calm.

They sat on mats.

Water was brought.

Thuraya whispered, "First... wash hands."

Everyone went to wash their hands.

John washed his hands three times.

"Just in case," he said.

They came back and sat.

Sophia whispered, "Back straight. Legs in. Don't touch food yet."

Mansoor was already touching food.

John pulled his hand back. "No."

Mansoor whispered, "But I am hungry."

Then Al-Mu'allim Hamad came in.

A calm man. White beard. Kind eyes.

"Welcome," he said.

Everyone answered together, "Welcome."

He smiled. "Today, you are our guests. And guests must be honored."

Food came.

Rice. Meat. Bread. Dates.

Sophia looked amazed. "So beautiful..."

Before eating, Thuraya said softly, "We say bismillah."

John heard the word.

He repeated it quietly. “Bismillah...”

They ate.

Slowly.

Politely.

At first.

Then John forgot etiquette.

Then he forgot the world.

He ate.

And ate.

And ate.

Fatkat whispered to Sophia, “He eat like he never see food before.”

After lunch, tea came.

They sat.

Al-Mu’allim Hamad talked about life, kindness, and respect.

John listened.

He did not understand everything, but he felt something... peaceful.

On the way back, John was very quiet.

Sophia looked at him. “Are you okay?”

John touched his stomach. “My stomach is very okay.”

Then he said slowly, “But... today was... different.”

Thuraya looked at him. “Different how?”

John thought. “The way... he lives. The way... he talks. The calm. The respect. The prayer...”

He stopped.

Sophia looked at him.

John said quietly, “I think... I want to learn more about Islam.”

Thuraya did not smile.

She did not joke.

She just said softly, “When you are ready... I will explain.”

At Home

John entered the house.

He tried to sit.

He failed.

He fell on the mat.

“My stomach... is now... a separate country.”

Sophia laughed. “You should not eat like that.”

John closed his eyes. “But we should accept hospitality.”

She threw a pillow at him.

📖 Story 35 (Samail, 1973)

Title: “*I Am Afraid of...*”

Target Language:

- I am afraid of ...
 - Insects vocabulary
 - He is afraid of ... / She is afraid of ...
-

📖 Story 35

“I Am Afraid of...”

The fan was making its usual tired sound.

The classroom was hot.

The chalk was squeaking.

And John was already sweating before the lesson even started.

Sophia stood near the board, holding a small paper and smiling.

“Today,” she said happily, “we will talk about **fear**.”

The students looked at each other.

Mansoor immediately said, “I am not afraid of anything.”

Khalil whispered, “Liar.”

John wrote on the board:

I am afraid of ...

He turned. “Repeat, everyone.”

The class said together: “I am afraid of...”

Sophia clapped. “Good! Now we will learn insect words.”

She drew small bad pictures on the board.

A bee. A grasshopper. A butterfly. A lizard.

Mansoor shouted, “This one looks like Ali!”

Ali threw chalk at him.

The Confession Game

Sophia said, “Okay. One by one. You say your name and what you are afraid of.”

She pointed at Noura.

Noura stood up and said shyly, “I am afraid of... bee.”

John smiled. “Good! Say: I am afraid of **bees**.”

Noura repeated. “I am afraid of bees.”

Khalil said proudly, “I am afraid of nothing.”

At that moment, a fly passed near his ear.

He screamed.

The class exploded with laughter.

Ali said, “I am afraid of... snake.”

Ahmed said seriously, “I am afraid of... failing exam.”

Everyone respected that.

Then Mansoor stood up, smiling like a hero.

“I am afraid of... butterfly.”

The class went silent.

Then BOOM.

Laughter.

“Butterfly???” Khalil shouted. “You fight boys but afraid of butterfly?”

Mansoor shouted, “They fly... without warning!”

John wrote on the board:

Mansoor is afraid of butterflies.

Mansoor crossed his arms. “They are dangerous.”

Sophia’s Turn

Sophia smiled. “Okay. My turn. I am afraid of... grasshoppers.”

The students looked at her in shock.

“You eat it,” Khalil said.

Sophia made a face. “Yes. But I don’t want to **meet** it alive.”

Fatkat, passing by the door, said, “Normal. I am afraid of rats.”

Then John said proudly, “I am afraid of... nothing.”

Thuraya looked at him. “Really?”

John nodded. “I am a brave man.”

At that moment, Malood jumped inside the class.

Straight to John.

John jumped on the table.

“I am afraid of goats!” he shouted.

The class died laughing.

Sophia wrote:

Mr. John is afraid of Malood.

Thuraya’s Secret

Sophia looked at Thuraya. “And you?”

Thuraya answered fast, “I am not afraid of anything.”

Too fast.

John looked at her suspiciously.

“Really?”

She nodded. “Really.”

But her eyes moved to the window.

John followed her eyes.

On the wall outside...

A small **lizard** was sitting quietly.

John smiled.

A dangerous smile.

“Ohhh,” he said. “Interesting...”

He walked outside.

The students watched like they were watching a movie.

He came back holding a small box.

“Thuraya,” he said sweetly, “I have something for you.”

Thuraya stepped back. “No.”

John opened the box.

The lizard jumped out.

Thuraya screamed.

A real scream.

She ran.

The girls screamed.

Sophia screamed.

Mansoor climbed on the desk.

The lizard ran.

The class became a war zone.

Thuraya shouted, “JOHN!”

John laughed so much he couldn’t breathe.

“I am afraid of nothing,” he said, “but **you** are afraid of lizards!”

Thuraya pointed at him. “You will pay for this.”

Malood tried to eat the lizard.

The lizard escaped.

Order came back after ten minutes.

Sophia wrote on the board:

Ms. Thuraya is afraid of lizards.

Thuraya crossed her arms. “Delete it.”

The Big Question

When the class calmed down, Ali raised his hand.

“Teacher... what about Shayb Khalaf?”

The class became quiet.

“What is he afraid of?” Mansoor asked.

Everyone looked at the door.

John swallowed.

Sophia whispered, “Good question...”

Thuraya smiled slowly.

“No one knows,” she said.

The fan continued its tired sound.

Outside, somewhere far away...

Someone was laughing.

Story 36: “The Only Thing Shayb Khalaf Was Afraid Of”

(Samail, 1973)

The morning in Samail began before the sun fully decided to show itself.

A rooster screamed like it was late for work. Somewhere nearby, a woman clapped dough between her palms, and the sound traveled through the quiet lanes like soft drumbeats. John opened his eyes to the smell of wood smoke, warm bread, and that familiar village dust that somehow made every day feel like a new page.

Sophia, or “Safiya” as the villagers insisted on calling her, sat on the edge of the bed tying her scarf with careful patience.

“I feel like I’m dressing for a documentary,” she whispered, then smiled. “A very hot documentary.”

John rubbed his eyes. “At least documentaries have fans. We have... heat.”

A tiny hoof tapped the door.

Tap. Tap. Tap.

Sophia froze. “Please tell me that is not... him.”

The door creaked open because it was never properly closed in the first place, and Malood walked in like he owned the entire house. The baby goat looked at them with calm confidence, then marched straight to John’s shoe.

“No,” John warned, pointing. “No biting.”

Malood ignored the warning and chewed the shoelace with the seriousness of a professional worker.

Sophia sighed. “He has a mission.”

John leaned down, trying to free his shoe with dignity. Malood pulled harder. John pulled harder. The shoelace snapped.

John stared at the broken lace in his hand.

Malood stared at him.

It was a silent war.

Outside, Ms. Thuraya’s voice called, bright and practical.

“Good morning! Hurry, or the students will arrive before you.”

John stepped into the yard, still holding the dead shoelace like a defeated soldier. Thuraya stood at the gate with her chalk and her notebook. She looked ready to fight the whole world using only grammar and confidence.

Sophia walked out behind him. Malood followed, still chewing.

Thuraya’s eyes moved to Malood. “He came again?”

Sophia nodded with tired respect. “He chose us.”

John pointed at Malood. “I think he is secretly the principal.”

Thuraya laughed. “Come. Today we have something special. Morning assembly.”

John’s eyebrows rose. “Assembly? Like... lines and rules?”

Thuraya’s smile was innocent. Too innocent. “Yes. And you must be strong.”

John didn’t like the way she said *must*.

The Schoolyard

The school in 1973 did not look like the schools in John’s mind. It was simple. Chalk dust lived everywhere. The bell was not a modern bell. It was more like a sound that said, *Enough talking, start suffering quietly*.

Students arrived in groups, barefoot or wearing worn sandals, carrying small notebooks. Some carried nothing except energy and curiosity.

And then... the shouting started.

“Teacher John!”

“Teacher!”

“Safiya!”

“Miss Thuraya!”

Mansoor ran first, as usual, like his legs were powered by nonsense. He nearly crashed into John, then stopped at the last second and saluted dramatically.

John blinked. “Good morning, Mansoor.”

Mansoor grinned and yelled the only English greeting he trusted:

“HAAAAI!”

Behind him came Ali with calm eyes, Ahmed sitting upright even while walking, Khalil already laughing about something he hadn't done yet, and the girls: Matla, Noura, Rahma, Marwa, and Salimah, all watching with the curious bravery of people who had never seen a foreign teacher before this year.

Saeed stood at the far side, half-hidden near the wall, watching like a quiet shadow. He still didn't join fully, but his eyes collected every detail.

Thuraya clapped once. “Okay! Everyone, listen. Today we practice morning assembly.”

John picked up a piece of chalk and wrote large words on a small board he carried:

**LINE UP
STAND STILL
GOOD MORNING
EXERCISES
ANTHEM**

Sophia leaned closer. “You look serious.”

John whispered, “I have learned something in Oman. If you don't look serious, the village will eat you alive.”

Thuraya pointed. “First rule. Line up.”

John raised his voice. “LINE UP!”

The students looked at each other.

Ali immediately stood in a straight line like he was born as a ruler. Ahmed joined him perfectly. Matla and Noura followed. Soon, the line began to form.

Then Mansoor decided a line was boring and tried to make it into a circle.

Thuraya's eyes narrowed. “Mansoor...”

Mansoor froze, then ran back into the line like nothing happened.

John nodded proudly. “Good. You see? Discipline.”

A small group of men appeared at the corner of the yard carrying measuring tools. One held a rolled paper. Another carried a hammer. They looked like they were here to change the world one brick at a time.

Sophia pointed. “Who are they?”

Thuraya lowered her voice, sounding proud. “Workers. The school will be rebuilt. New classrooms. Better rooms. Better future. This is the new time.”

John watched them with awe. “So this is what it looks like when a country starts to grow.”

Thuraya’s face softened. “Yes. Slowly. But it will grow.”

The anthem began, sung in voices that were not perfect but were full of something bigger than music.

John stood quietly, listening, feeling like he was standing inside history.

Then his brain remembered something else.

Shayb Khalaf.

The mysterious old man.

The village’s “wizard.”

The man who had scared children without even trying.

John’s eyes narrowed.

An idea sparked like a dangerous match.

The “Fear Lesson”

Later, in class, John decided to do what teachers do best:

Turn chaos into a lesson.

He wrote on the chalkboard:

I AM AFRAID OF...
HE IS AFRAID OF...
HE IS NOT AFRAID OF...

Sophia clapped softly. “Good topic. Everyone has fears.”

Thuraya smirked. “Even you, Mr. John.”

John pretended not to hear.

He pointed at Noura. “Noura. I am afraid of...?”

Noura stood up confidently. “I am afraid of... bee.”

John corrected gently. “A bee. Good.”

Mansoor raised his hand like his arm was on fire.

John sighed. “Yes, Mansoor.”

Mansoor stood and announced proudly, “I am afraid of... butterfly.”

The room exploded.

Khalil laughed so hard he fell sideways. Ahmed tried to stay serious and failed. Even Ali’s mouth twitched.

John stared. “A butterfly?”

Mansoor nodded quickly. “Yes. It... fly... in my face. Big problem.”

Sophia wiped tears from her eyes. “That is the cutest fear I have ever heard.”

John tapped the board. “Okay. We respect all fears.”

Mansoor looked relieved.

Then John leaned forward. “Now... let’s talk about Shayb Khalaf.”

Half the class gasped.

Some students looked at the door as if Khalaf might appear just because his name was said.

John lowered his voice like a storyteller. “Is Shayb Khalaf afraid of anything?”

Silence.

Then Ali whispered, “He is not afraid.”

Khalil added softly, “He is... the fear.”

Thuraya watched John carefully. “Why you ask?”

John tried to look casual and failed. “Just... teacher curiosity.”

Sophia narrowed her eyes. She knew that face. That face meant: *John is about to do something stupid but educational.*

Dukkan Al-Hallah

After school, John walked to Dukkan Al-Hallah, determined to collect information like a detective.

Sophia and Thuraya followed, suspicious.

Inside, the shop smelled like dried fish, spices, and childhood. Sadu stood behind the counter, half-selling and half-arguing with a boy who wanted something for free.

Sadu spotted John and grinned. “Jooohen! You come! You want what?”

John leaned on the counter. “Sadu. I need village information.”

Sadu’s eyes lit up. He loved information. Especially dramatic information.

Before Sadu could speak, an old man entered slowly, carrying a small bag. His beard was white and his eyes were bright like they still had mischief in them.

Sadu whispered, “That is Shayb Zahran.”

John turned politely. “Hello, sir.”

Zahran looked at him and smiled slowly. “Hello, teacher.”

John blinked. “You speak English.”

Zahran shrugged. “Little. Life teach.”

John leaned closer. “Sir... can I ask something?”

Zahran’s smile widened. “You want ask about Khalaf.”

Sophia’s head snapped toward John. “John!”

Thuraya’s eyebrows lifted. “Mr. John...”

John pretended this was totally normal. “Yes. About Khalaf.”

Zahran lowered his voice, enjoying himself. “People think he fear nothing.”

John nodded eagerly. “Yes!”

Zahran pointed one finger up like a lecturer. “Wrong.”

John’s eyes widened. “He is afraid?”

Zahran’s smile turned wicked. “He was afraid of one thing.”

Sophia leaned in. Even Thuraya stopped breathing for a moment.

Zahran whispered like it was a secret that could burn the air:

“His wife.”

John blinked. “His wife?”

Zahran nodded seriously. “Name... M.نوره.”

The moment Zahran said the name, the shop felt colder for half a second, as if the air itself remembered it.

John swallowed. “And... what happens if you say her name?”

Zahran chuckled. “He change. He shake. He... fly.”

Sophia whispered, “This is too good.”

Thuraya looked at John, already knowing the disaster coming.

John straightened up, eyes shining. “Thank you, sir. Very helpful.”

Thuraya grabbed his sleeve. “No. Absolutely no.”

John smiled innocently. “I’m just... practicing English.”

Sophia muttered, “Liar.”

The House of Clay

The sun was dropping when John reached the path to Khalaf’s clay house.

Sophia and Thuraya followed at a distance, whispering:

“He will do it.”

“He will definitely do it.”

“He will die.”

Malood followed too, because Malood followed everything interesting.

John stood at the door. His heart beat fast.

He raised his hand, ready to knock.

Then he remembered... fear lesson.

He whispered to himself in English, “He is not afraid of... anything.”

He pushed the door open dramatically.

The wooden door swung wide.

John stepped in and shouted, “M—نووو!”

He stopped.

His voice died in his throat.

The house was silent.

Too silent.

The walking stick was on the ground.

The coffee pot, the dallah, was tipped over, and the dark coffee had spread like a stain across the earth floor.

John’s mouth went dry.

Sophia appeared behind him, her face suddenly serious. “John...”

Thuraya stepped in slowly, her laughter completely gone. She looked around once, then whispered, “No...”

Malood made a small nervous sound.

From outside, the wind moved through the palm fronds like a quiet warning.

John swallowed and spoke softly, no jokes now.

“He was here...”

Thuraya’s eyes fixed on the spilled coffee, and for the first time, John saw real worry in her face.

Then, far away, from the village road, a child’s voice called:

“Teacher John!”

The sound snapped the moment like a thread.

But the house stayed quiet.

And the coffee stayed spilled.

And the stick stayed on the floor.

John backed out slowly, his mind racing.

Sophia whispered, “Where is he?”

Thuraya didn’t answer. She stared at the doorway like the village itself had just changed shape.

John looked at the dark stain again, then at Thuraya.

In a low voice, he said:

“Tomorrow... we must find out.”

Thuraya finally spoke, very quietly:

“Yes.”

And somewhere behind them, Malood chewed a leaf like nothing in the world was wrong.

But for once... Malood looked uncertain.

End of Story 36.

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Story 37

“A Son from Bahrain”

That morning, Samail felt different.

The air was softer. The sun was kinder. Even the palm trees looked like they were waiting for something.

John noticed it before anyone else.

He stood at the door of the small house, holding his notebook, and said quietly, “Today feels like... something is coming.”

Sophia, tying her scarf, smiled. “In Oman, something is always coming. Usually heat.”

Thuraya walked in from the path, holding her bag, her face thoughtful.

“Not heat today,” she said. “News.”

John looked at her. “Good news or village-news?”

Thuraya smiled. “Both.”

They walked together toward the school. Malood followed, of course, like a loyal cloud with legs.

The students were already there, sitting under the palm tree, not running, not shouting.

Ali was quiet.

Ahmed was quiet.

Even Mansoor was quiet.

Something was definitely wrong.

Thuraya clapped her hands. “Why are you all sitting like this?”

Khalil answered softly, “We are waiting.”

“Waiting for what?” Sophia asked.

Saeed, who usually stayed at the back, stepped forward.

“For Obaid,” he said.

John frowned. “Who is Obaid?”

Thuraya’s face changed. Softer. Warmer.

“Obaid is Shayb Khalaf’s son.”

Sophia gasped. “He has a son?”

Thuraya nodded. “He left years ago. To Bahrain. To work. No one thought he would come back.”

John felt something move in his chest. “And now?”

Thuraya smiled. “Now he is coming.”

The Return

The sound came first.

A car.

Not the pickup of Uncle Nasser.

Not a donkey.

A real car.

Dust rose at the end of the road.

The students stood up like one body.

Then they saw him.

A man in clean clothes, carrying two bags, walking fast, his eyes searching.

“Baba!” someone shouted.

Shayb Khalaf came out of his clay house slowly, his stick in his hand.

He stopped.

He looked.

The stick fell.

For a second, the village stopped breathing.

Then Obaid ran.

He didn't walk.

He didn't think.

He ran and hugged the old man so hard that Khalaf almost fell.

"Baba," Obaid said, his voice breaking. "I am back."

Shayb Khalaf did not speak.

He just held him.

And held him.

And held him.

Some of the women wiped their eyes.

Sophia's eyes were full.

John swallowed.

Thuraya whispered, "He waited many years."

Even Malood was quiet.

Gifts and Stories

Later, Obaid came to the school with his father.

He brought small gifts for the children.

Simple things.

But precious.

For each child, a smile.

For each smile, a memory.

John shook Obaid's hand. "Welcome back."

Obaid smiled. "Thank you, teacher."

Sophia asked, "What do you do in Bahrain?"

Obaid's eyes shone. "I work with herbs. Medicine. Old knowledge."

He showed them small bags.

"This is for stomach."

"This for headache."

"This for sleep."

Thuraya nodded. "Your grandfather used to do this."

Obaid smiled sadly. "Yes. And my mother..."

He stopped.

No one spoke.

Shayb Khalaf looked away.

The Truth Comes Out

That afternoon, John went to Dukkan Al-Hallah.

He found Sadu laughing.

Too much laughing.

"What?" John asked.

Sadu almost fell from the bench. "You! You and 'Manooh'!"

John froze. "What?"

Sadu wiped his eyes. "Zahran. He is crazy. Manooh is his wife, not Khalaf's!"

John's mouth opened.

“Zahran mixes names. He forgets. He tells stories. Everyone knows.”

John whispered, “So... Shayb Khalaf was never afraid of Manooh?”

Sadu laughed harder. “No. He is afraid of nothing.”

John closed his eyes.

Slowly.

Very slowly.

The Big Embarrassment

In the evening, John walked to Shayb Khalaf’s house.

He stood straight.

He cleared his throat.

Khalaf looked at him. “You were coming yesterday?”

John nodded. “Yes. I wanted to say something.”

Khalaf leaned on his stick. “Say.”

John took a deep breath.

“I wanted to say... Man—”

He stopped.

He waited.

Nothing happened.

No shaking.

No flying.

No fear.

Khalaf raised an eyebrow. “Say what?”

John tried again. “I wanted to say... M—”

Suddenly:

WHACK.

The stick hit John’s back.

“أنا أخاف منوره نوبه؟” Khalaf shouted. “!عجب”

John jumped. “OW!”

Khalaf growled. “You think I am stupid?”

John’s face turned red.

Then Khalaf added calmly, “Zahran is crazy.”

John looked at the ground.

Very interested in the ground.

The Legendary Chase

From behind the house, Sadu appeared laughing like a drum.

“I told you! I told you!”

John saw the stick in Khalaf’s hand.

Bad idea.

Very bad idea.

He grabbed it and ran.

“HEY!” Khalaf shouted and ran after him.

Malood saw running and decided this is a game.

He ran too.

The children saw running and joined.

Soon the whole village saw:

Sadu running.

Behind him John.

Behind him Khalaf.

Behind him Malood.

Behind him the children.

Someone shouted, “It’s a festival!”

End

That night, John sat at home, rubbing his back.

Sophia looked at him. “So... what did we learn today?”

John sighed. “Never trust village gossip.”

Thuraya smiled. “And?”

John thought.

Then said softly, “Some people wait years for love.”

Outside, Shayb Khalaf’s house had light again.

And for the first time...

The village slept peacefully.

Story 38

“Then and Now”

(A Trip to Jibreen Castle – Samail, 1973)

The road to Jibreen Castle was long, dusty, and full of quiet excitement.

The pickup of Uncle Nasser moved slowly between palm trees and open land. The children sat in the back, holding their bags, their notebooks, and their small dreams. John sat in front, looking at the horizon like a man about to meet history. Sophia sat beside him, her camera resting on her lap. Thuraya sat behind them, explaining the plan again and again because teachers never trust that students really listen.

And with them this time was Obaid.

Not as a visitor.

Not as a guest.

But as a **guide**.

He stood in the back of the pickup, holding the side with one hand and pointing at the land with the other.

“There,” he said, “that road did not exist before.”

John turned. “So... how did people travel?”

Obaid smiled. “On animals. On feet. Slowly. Very slowly.”

Mansoor opened his eyes wide. “Even to Nizwa?”

Obaid nodded. “Especially to Nizwa.”

The children looked at each other like they were trying to imagine a world without roads.

Sophia whispered to Thuraya, “It’s strange. We are living inside a story.”

Thuraya smiled. “Yes. And today, we will teach them how to tell it.”

The Castle

Jibreen Castle appeared like something from a dream.

Tall.

Strong.

Quiet.

Its walls looked like they were holding secrets.

Ali stood very still. “It looks like a king’s house.”

Obaid nodded. “It was.”

They entered slowly.

Their footsteps echoed.

Obaid spoke in a calm, respectful voice.

“Long time ago, people **lived** here. They **studied** here. They **fought** here. They **planned** here.”

John wrote some words in his notebook:

lived – studied – fought – planned

Sophia whispered to the students, “Repeat after me: *They lived here.*”

“They lived here,” the class said together.

Obaid continued. “In the past, Oman **did not have** schools like today. People **learned** in mosques and houses. They **used** oil lamps, not electricity.”

Thuraya added gently, “And water... they **used** falaj. No pipes.”

John turned to the students and wrote on a small board he carried:

In the past, they used to...

Now, we...

He pointed at Ali. “Ali. In the past, they used to...?”

Ali thought. “They used to... walk... long.”

John smiled. “Good! They used to walk long distances.”

Ahmed added, “Now, we... use car.”

Sophia clapped. “Excellent!”

Mansoor raised his hand. “In the past, they used to... no fan.”

The class laughed.

Thuraya nodded. “True. No fan. Only patience.”

They walked from room to room.

Obaid showed them the ceilings, the small windows, the secret passages.

“In the past,” he said, “people **protected** their families here. Now, we protect history.”

John felt something heavy and beautiful in his chest.

He looked at Thuraya. “Your country has strong roots.”

She answered quietly, “And now... it is growing.”

Past and Future

They sat in the shade near the castle wall.

Sophia took out colors and papers.

“Now,” she said, “you draw.”

The students looked at her. “Draw?”

“Yes,” she smiled. “Draw the castle. Or what you feel.”

Thuraya added, “And write one sentence.”

John wrote on a big paper:

In the past...

Now...

In the future, I will...

Ali sat very quietly.

Very focused.

His hand moved slowly.

Carefully.

John passed by and stopped.

He leaned down.

Did not speak.

Just watched.

Ali was not drawing only the castle.

He was drawing **the castle, the land, and a big flag above it.**

The lines were confident.

The colors were strong.

Sophia came and froze.

She whispered, “Thuraya...”

Thuraya looked.

And smiled in surprise.

“He has talent,” she said softly.

Ali wrote under his drawing, slowly:

In the past, Oman was strong.

Now, Oman is growing.

In the future, I will help my country.

Sophia felt her eyes burn.

She lifted the drawing and showed it to John.

He looked at it for a long time.

Then he said quietly, “Ali... you are an artist.”

Ali looked down, shy.

Mansoor’s drawing was... a castle with five suns and two goats.

Malood walked over and tried to eat the corner.

The Lesson

Before leaving, John stood and said, “Okay. Let’s speak.”

He pointed to Noura. “One sentence.”

Noura said, “In the past, they used to... live in castle.”

John nodded. “Good.”

Khalil said, “Now, we have... school.”

Ahmed said, “In the future, I will... be teacher.”

Saeed, from the back, said quietly, “In the future, I will... learn more.”

Thuraya looked at him.

And smiled.

The Flag

On the way back, the sun was lower.

The castle stayed behind them like a memory.

Sophia held Ali’s drawing on her lap.

She said softly, “Sometimes... a lesson is not in the book.”

John nodded. “Sometimes, it’s in a child.”

Thuraya looked at the road ahead.

“And sometimes,” she said, “it is in a country.”

The pickup moved forward.

And history moved with it.

“The Month When Everything Changed”

(Ramadan in Samail, 1973)

The first sound came before the light.

It was not the sun that woke Samail.

It was the **adhan**.

The voice floated from far away, soft and strong at the same time, moving between the mountains, over the palm trees, into the houses, into the hearts.

John opened his eyes slowly.

“What... is that?” he whispered.

Sophia was already awake. She was sitting on the edge of the bed, listening.

“It’s beautiful,” she said. “It sounds like... the sky is speaking.”

Outside, the village was different.

Quieter.

Kinder.

Like it was holding its breath.

Thuraya walked past their house, her steps light, her face calm. She carried a small bag of dates and bread. She stopped, looked at the sky, and whispered a short prayer before continuing her way.

That day, **no children came to school**.

No noise.

No running.

No shouting.

Even Sadoo’s shop was closed.

A wooden sign hung on the door:

Closed for Ramadan.

Mansoor passed by slowly, his face tired but proud.

“I am fasting,” he said to Malood, who was trying to eat a leaf. “You... you don’t understand religion.”

Malood ate the leaf.

The Smell of Ramadan

By afternoon, something strange happened.

The village started to **smell different**.

From one house: fried onions.

From another: bread.

From another: spices, soup, meat.

Plates moved from door to door.

Women walked in groups, carrying food, laughing quietly.

Sophia stood at the window.

“The food... it’s travelling,” she said.

John laughed. “Like a food parade.”

But the sun was still high.

And nobody was eating.

John looked at his watch. “So... they don’t eat. They don’t drink. All day?”

Thuraya, who had just come to check on them, nodded. “From dawn to sunset.”

Sophia blinked. “Even water?”

“Yes.”

John sat slowly. “That is... serious.”

Sophia smiled. “We read about this. In books. Remember?”

John nodded. “That was... one of the reasons we wanted to come here.”

They stayed quiet for a moment.

Then Sophia said, suddenly, “Let’s try.”

John turned slowly. “Try what?”

“Fasting.”

He stared at her. “Are you... serious?”

She smiled. “Come on. One day.”

The Longest Day

By ten in the morning, John was already dramatic.

“I think... my mouth is becoming a desert.”

Sophia looked at him. “Stop it.”

By twelve, he was lying on the floor.

“I can hear... water calling me.”

Sophia sat beside him. “Drama queen.”

By two, he tried to stand up and failed.

“I see... light.”

Sophia laughed. “That’s the fan.”

Malood came, looked at him, and stepped over his leg.

By four, John was on the floor again.

“I am not built for this.”

Sophia sat cross-legged. “You wanted to understand the culture. Congratulations.”

Then... **knock knock.**

The door opened.

Thuraya stood there with a big tray.

“I brought you iftar,” she said.

John tried to sit. “But... we are not fasting.”

Thuraya smiled. “I know. But you should taste Ramadan.”

She put the tray down.

Dates.

Soup.

Bread.

Samosas.

Rice.

Sophia looked at the food. Then at Thuraya. Then at John.

Then she laughed.

“Look at us. Not fasting. And dying.”

Thuraya looked at them both and laughed.

“Poor you. One day only, and you almost die.”

She looked at John seriously and said in Arabic, smiling:

“صيام بدون صلاة؟”

Then she laughed again.

Something Is Changing

Days passed.

Ramadan continued.

John and Sophia started... **disappearing** in the afternoons.

They left quietly.

They came back quietly.

The children noticed.

Mansoor whispered, "They go to the teacher's house."

Khalil said, "Every day."

Noura said, "Why?"

They tried to follow them.

But Shayb Khalaf appeared like a wall.

He stood in the road, holding his stick.

"Any one follow them," he said, "this bamboo talks."

He looked at Thuraya. "First you, Thraywa."

Thuraya crossed her arms. "You like drama."

He did not move.

They turned back.

The Secret

Half of Ramadan passed.

One evening, the adhan was different.

Stronger.

Closer.

John and Sophia walked with Thuraya.

Not to their house.

Not to the teacher's house.

To the mosque.

The village noticed.

People stopped.

Looked.

Whispered.

That night, after iftar, Shayb Khalaf opened his house.

He did something nobody expected.

He made a **big table**.

For everyone.

Rice.

Meat.

Bread.

Dates.

Tea.

He stood and said, simply:

“Today... we celebrate.”

John stood.

His voice was not strong.

But it was clear.

“I came to Oman to teach English,” he said. “But Oman taught me... something bigger.”

Sophia held his hand.

“We did not come only for work,” she said. “We came because we were... searching.”

John looked at Thuraya.

“At your people. Your life. Your faith.”

He took a breath.

“Today... we say it clearly.”

They looked at each other.

And said:

“We are Muslims.”

For a second, nobody spoke.

Then... the village exploded.

Smiles.

Tears.

Voices.

Mansoor shouted, “Teacher John is one of us!”

Malood jumped on the table.

Shayb Khalaf wiped his eyes with his sleeve and said, “Late... but good.”

The Night of Light

They ate together.

They laughed.

They talked.

Sophia tasted everything and said, “This is dangerous. I will never be thin again.”

John looked at the people praying.

Quiet.

Peaceful.

And said softly, “I think... this is home.”

Thuraya looked at them.

And said nothing.

Because some moments... do not need words.

The End of the Night

Later, at home, John lay on the floor.

Full.

Happy.

Sophia looked at him.

“You survived fasting. You survived food. Congratulations.”

He smiled.

“This... was the month that changed everything.”

Outside, the adhan for night prayer rose again.

And Samail slept.

Different.

Final Note

This was not a lesson about grammar.

It was a lesson about **hearts**.

!

★ Story 40

“The Day the Palm Tree Witnessed Everything”

(Samail, 1976 → 2026)

The classroom was not noisy that morning.

It was... **nervous**.

Even Mansoor was quiet.

The old fan turned slowly. The chalkboard was clean. The desks were too straight, like they were also waiting.

“Today... exams,” John said, trying to sound calm.

Sophia smiled. “Don’t look at me like I am the judge.”

Thuraya walked between the desks. “Just do your best. That’s all.”

The papers were given.

Silence fell like a blanket.

Ahmed wrote like a machine.

Ali stopped sometimes, looked up, then continued.

Noura whispered the question to herself.

Khalil bit his pencil.

Mansoor stared at the paper like it was an enemy.

Malood slept near the door.

The Longest Week

The week of correction was... dangerous.

John was tired.

Sophia was tired.

Thuraya was pretending she was not nervous.

At night, they corrected papers in the small house.

“Look at Ali,” Sophia said. “His writing improved so much.”

“And Ahmed,” John said. “Perfect grammar.”

“And Mansoor...” Thuraya laughed. “At least he wrote something.”

Results Day

The children stood in lines under the palm tree.

The same palm tree.

The one that saw everything.

John held the paper.

Sophia held her breath.

Thuraya smiled like a mother.

“Ahmed,” John said. “Excellent.”

Ahmed stood straight like a soldier.

“Ali,” Sophia said. “Excellent.”

Ali’s eyes shined.

“Noura... Very good.”

“Mithla... Very good.”

“Salima... Good.”

“Marwa... Good.”

“Rahma... Good.”

Then...

“Mansoor...”

He closed his eyes.

“...Passed.”

The village heard his scream before the mountains did.

Graduation Day

The school was decorated with simple cloth and palm leaves.

Mothers brought food.

Fathers came with proud faces.

Even Sadoo closed his shop early.

Shayb Khalaf sat in the front, holding his stick like a medal.

The children stood in a line.

They sang.

They laughed.

They received small certificates.

Sophia cried.

John pretended not to cry.

Thuraya cried openly.

When it ended, John looked at the children and said:

“You came here not knowing even one word. Now... you can speak. You can read. You can dream.”

The Goodbye That Was Not a Goodbye

That evening, they sat under the palm tree.

The same one.

Malood jumped between them.

The sun went down slowly.

Sophia said quietly: “Do you remember our first day here?”

John smiled. “I fell in the smoke.”

They laughed.

Thuraya looked at the tree. “This place... changed us all.”

Suddenly... 2026

The sound of a pen.

A notebook.

A woman sitting in her room.

Writing.

She closes the notebook slowly.

A voice from outside:

“إثريا... تعالي تغدي، الساعة صارت 2”

Thuraya answers:

“إنزين ماه... جايه”

She looks at the notebook.

On the last page:

“And this was how it all started... under the palm tree.”

She closes it.

On the cover:

123 Let's Learn English Under the Palm Tree

Fade out.

On the screen:

 *An old photo of John, Sophia, and Thuraya, standing in Samail, 1973.*

Then the words appear:

To Be Continued...

1 (John) برومبت جون

انسخي هذا النص واحفظيه

A realistic cinematic portrait of a British man in his early 30s, handsome but simple and friendly, light brown hair, short neat haircut, light stubble, warm smile, athletic build, wearing a beige long sleeve shirt with rolled sleeves and brown trousers, standing in rural Oman in the 1970s, palm trees and mud houses in background, warm sunlight, ultra realistic, high detail, natural skin, cinematic photography, 35mm lens, shallow depth of field

✦ هذا هو "قالب جون"
كل مرة تكتبي

John in the classroom

أو

John in the market

تحطي هذا الوصف وتضيفي المشهد

2 (Sophia) برومبت صوفيا

A realistic cinematic portrait of a European woman in her late 20s, blonde hair, fair skin, slim body, soft feminine face with dimples, gentle smile, light blue eyes, elegant but simple clothes, natural makeup, 1970s style, standing in rural Oman, warm sunlight, ultra realistic, high detail, cinematic photography, 35mm lens, shallow depth of field

✦ هذا قالب صوفيا الثابت

om 3 (Thuraya) برومبت ثريا

A realistic cinematic portrait of an Omani woman in her early 30s, slim body, soft oval face with dimples, confident and strong personality, wearing black abaya and hijab, sporty sneakers, warm intelligent smile, leader presence, standing in rural Oman village in the 1970s, palm trees, mud houses, warm sunlight, ultra realistic, high detail, cinematic photography, 35mm lens, shallow depth of field

✦ هذا قالب ثريا الثابت

1 الماعز الصغير – (Malood) مالود

A cute small baby goat, white fur, big innocent eyes, playful and naughty, standing in an Omani village in the 1970s, dusty ground, palm trees, ultra realistic, high detail, cinematic photography

✈ لاحقًا لما يكبر:

change "small baby goat" to "young goat" or "grown goat"

 [2] الشايب خلف (Shayb Khalaf)

مهم: دايماً أضيفي

mysterious, dramatic lighting

An old Omani man in his late 70s, thin, wrinkled face, sharp mysterious eyes, long white beard, wearing traditional Omani dishdasha and turban, holding a wooden stick, looks scary but kind, standing near a mud house under palm trees, 1970s Oman, ultra realistic, cinematic lighting, dramatic shadows

 [3] صاحب الدكان – سادو (Sadoo)

A middle-aged Omani man, short and strong body, simple village clothes, friendly funny face, big mustache, energetic and confident, looks like he can do everything, standing in a small village shop, 1970s Oman, ultra realistic, cinematic, warm colors

 [5] الطفل الهادي اللي يراقب – سعيد (Saeed)

An Omani boy around 10 years old, thin, quiet, intelligent eyes, simple village clothes, shy but curious, standing a bit far watching others, 1970s Oman village, ultra realistic, cinematic

 [6] المشاغب – منصور (Mansoor)

An Omani boy around 8 years old, short, very energetic, messy hair, naughty smile, playful eyes, always moving, simple village clothes, 1970s Oman, ultra realistic, cinematic

 [7] المرتب الذكي – أحمد (Ahmed)

An Omani boy around 11 years old, clean and neat, calm face, intelligent and serious eyes, tidy h

8 العبقري – (Ali) علي

An Omani boy around 11 years old, thoughtful face, curious intelligent eyes, slightly shy, simple clothes, looks like a future inventor, 1970s Oman village, ultra realistic, cinematic

9 صاحب المقال – (Khalil) خليل

An Omani boy around 11 years old, mischievous smile, clever eyes, always planning something, playful face, simple village clothes, 1970s Oman, ultra realistic, cinematic

10 بنت الشيخ – (Mathla) مثلى

An Omani girl around 11 years old, neat and elegant, confident and kind face, clean clothes, looks polite and generous, 1970s Oman, ultra realistic, cinematic

1 نورة

An Omani girl around 10 years old, curious eyes, always asking questions, expressive face, simple village clothes, 1970s Oman, ultra realistic, cinematic

2 رحمة

An Omani girl around 10 years old, shy and gentle, soft smile, calm eyes, simple village clothes, 1970s Oman, ultra realistic, cinematic

3 مروة

An Omani girl around 10 years old, friendly face, cheerful eyes, simple clothes, always smiling, 1970s Oman, ultra realistic, cinematic

4 سليمة

An Omani girl around 10 years old, quiet and observant, thoughtful eyes, simple clothes, 1970s Oman, ultra realistic, cinematic

4 الحمار (في السلسلة الثانية لاحقًا)

A gray donkey, funny face, stubborn and playful, standing in a village street, ultra realistic, cinematic photography

(نخليه محفوظ للمستقبل)

محمد بن (Mohammadeen) – مدرس الرياضيات المصري

A middle-aged Egyptian man, strong personality, short black hair, thick mustache, serious but kind face, wearing 1970s teacher clothes, holding a thin stick, standing in a simple Omani school classroom, ultra realistic, cinematic lighting

فتكات (Fatkat) – زوجته، مدرسة الرياضة

A middle-aged Egyptian woman, energetic, sporty body, kind but strict face, wearing 1970s sports tracksuit, confident posture, standing in a school yard, ultra realistic, cinematic photography

الرجل القاسي صاحب المال (Marhoon) – العم مرهون

An old Omani farmer in his 60s, rough face, strong build, sunburned skin, wearing traditional Omani clothes, holding a farming stick, looks strict and tough, standing near palm farm, 1970s Oman, ultra realistic, cinematic

الشايب اللي يخرف (Zahran) – زهران

An old Omani man in his 70s, thin, confused face, messy beard, worn clothes, looks lost and talks a lot, standing near a small village shop, 1970s Oman, ultra realistic, cinematic

ابن الشايب خلف العائد من البحرين (Obaid) – عبيد

An Omani man in his late 30s, educated and calm, kind eyes, short beard, wearing simple but clean clothes, looks wise and gentle, standing in a village, ultra realistic, cinematic

صاحب البيك أب (Uncle Nasser) – العم ناصر

An Omani man in his 50s, strong body, friendly face, big mustache, wearing traditional clothes, confident driver, standing next to an old pickup truck, 1970s Oman, ultra realistic, cinematic

سيارة البيك أب

An old 1970s pickup truck, dusty, simple, used in Omani villages, carrying people in the back, palm trees and mountains in background, ultra realistic, cinematic

🏠 البيت (بيت جون وصوفيا)

A simple 1970s Omani village house made of mud and stone, small yard, palm trees around, traditional wooden door, warm sunlight, ultra realistic, cinematic

🎒 المدرسة

A simple 1970s Omani village school, small building, dusty yard, Omani flag, children standing outside, palm trees around, ultra realistic, cinematic

🎒 الصف (الفصل)

A simple 1970s classroom in Oman, wooden desks, chalkboard, ceiling fan, sunlight coming from windows, children sitting, ultra realistic, cinematic

🏡 القرية (القرواشية / سمائل)

A 1970s Omani village, mud houses, palm trees, falaj water channel, mountains in the background, children playing, warm sunlight, ultra realistic, cinematic

👤 الطالب المصري – (Mostafa) مصطفى

ولد مصري عمره تقريباً 12-13 سنة، ذكي، شقي شوي، واثق من نفسه، لهجته مصرية واضحة، يحب يشارك ويتكلم كثير.

🌀 Prompt:

An Egyptian boy around 12 years old, smart and confident, short black hair, lively eyes, slim body, wearing simple 1970s school clothes, playful smile, standing in a classroom, ultra realistic, cinematic lighting

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